Local Vietnam

Vietnam travel guide



WELCOME

Dear reader,

Nice that you are planning a trip to Vietnam! Through this travel guide we share our years of experience with you and we send you well prepared for your trip.

Here you can read practical information that you need to know in preparation, as well as information during your tour, such as the best accommodations, the tastiest food, the most special sights and activities that you really should not miss, best travel time, health, safety, SIM cards and much more. In addition, you can also read travel inspiration if you are not sure where to go.

The Local Vietnam team wishes you a lot of fun during your Vietnam trip!

Nhung & Marnick



Nhung Phung



Marnick Schoonderwoerd

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ABOUT US

Nhung started her first travel blog 9 years ago and a month later she quit her office job to focus entirely on her blog. She traveled the world to 30 different countries and grew her website into one of the most famous travel blogs in Vietnam.

Marnick studied tourism in the Netherlands and worked in a resort in Costa Rica and a backpackers hostel in Australia. After visiting about 40 countries he got “stuck” in Vietnam with Nhung.

ABOUT LOCAL VIETNAM

Founders Nhung (Vietnamese) and Marnick (Dutch) started Local Vietnam as an alternative to the classic travel agencies that have been popping up everywhere since Vietnam started to gain popularity. Most travel agents in Vietnam have little knowledge about traveling, find it difficult to understand foreign tourists or only offer popular activities to crowded destinations. Travel agencies in Europe, the US and Australia do have this, but lack the specialization and connections in Vietnam.

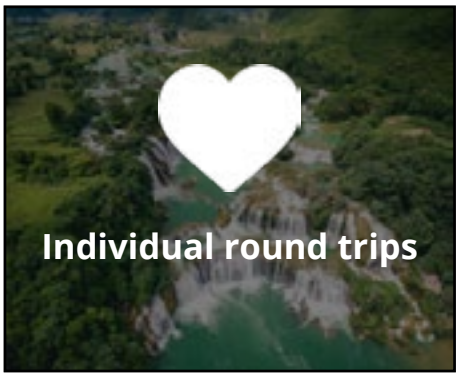
This is where Local Vietnam originated. Together we have visited more than 50 different countries and seen all 58 provinces of Vietnam. Not only does this give us incredible knowledge of our destinations, but our experience in travel helps us understand other travelers better.

With Local Vietnam, we offer carefully selected, high-quality activities and service for all destinations in Vietnam. Private or small groups, with a lot of contact with the local population, the culture and discovering the beautiful untouched nature.

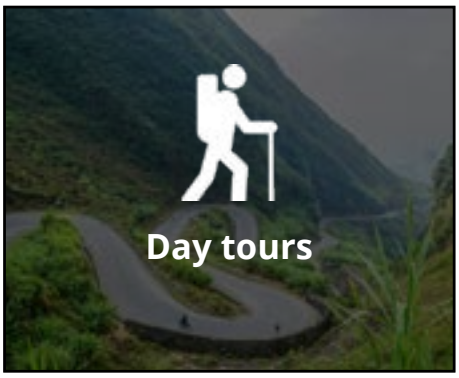
As a provider of activities, we also feel a responsibility to reduce the pressure that tourism puts on the natural and social environment of our destinations. Our mission is to bring more and more sustainability into our tours and way of working.

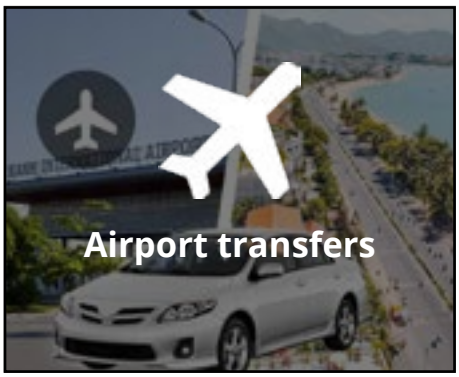
WHAT DOES LOCAL VIETNAM DO

As a local travel agency based in Vietnam, we can arrange everything without an intermediary. This allows us to act quickly and we are often a lot cheaper than travel agents outside Vietnam. From transfers to accommodations, from short day tours to complete round trips and from local guides to boat trips. We have mainly specialized in unique and local experiences - often off the beaten track and places we first explored ourselves.

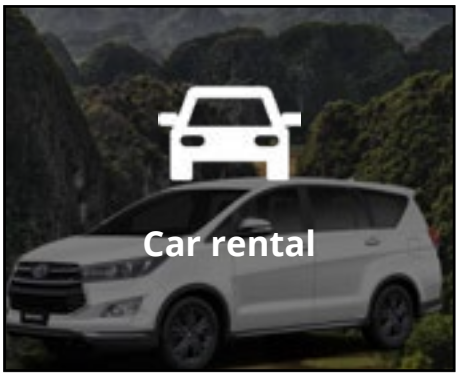












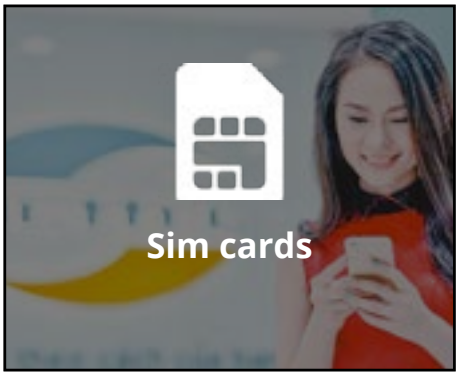


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FACTS FOR ON THE ROAD

Did you know....

1) Vietnam's coastline is 3,269 km long. That is even longer than Thailand (2,815km)?

2) Nguyen is the most popular surname in Vietnam. More than 40% of the Vietnamese population has this surname?

3) in Vietnam there are 60 million motorcycles out of a population of 95 million. This makes it the fourth highest number of motorbikes in the world?

4) Vietnam is the second largest coffee exporter in the world after Brazil?

5) Vietnam is the world's largest exporter of black pepper and cashews? The country produces nearly a third of all black pepper and even half of the world's cashews.

6) the Vietnamese language also uses the alphabet, including 5 different symbols? With this, Vietnam has 6 different tones. By changing the tone, the meaning of the word changes or it means nothing anymore.

7) Vietnam was originally spelled in 2 words: Viet Nam - a name dating back to the 16th century. Although the name came to be known as Vietnam - especially in English - the Vietnamese government and the United Nations still refer to the country as Viet Nam.

8) there is a lot of superstition about food in Vietnam? A small part of the population drinks and eats things that are rather sinister for us, such as scorpion and snake wine, dog, cat and a duck emryo. Eating and drinking this is believed to be good for vitality.

9) in Vietnam you find the largest and the third largest cave in the world? The Son Doong cave is so big that a Boeing 747 can fly through the largest entrance. The cave is big enough for a 40-storey skyscraper and is so huge that it even has its own climate and clouds can form in it.

10) The Vietnamese flag has a meaning consisting of a gold star with five points, the different points represent farmers, workers, intellectuals, youth and soldiers. The red background is a tribute to the bloodshed during the wars.

11) Vietnam has the cheapest beer in the world? Bia Hoi can only be found at street vendors, especially in the north and is already available from 0.25 cents per glass.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Vietnam is one of the most beautiful countries in Southeast Asia, drawing travelers to its lush mountains, bustling cities and golden sandy beaches. Despite rapid modernization in Vietnam's urban centers such as Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City, time-honored traditions remain intact among the locals. There are numerous ancient monuments and colonial structures that have survived its eventful history.

Buddhist shrines can be found next to towering skyscrapers, where you can experience vibrant festivals and ceremonies dating back hundreds of years. Long sandy beaches are home to luxury resorts and gastronomic locations, making them ideal romantic getaways, while sprawling rice terraces on the hills lend themselves to hiking trips. Whether you're planning a historical tour, a relaxing beach vacation, or simply or actively exploring the country, this Vietnam travel guide caters to almost any vacation preference.

COUNTRY INFORMATION

Language
Vietnamese

Capital city
Hanoi

Biggest city
Ho Chi Minh City

Population
96,208,984

Size
332,698 km2

Religion
73.2% Folk or Irreligious
12.2% Buddhist
8.3% Christian

Country code
+84

Time difference
+5 in summer time
+6 in winter time
(UTC + 7)

Driving on
Right side of the road

Money
Vietnamese Dong (₫) (VND)

State form
People's Republic

Ethnic groups
Vietnamese 85%
53 minorities (15%)

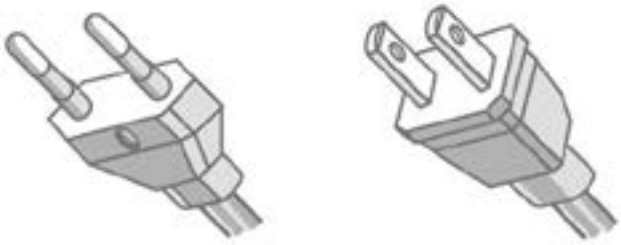
Climate
Tropical

Visa
Visa required

ELECTRICITY

The standard household (hotel) power supply in Vietnam is 220 volts, 50 Hertz.

Power outlets in Vietnam usually accept two-pin plugs; flat and round plugs are both possible.



VISA

OPTIONS

Before you travel to Vietnam you must already be in possession of a valid visa, e-visa or letter of authorization for a visa on arrival.

You can get this in 3 different ways:

- **Visa** – through any Vietnamese embassy
- **E-visa** – online through the official website of the Vietnamese Immigration Service
- **Visa on Arrival** – through a local travel agency such as Local Vietnam

	Visa through embassy	**Online e-visa**	**Visa on Arrival**
Validity	1 month or 3 months	1 month	1 month or 3 months
Border crossing	Airports, ports and land borders	Airports, ports and land borders	Airports
Cost	$ 70,00 - $ 110,00	$ 25,00	From $ 20 for letter of authorization + $ 25 for single entry or $ 50 for multiple entry on arrival.
Application	At the embassy or via a visa agency that does this for you	Online	Online
Processing time	1 working day (if you visit yourself)	3 working days	1 hour - 3 working days

- If you are going to Vietnam for less than 30 days, choose an e-visa.
- If you are going to Vietnam for more than 30 days, choose a visa on arrival (keep in mind that you have to enter the country via international airport.

VISA ON ARRIVAL

With a visa on arrival, you request an online authorization letter in advance. You can apply here a VOA authorization letter on localvietnam.com. Local Vietnam is a local company based in Vietnam. This allows us to arrange the visa ourselves directly with the immigration service, without other parties and therefore avoids high costs incurred by companies outside Vietnam. This allows us to offer the authorization letters for a much cheaper price. With this authorization letter you can obtain a visa on arrival through the immigration counter on arrival at the airport before going through immigration.

E-VISA

The E-visa is an electronic visa that can only be issued by the Vietnamese immigration service. This can only be obtained through the official website of the Vietnamese Immigration Service.

Important: (1) Many online visa agencies also refer to a Visa on Arrival as an E-Visa. Although you also apply for this online, this is not the same. For a Visa on Arrival you will receive an authorization letter that you use on arrival to collect your visa. This is not the same as an E-Visa.
(2) The cheapest you can apply for an e-visa directly via the official website of the Vietnamese Immigration Service. You do not need a visa agency for this. This is the official website from the Vietnamese Immigration Service to apply for an e-visa.

VISA THROUGH THE EMBASSY

It is possible to arrange a visa at the embassy. You can do this at the Vietnam embassy in the country where you live, but also at any Vietnamese embassy in the world; so even when you are in Cambodia for example. You can also choose the service of a visa agency, so you don't have to go to the embassy.

ARRIVAL IN VIETNAM

If you have an e-visa or a visa through the embassy, you can go straight through customs.
If you have a visa on arrival, you must first go to the immigration desk to get your visa with the following documents:

- Authorization letter
- The application form (completed)
- Passport photograph
- Valid passport
- $ 25 for Single Entry or $ 50 for Multiple Entry Visa (recommended to pay with US Dollars)

When the visa is in your passport, you can go through customs and collect your luggage.
Do not forget to print the authorization letter, because airlines will not let you check in without this letter.

FLYING TO VIETNAM

Direct flights

Not all major cities in Europe and the US have direct flights to Vietnam. Below is a list of airports with direct flights to Vietnam. There are many destinations with direct flights from Asia.

EUROPE
- Paris
- Frankfurt
- London

US
- Los Angeles
- San Francisco

AUSTRALIA
- Sydney
- Canberra
- Melbourne

Tips for booking cheap tickets

- Ho Chi Minh City or Hanoi? See which airport is the cheapest.
- Try to be flexible with your travel date and times.
- Use different search engines: Momondo, Google Flights, Skyscanner.
- Search ticket prices as one person: Airlines always show the highest ticket price for a group of tickets.
- Book your flight ticket on time, but not too early: 6-8 weeks before departure or about three months in advance if you are flying to Vietnam during the high season.
- Set a price alarm: Handy feature of Skyscanner: If you want to fly to Ho Chi Minh City, choose the option “Set price alarm”. You will receive an email regarding price changes of the flight ticket.

International airports in Vietnam

- Hanoi: Nội Bài International Airport
- Ho Chi Minh: Tân Sơn Nhất International Airport
- Da Nang: Đà Nẵng International Airport
- Nha Trang: Cam Ranh International Airport
- Phú Quốc: Phú Quốc International Airport
- Hai Phong: Cát Bi International Airport

Hanoi or Ho Chi Minh City?

A majority of travelers seem to start in the south by flying to Ho Chi Minh first. Flight prices are often cheaper to Ho Chi Minh City. In addition, this city offers a somewhat “softer” landing culturally for first-timers in Vietnam, according to many. This can of course be a good or bad thing depending on your point of view.

Flying from Asia to Vietnam

Regional air connections from Asia to Vietnam are getting better. You can fly from many cities in Cambodia, Laos, Malaysia and Thailand and there are plenty of options from South Korea, Japan and China too. Budget options are increasing every year: from Singapore you can choose from Jetstar, Scoot, Silk Air and Vietjet Air, and from Bangkok you can take AirAsia, Jetstar, Lion Air, Nok Air or Vietjet. There are also plenty of options from Kuala Lumpur.

FROM AIRPORT TO CITY

From Noi Bat to Hanoi

Taxi – Taxi stands can be reached outside the Noi Bai arrival terminals on the first island past the arrival hall to find the taxi queue. You may be approached by "helpful" people in the terminal asking if you need a taxi, but don't accept it. Airport taxis charge a flat rate of approximately 18 USD.

Airport transfer – If you prefer to book your airport pick-up and drop-off service in advance, for a fixed price, then this is possible via Local Vietnam. Boek vliegveld transfer hier

Hotel shuttle - Some hotels offer pick up from the airport. An alternative is to rent a car with a driver to pick you up and take you to the center

Bus - Bus 86 connects the arrivals from the airport directly to the stops in Hanoi city. The bus ride takes about an hour to arrive at the bus station and costs VND 5,000 (approximately $ 0.30) per ride. This yellow-orange bus follows a route from the airport, down through Hoan Kiem Lake and Hanoi's Old Quarter, and ends at Hanoi Central Station.

Airport shuttle bus - There are several shuttle buses from the airport to the center of Hanoi. Vietnam Airlines minibuses depart every 30-40 minutes from arrival at Terminal 1. Tickets cost VND 40,000 (approximately 2 USD) each way. This shuttle bus also runs from the city center to the airport in Hanoi from the Vietnam Airlines booking office (01, Quang Trung street).

From Tan Son to Ho Chi Minh City

Taxi - You can get a taxi coupon at the airport at the taxi counter. You will then be assigned to a driver. Opt for a reliable taxi such as Mai Linh or Vinasun.

Bus - Many backpackers take the bus (No. 152) which will take you for 20,000 VND (incl. Backpack supplement) to the bus stop on Pham Ngu Lao Street, which is at the roundabout on Ben Thanh Market. There is another bus (nr. 49) and costs 40,000vnđ that also stops on Pham Ngu Lao street, this bus does not have many stops so it arrives in District 1 faster than other buses.

Airport transfer – If you prefer to book your airport pick-up and drop-off service in advance, for a fixed price, then this is possible via Local Vietnam. Boek vliegveld transfer hier

COMMUNICATION

SIM Card



We recommend Viettel for most travelers. There are shops on almost every street corner that sell SIM cards, including small supermarkets. But officially SIM cards must be registered with passport. Recommended to buy in an official store. You can also buy it at the airport. The SIM card and a 5 GB / 30 day package cost 100,000 VND (about $ 5 USD).

WiFi



In most hotels, restaurants and cafés you can get free wireless internet.

Calling



There is a mobile network in most parts of Vietnam. Before you go, ask your provider about the options and costs for mobile calling in Vietnam.

Useful apps



Make sure you have a navigation app. like Google Maps or Maps.me. Use Google translate to interact with the locals and you can even translate real-time things like a restaurant menu. Use TripAdvisor to find a nice restaurant. Grab, which is similar to Uber, is a taxi app. In addition to a car, you can also use the motorcycle taxi, which is useful for solo travelers.

HEALTH & SAFETY

HEALTH

Water

Do not drink tap water and only drink bottled water. Ice can be made from polluted water, but many restaurants buy ice from companies, which is quite safe in this case.



Food

Make sure soup dishes, such as Pho, are piping hot. Only eat cooked foods and stay away from raw meat. Also, be mindful when eating raw vegetables. Use your own judgment. Be careful with fruits. Eat fruits with inedible skin, such as bananas, oranges, and watermelons.



Arnimals

You will see many animals in Vietnam on the street, including dogs, cats, chickens and more. Vietnam is not a rabies-free country, so stay away from these animals.



Insects

In Vietnam, malaria is confined to rural areas, but dengue fever is more common across the country. Both are transmitted by mosquitoes, so a bug spray containing DEET is a must! Malaria pills are not necessary, but it is useful to bring emergency Malaria treatment, especially if you are going off the beaten track.



Vaccinations

Vaccinations are not mandatory for Vietnam. However, a DTP vaccination and protection against hepatitis A are recommended. Typhoid vaccination is also recommended for stays longer than two weeks. Always ask yor doctor for professional advice.



SCAMS



- Overpaying and confusing currency in stores and markets
- Paying too much for the taxi, drive longer with meter or fake taxis
- Restaurants that do not display prices
- Paying for damage that has not been made on motorcycle rental
- Unreliable travel agents: tickets that are too high or forged
- Hanoi shoe cleaners (cleaning shoes without being asked)
- Pay for taking pictures

SAFETY

Traffic



Traffic in Vietnam is often very chaotic and dangerous. There are many road accidents every year, many of which are in Ho Chi Minh City.

Crime



Vietnam is a safe place to travel. Crime is rare against tourists. Only in large cities it is advisable to store loose items that can be picked up by a passing scooter.

Emergency numbers



Police: 113
Ambulance: 115
Fire department: 114

MONEY & BUDGET

CURRENCY

The official currency is the Vietnamese Dong - đồng (₫) (VND)

1 EUR = 27,000
1 USD = 23,000
1 AUD =

** March 2021 conversions*
** Conversions on the right have been rounded to 1 cent.*

Available bills:

200 ₫	$ 0,01
500 ₫	$ 0,02
1000 ₫	$ 0,04
2000 ₫	$ 0,07
5000 ₫	$ 0,18
10.000 ₫	$ 0,37

20.000 ₫	$ 0,73
50.000 ₫	$ 1,83
100.000 ₫	$ 3,66
200.000 ₫	$ 7,31
500.000 ₫	$ 18.28



PAYING & TIPPING

Other currency
Although the official currency is the Vietnam Dong (VND), many major stores and hotels in Vietnam also accept the US dollar.

Credit card
Credit cards are accepted in major cities at hotels and travel agents, but don't expect cheap guesthouses or local restaurants that accept credit cards. Payment commissions are sometimes applicable (about 3%).

Cash
Cash payment is the norm for many shops and restaurants. Especially when you travel to remote villages, it is useful to bring enough cash.

Tipping
Tipping is not expected in Vietnam, but it is greatly appreciated. For someone making $ 150 a month, a $ 1 tip is important. Normally, guides on minibus tours will share tips between themselves and the drivers.

WITHDRAW MONEY AT ATM

The rules regarding the maximum ATM amount in Vietnam and the withdrawal fee for each transaction vary from bank to bank, but local bank ATMs have quite a low maximum withdrawal amount per transaction compared to international banks.

Bank	Max	Fee
Vietcombank	2.000.000 ₫	50.000 ₫
Agribank	6.000.000 ₫	22.000 ₫
BIDV	2.000.000 ₫	30.000 ₫
Military Bank	5.000.000 ₫	49.500 ₫
Citibank	8.000.000d ₫	55.000 ₫
ANZ	10.000.000 ₫	40.000 ₫

BUDGET

	Low budget	Average budget	High budget
Daily from	$ 15	$ 40	$ 100
Accommodation	$ 5	$ 20	$ 60
Food and drink	$ 4	$ 10	$ 20
Local transport	$ 2	$ 5	$ 20
Transport between cities	$ 5	$ 15	$ 40
Activities	$ 5	$ 35	$ 60

WHAT IS THE PRICE FOR...

Wat	Price in VND	Price in Euro
Bia Hoi (beer that you only find at street stalls)	7.000 ₫	$ 0,25
Local beer in a restaurant	20.000 ₫	$ 0,70
Cola in a restaurant	15.000 ₫	$ 0,55
Meal in a cheap restaurant	50.000 ₫	$ 1,80
Meal in an average restaurant	120.000 ₫	$ 4,25
Banh Mi (filled baguette)	15.000 ₫	$ 0,55
Rent a scooter per day	150.000 ₫	$ 5,50
Taxi per kilometer	14.000 ₫	$ 0,50
Entrance fees to museums and sights (avg.)	50.000 ₫	$ 1,80

HOLIDAYS

NATIONAL HOLIDAYS 2021

1-jan	Int. New Year
15-feb	Start Tet holiday
12-feb	Vietnamese New Year
19-feb	End Tet holiday
21-apr	Remembrance Day of Vietnamese Kings
30-apr	Day of reunification
1-mei	Labour Day
2-sep	Independence Day
20-oct	Vietnamese Women's Day
25-dec	Christmas

TRAVEL DURING TET NEW YEAR

Accommodations
Contrary to many reports, there are plenty of accommodations in Vietnam during Tet. Only in the destinations popular with Vietnamese holiday-makers, such as Dalat and Phu Quoc, it is more difficult.

Visa
Government agencies are also closed during the entire holiday (7 days). This means that the Vietnamese Immigration Service does not process e-visas and authorization letters for a visa on arrival.

Tours & sightseeing
Many tourist attractions are closed during the holidays.

Banks & ATMs
Banks are closed during the holidays and ATMs are not refilled. This means that you cannot get cash when Tet is approaching.

Restaurants
During Tet Holiday, restaurants and coffee shops also take a few days off.

Buses
Buses can be busy and advance booking is recommended.

Domestic flights
Book airline tickets as soon as possible, especially for domestic flights between major cities (Ho Chi Minh - Ha Noi, Ho Chi Minh - Da Nang and vice versa), or else you may have to pay 5x as much for a ticket.

Trains
Getting a train ticket is even more stressful than flights and getting a ticket at the train station during this time is almost impossible, so book it as early as possible.

Taxis
There are still taxis, Grab and Uber during Tet, but the prices will be much higher.

TRANSPORTATION

MEANS OF TRANSPORTATION

Domestic flights

Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City are the two main international airports with most international flights arriving. Domestic flights are also a good option as many of Vietnam's highlights are relatively far apart and flights can be very cheap. So you already have flights from 25 euros!

Bus



The bus is often the cheapest option between the various destinations in Vietnam. Night buses save you a day of traveling and a night in a hotel.

Train



The train is a more comfortable option, but also more expensive. You can take the train on several popular routes, but the night train is also an option. Tickets must be purchased in advance.

Car



Driving yourself is not recommended due to the poor condition of the roads and a driver is not expensive. If you are traveling with a group, it is recommended to rent a minivan. Taxis can be found everywhere. An alternative is the App. Grab, comparable to Uber in the Netherlands. Grab scooters are also available for solo travelers.

Motorbike / scooter



A very cool way to travel through Vietnam is on a motorcycle. You can rent one in many places and it only costs a few dollars a day. Please note that you are officially not allowed to drive without a valid Vietnamese driver's license. The police condoned the policy, but you are not automatically insured.

Cruise



In the Mekong Delta you can take a boat for short distances. You can also go by boat from Rach Gia to the island of Phu Quoc. In Halong Bay, a boat is also inevitable to visit the beautiful bay.

Other options



Renting a bicycle is an ideal way to explore the smaller towns and the countryside. In the cities you never have to walk if you don't want to. There are plenty of cheap options to get you around. You absolutely must try a cyclo. That's a bike with two passenger seats.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Cities	Airport	Train station	Bus connection	Boat connection
Da Nang	✓	✓	✓	
Dalat	✓		✓	
Halong Bay	✓		✓	✓
Hanoi	✓	✓	✓	
Ho Chi Minh City	✓	✓	✓	
Hoi An	✓	✓	✓	
Hue	✓	✓	✓	
Mai Chau			✓	
Ha Giang			✓	
Mekong Delta	✓		✓	✓
Mui Ne		✓	✓	
Nha Trang	✓	✓	✓	
Ninh Binh		✓	✓	
Phong Nha	✓	✓	✓	
Phu Quoc	✓			✓
Quy Nhon	✓	✓	✓	
Sapa		✓	✓	
Con Dao	✓			✓

WEATHER

WEATHER PER MONTH

	North Vietnam		Central Vietnam		South Vietnam	
Month	Average temperature	Rain (mm)	Average temperature	Rain (mm)	Average temperature	Rain (mm)
January	17 °C	18	22 °C	101	27	15
February	18 °C	28	22 °C	31	28	4
March	20 °C	38	24 °C	12	29	13
April	24 °C	81	27 °C	18	30	42
May	28 °C	197	29 °C	47	29	221
June	30 °C	238	30 °C	42	29	331
July	30 °C	322	30 °C	99	28	314
August	29 °C	343	28 °C	117	28	268
September	28 °C	252	26 °C	447	27	334
October	26 °C	98	24 °C	530	27	268
November	22 °C	42	22 °C	221	27	114
December	19 °C	21	21 °C	208	27	56

*Best travel time is indicated in green.

REGION

North Vietnam
Northern Vietnam (Hanoi, Halong Bay, Sapa, Mai Chau & Ninh Binh) has a distinct winter and summer season. The cool but mostly dry winter lasts from November to April, with an average temperature of 17-22 ° C with the coldest months January - March. Summer lasts from May to October when it is hot and humid and the region has the most rainfall. July to September are often the wettest months of the year.

Central Vietnam
Central Vietnam (Hoi An, Da Nang, Hue) has hot and dry weather from mid-January to the end of August, with temperatures often reaching mid-30 degrees. During the winter months, rainfall increases with peak levels in October and November, sometimes in the form of typhoons.

South Vietnam
With temperatures remaining constant throughout the year, the climate in the south (Ho Chi Minh City, Mekong Delta, Mui Ne, Phu Quoc) is split into two simple seasons, wet and dry. The dry season starts in November and ends in April / early May, with slightly warmer and more humid at the end of February to May. The wet season lasts from May to early November, with the months of June, July and August receiving the most rainfall of the year.

SEASONS

Travel during the rainy season
A big misconception is that the rainy season in Vietnam means it rains all day long. Especially in South Vietnam it rains almost every day, but often only one or two hours in the afternoon very hard and the rest of the day it is dry.

Travel in the winter
Vietnam has a tropical climate. Nevertheless, in the winter, especially the months of December and January, it can get quite cold in the north of Vietnam. In Sapa and Ha Giang it can go towards the freezing point. In Hanoi, Ninh Binh and Mai Chau expect temperatures around 8 to 10 degrees. It is best to wear several layers, instead of thick coats and sweaters.

Travel for the most beautiful rice fields
In the Mekong Delta there are several harvests per year. In the northern mountain regions there is one rice crop every year. The best is in the harvest season, when the rice fields are yellow. But what is also impressive is the start of the rice season, when the fields are underwater and look like a large mirror. The months in between you will find the fields in different shades of green. In most places in the north, the harvest season is from mid-September to early October, and the rice season starts in May.

PACKING LIST

Suitcase or backpack?
Roads and sidewalks are often of poor quality for trolley cases. In addition, you travel a lot from destination to destination, so you can be more mobile with a backpack.

Important documents
- Visa!
- Passport
- Credit Card (s)
- Debit card
- Cash (possibly in Dollars)
- Copies of important documents
- Reservations
- Boarding pass

Medical checklist
- Healthcare card
- Paracetamol
- Diarrhea / diarrhea medicine
- Insect repellent
- First aid kit (bandages, (blisters) plasters, etc.)

Clothing woman
- 3 shorts
- 2 dresses (1 maxi, 1 short)
- 3 tank tops
- 1 cotton shirt
- 1 Dry Fit T-shirt
- 1 legging
- 1 skirt
- 1 long pants
- 1 long-sleeved shirt (thin)
- 1 lightweight waterproof jacket
- 5 pairs of travel underwear
- 2 bikinis
- 4 pairs of travel socks
- 2 sports bra
- 1 bra
- 1 hat / cap
- 1 walking shoes / sneakers
- 1 slippers / sandals

Toiletries
- Travel soap
- Toothpaste / toothbrush
- Shaving supplies
- Contact lens solution
- Feminine hygiene products
- Makeup
- Hair products / accessories
- Shampoo
- Travel towel
- Insect / mosquito spray (with DEET)
- Sunscreen
- Deodorant

Electronics & accessories
- Mobile phone
- Tablet / laptop (including chargers / accessories)
- Camera (including chargers, extra battery)
- SD card
- Headphones / Earpieces

Clothes man
- 3 shorts (2 board shorts, 1 travel shorts)
- 4 tank tops
- 3 cotton T-shirt
- 1 dri-fit T-shirt
- 1 long pants
- 2 swimsuits
- 1 base layer with long sleeves (thin)
- 1 Lightweight rain jacket
- 5 pairs of travel underwear
- 4 pairs of travel socks
- 1 hat / cap
- 1 Light walking shoes or sneakers
- 1 Microfiber travel towel
- 1 Slippers / sandals
- 1 Closed shoes

ROUTES

1 WEEK NORTH VIETNAM

Hanoi (2 days)
Explore the old quarter, do the food tour, visit sights and watch a water puppet show.

Halong Bay (2 - 3 days)
You will be picked up in Hanoi for your Halong Bay cruise. Lan Ha Bay, Cat Ba and Bai Tu Long Bay options are also available.

- Back from Halong Bay, take a minibus or private car to Ninh Binh (Tam Coc / Trang An / Hoa Lu)

Ninh Binh (2 days)
Take a boat trip in Trang An or Tam Coc. Visit the viewpoint in Mua Cave. Cycle along the rice fields.

- From Ninh Binh to Hanoi: By shuttle / minibus or private transport.

1 WEEK CENTRAL VIETNAM

Hoi An (4 days)
Walk through the Old Town, take a day trip to Cham Island, My Son, Marble Mountains or the Hai Van Pass. Enjoy the beach.

- From Hoi An to Hue: you can take this sightseeing route on the back of your motorcycle with an easy rider, by old military jeep or private car with driver.

Hue (3 days)
Explore the old Imperial city; possibly by bike. Take a boat trip on the Perfume River. Day trip to the DMZ, Bach Ma national park or the Ba Na Hills with golden bridge.

- From Hue to Hanoi or Ho Chi Minh City: Daily flights from Hue airport.
- There are also international flights direct from Da Nang to Europe and other countries in Asia.

1 WEEK SOUTH VIETNAM

Ho Chi Minh City (2 days)
Explore the city and take a day trip to the Cu Chi Tunnels.

- From HCMC to Mekong Delta: By organized tour or bus.

Mekong Delta (2 days)
Cycle through the rice fields, take a boat trip and visit the famous floating markets. Explore villages, fruit orchards and local factories.

- From Mekong Delta to Phu Quoc: Take the speed ferry or short domestic flight from Can Tho.

Phu Quoc (3 days)
Enjoy the many beaches and do as little as possible. Visit restaurants and bars. You can also visit the chef's nuts prison and pepper plantations.

- Phu Quoc has an international airport and daily connections to HCMC, Da Nang and Hanoi.

HIGHLIGHTS IN 2 WEEKS

Ho Chi Minh City (2 days)
Explore the city and take a day trip to the Cu Chi Tunnels or to the Mekong Delta.

- From HCMC to Hoi An: Take a domestic flight to Da Nang and from here a taxi to Hoi An.

Hoi An (3 days)
Walk through the Old Town, take a day trip to Cham Island, My Son, Marble Mountains or the Hai Van Pass. Enjoy the beach.

- From Hoi An to Ninh Binh: Return to Da Nang for a flight to Hanoi. From here you take a bus, private transport or by bus through the center of Hanoi to Ninh Binh

Ninh Binh (2 days)
Take a boat trip, cycle through the countryside and visit the viewpoint.

- From Ninh Binh to Hanoi: By train, bus, shuttle / minibus or private transport.

Hanoi (2 days)
Explore the old quarter, do the food tour, visit sights and watch a water puppet show.

- From Hanoi to Sapa: By night train or sleeping bus

Sapa (2 days)
In Sapa you will make a 2-day trek and stay in a homestay.

- From Sapa to Halong Bay: Take the overnight train back to Hanoi. From here you will go by tour to Halong Bay.

Halong Bay (2 days)
Enjoy a 2-day cruise through Halong Bay before heading back to Hanoi for your return flight.

2 WEEKS NORTHERN VIETNAM

Hanoi (2 days)
Explore the old quarter, do the food tour, visit sights and watch a water puppet show.

- From Hanoi to Sapa: By night train or sleeping bus

Sapa (2 days)
In Sapa you will make a 2-day trek and stay in a homestay.

- From Sapa to Ha Giang: Take the limousine bus that leaves early in the morning

Ha Giang loop + Cao Bang + Ba Be Lake (6 days)
Stay 1 night in Ha Giang City before starting your 5 day tour with private car or on the back of your motorcycle. The first 2 days you travel through the mountains of Ha Giang. Then you continue to Cao Bang where you visit the Ban Gioc Waterfall. You end the trip with a boat cruise on Ba Be National Park Lake and drive back to Hanoi.

Halong Bay (2 - 3 days)
You will be picked up in Hanoi for your Halong Bay cruise. Lan Ha Bay, Cat Ba and Bai Tu Long Bay options are also available.

2 WEEKS NORTH AND CENTRAL

Hanoi (2 days)
Explore the old quarter, do the food tour, visit sights and watch a water puppet show.

- From Hanoi to Sapa: Night train, bus or sleeping bus
- From Hanoi to Ha Giang: Bus, minibus or private transport.

Sapa or Ha Giang (3 - 4 days)
In Sapa you will hike through the rice fields, visit nearby attractions such as waterfalls and stay one night in a homestay of local minorities.
In Ha Giang you do the Ha Giang walk on the back of the motorcycle or by car. Drive through beautiful mountain scenery and visit minority villages.

- Return to Hanoi from Sapa by night train or bus and Ha Giang by night bus.

Halong Bay (2 - 3 days)
You will be picked up in Hanoi for your Halong Bay cruise. Lan Ha Bay, Cat Ba and Bai Tu Long Bay options are also available.

- Back from Halong Bay, take a minibus or private car to Ninh Binh (Tam Coc / Trang An / Hoa Lu)

Ninh Binh (2 days)
Take a boat trip in Trang An or Tam Coc. Visit the viewpoint in Mua Cave. Cycle along the rice fields.

- From Ninh Binh to Hanoi Airport: By shuttle / minibus or private transport.
- From Hanoi airport you then fly to Da Nang.
- From Da Nang take the bus or taxi to Hoi An

Hoi An (3 days)
Walk through the Old Town, take a day trip to Cham Island, My Son, Marble Mountains or the Hai Van Pass. Enjoy the beach.

- From Hoi An to Hanoi: Return to Da Nang for a flight to Hanoi.
- There are also international flights direct from Da Nang.

3 WEEKS NORTH AND CENTRAL

Hanoi (2 days)
Explore the old quarter, do the food tour, visit sights and watch a water puppet show.

- From Hanoi to Sapa: By night train or sleeping bus

Sapa (2 days)
In Sapa you will make a 2-day trek and stay in a homestay.

- From Sapa to Ha Giang: Take the limousine bus that leaves early in the morning

Ha Giang loop + Cao Bang + Ba Be Lake (6 days)
Stay 1 night in Ha Giang City before starting your 5 day tour with private car or on the back of your motorcycle. The first 2 days you travel through the mountains of Ha Giang. Then you continue to Cao Bang where you visit the Ban Gioc Waterfall. You end the trip with a boat cruise on Ba Be National Park Lake and drive back to Hanoi.

Halong Bay (2 - 3 days)
You will be picked up in Hanoi for your Halong Bay cruise. Lan Ha Bay, Cat Ba and Bai Tu Long Bay options are also available.

Ninh Binh (2 days)
Take a boat trip in Trang An or Tam Coc. Visit the viewpoint in Mua Cave. Cycle along the rice fields.

- From Ninh Binh to Hanoi Airport: By shuttle / minibus or private transport.
- From Hanoi airport you then fly to Da Nang.
- From Da Nang take the bus or taxi to Hoi An

Hoi An (3 days)
Walk through the Old Town, take a day trip to Cham Island, My Son, Marble Mountains or the Hai Van Pass. Enjoy the beach.

From Hoi An to Hue: this sightseeing route can be done on the back of your motorcycle with an easy rider, by old military jeep or private car with driver.

Hue (2 days)
Explore the old Imperial city; possibly by bike. Take a boat trip on the Parfum river. Day trip to the DMZ or Bach Ma national park.

- From Hue to Hanoi: Daily flights from Hue airport to Hanoi.
- There are also international flights direct from Da Nang to Europe and other countries in Asia.

HIGHLIGHTS IN 3 WEEKS

Ho Chi Minh City (2 - 3 days)
Explore the sights in the city and take a day trip to the Mekong Delta and the Cu Chi Tunnels. In the evening you go to a rooftop bar and drink in a bar on Bui Vien street.

- From Ho Chi Minh City to Hoi An: Airplane

Hoi An (3 days)
Walk through the old town both during the day and at night when the lanterns illuminate the city. Cycle through the countryside, lie on the beach and take a day trip to Cham Island or My Son.

- From Hoi An To Hue: Train (via Da Nang), bus or easy rider tour via the Hai Van Pass

Hue (1 day)
Explore the old capital by bicycle and take a boat trip on the perfume river.

- From Hue To Phong Nha: Bus, private transport, train (to Dong Hoi) or tour on the DMZ

Phong Nha (2 days)
Choose one or more caves to visit, with an option on adventurous activities such as camping in the jungle and swimming and climbing in a cave.

- From Phong Nha to Ninh Binh: The night train from Dong Hoi or take a sleeping bus.

Ninh Binh (2 days)
Take a boat trip in Trang An or Tam Coc. Visit the viewpoint in Mua Cave. Cycle along the rice fields.

- From Ninh Binh to Hanoi: By train, bus, shuttle / minibus or private transport.

Hanoi (1 days)
Explore the Old Quarter and do a street food tour in the evening.

Halong Bay (2 - 3 days)
You will be picked up in Hanoi for your Halong Bay cruise. Lan Ha Bay, Cat Ba and Bai Tu Long Bay options are also available.

Hanoi (2 days)
Back in Hanoi you will continue to explore the sights. Take a cyclo tour and visit the water puppet theater.

- From Hanoi to Sapa: Night train, bus or sleeping bus
- From Hanoi to Ha Giang: Bus, minibus or private transport.

Sapa or Ha Giang (2 - 4 days)
In Sapa you will hike through the rice fields, visit nearby attractions such as waterfalls and stay one night in a homestay of local minorities.
In Ha Giang you do the Ha Giang walk on the back of the motorcycle or by car. Drive through beautiful mountain scenery and visit minority villages.

- Back to Hanoi for flight back to home or next destination.

HIGHLIGHTS IN 4 WEEKS

Ho Chi Minh City (2 - 3 days)
Take a day trip to the Cu Chi Tunnels or a 2-day tour to the Mekong Delta. Enjoy a drink at a rooftop bar and on Bui Vien Street.

- From Ho Chi Minh City to Dalat: Bus or plane
- From Ho Chi Minh City to Mui Ne: Train or Bus

Dalat or Mui Ne (2 - 3 days)
If you're feeling adventurous, go mountain biking, canyoning and hiking through the beautiful hills of Dalat. If you prefer to lie on a beach and slide down huge sand dunes, choose Mui Ne.

- From Dalat to Nha Trang: Bus, tour or easy rider
- From Mui Ne to Nha Trang: Bus or train

Nha Trang (1 day)
A real beach destination, but especially popular among Russians and Chinese. If you don't mind traveling a little longer from Dalat / Mui Ne, go straight to Quy Nhon (Xep Beach)

- From Nha Trang to Hoi An: Train or bus

Hoi An (3 - 4 days)
Stroll through the city during the day as well as in the evening with lantern-lit streets. Cycle through the rice fields just outside the city. Take a day trip to My Son, Cham Island or the Marble Mountains.

- From Hoi An To Hue: Train (via Da Nang), bus or tour via Hai Van Pass

Hue (1 day)
Explore the old Imperial city; possibly by bike. Take a boat trip on the Parfum river.

- From Hue to Phong Nha: Train (to Dong Hoi) or bus

Phong Nha (2 - 3 days)
Choose 2 or more caves you want to visit. If you are very adventurous, choose a 2 or 3 day trip to a cave, including camping in a cave or in the jungle.

- From Phong Nha to Ninh Binh: Train (from Dong Hoi) or bus

Ninh Binh (3 days)
Take a boat trip through the rice fields and caves of Trang An or / and Tam Coc. Check out the view from Mua Cave. Bird watching in Thung Nham or Van Long.

- From Ninh Binh to Hanoi: Bus, train or minibus / car

Hanoi (1 day)
Explore the old quarter and Hoan Kiem lake.

Halong Bay (2 - 3 days)
Just a cruise through Halong Bay for 2 days 1 night or 3 days 2 nights. Possible to go to less touristy Lan Ha Bay or Bai Tu Long Bay. Also possible to go to Cat Ba island. Halong Bay cruises include transport from Hanoi.

Hanoi (1 day)
Back in Hanoi. Watch a water puppet show and go to the old Imperial Citadel.

- From Hanoi to Sapa: Train or Bus
- From Hanoi to Ha Giang: Bus, minibus / car or tour

Sapa or Ha Giang (2 - 5 days)
Trekking through the rice fields of Sapa. Lots of options for good accommodation. Take a tour through the most beautiful mountain landscape in Vietnam: Ha Giang. Very authentic but therefore basic accommodations.

Hanoi (1 - 2 days)
Relax before flying back or on.

BUCKETLIST

- [ ] 1. Drive the Ha Giang loop
- [ ] 2. Walk through the ancient town of Hoi An
- [ ] 3. Cruise in Halong Bay
- [ ] 4. Trekking in Sapa
- [ ] 5. Canyoning in Dalat
- [ ] 6. Relax on the beaches of Phu Quoc
- [ ] 7. Crawl through the Cu Chi Tunnels
- [ ] 8. Visit a floating market in the Mekong
- [ ] 9. Explore a cave in Phong Nha
- [ ] 10. Street food tour in Ho Chi Minh City
- [ ] 11. Cycle through the landscape of Mai Chau
- [ ] 12. Take the motorcycle over the Hai Van Pass
- [ ] 13. Boat trip in Ninh Binh
- [ ] 14. Take a cooking class
- [ ] 15. Enjoy a water puppet show in Hanoi
- [ ] 16. Visit a local northern market
- [ ] 17. Have a beer at Bia Hoi Junction
- [ ] 18. Explore the imperial city of Hue
- [ ] 19. Have a cocktail at a rooftop bar in Saigon
- [ ] 20. Diving in Con Dao

TRAVEL INSPIRATION

No idea where to go? Use this inspiration to create your own list of destinations to visit, based on your needs; do you prefer beaches, mountains, culture.



TOP 15 MOST BEAUTIFUL DESTINATIONS

1. Ha Giang
Impressive karst mountains, hills and green valleys with minority villages.

2. Hoi An
A well-preserved old trading town, full of picturesque historic houses, pagodas and cafes.

3. Halong Bay
The karst mountains of this bay are one of the most fascinating seascapes in the world.

4. Dalat
Adventure capital, with French villas, pine forests, beautiful lakes and waterfalls.

5. Sapa
Surrounded by beautiful mountains, rice terraces and various hill tribes.

6. Phong Nha
Home to many caves, including the largest cave in the world.

7. Mai Chau
A rural valley with towering cliffs, a unique culture, rice fields and a good atmosphere

8. Ninh Binh
Known as Halong Bay on land, full of karst mountains, paddy fields, rivers and temples.

9. Hanoi
Numerous museums, historic streets and temples, markets, bridges and a historic citadel.

6. Con Dao
A heavenly place of secluded beaches, pristine dive sites and diverse nature.

11. Hue
Once the capital of imperial Vietnam, much of its rich history is well preserved.

12. Cao Bang
The biggest attraction is Ban Gioc waterfall, the most impressive waterfall in Vietnam.

13. Quy Nhon
Relaxed beaches, Champa ruins and an authentic experience of Vietnamese culture

14. Phu Quoc
A piece of paradise for beach lovers, with nothing but palm trees and the sea.

15. Mekong Delta
A unique water world, where boats, houses and markets float on the countless rivers and canals.



TOP 8 ADVENTURES

1. Explore Vietnam by motorcycle
Explore Vietnam like a local and experience things you would otherwise never see and feel.

2. Stay overnight in a cave in Phong Nha
Camp in a cave as you explore one of the largest and most impressive caves in the world.

3. Canyoning in Dalat
Rappelling waterfalls, cliff jumping, natural slides and forest walks.

4. Rock Climbing in Halong Bay
One of the most majestic climbing areas in the world, with more than 3000 limestone mountains.

5. Multi-day trekking in Sapa
Walk through villages, past rice fields, fantastic viewpoints and stay in a homestay.

6. Kitesurfing in Mui Ne
Safe learning conditions in the morning and a bit more challenging in the late afternoon

7. Mountain biking in Dalat
Lots of hills with forests, beautiful single tracks and you can stop at villages and viewpoints.

8. Diving in Con Dao
Considered the most beautiful coral reef in Vietnam, with 16 islands and a unique ecosystem.



TOP 8 CULTURAL DESTINATIONS

1. Hoi An
A well-preserved example of a trading port and a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

2. Hanoi
Influenced by the local Vietnamese culture as well as various colonial powers.

3. Ha Giang
Untouched hill tribe villages, authentic villages and local markets.

4. Sapa
Explore the culture of the local minority in each village, with different activities.

5. Hue
Former capital of Vietnam, full of monuments, temples, palaces and tombs.

6. Ho Chi Minh City
Shaped by the West; a great mix of Asian and Western cultures.

7. Mekong Delta
The local population lives from the rivers, with floating markets and houses on stilts.

8. Dalat
A very modern Vietnamese culture, where young Vietnamese come to spend their holidays.



TOP 8 OFF THE BEATEN TRACK

1. Ha Giang
The most beautiful mountain scenery, with ethnic minorities, and their own cultures

2. Pu Luong
Limestone landscape of extraordinary beauty with interesting culture.

3. Phong Nha
A beautiful place with the world's largest cave and dozens of other caves.

4. Mu Cang Chai
Famous for the most beautiful terraced rice fields and unique H'mong culture.

5. Ba Be lake
The highest and largest natural lake in Vietnam, with waterfalls, forests and caves.

6. Roof Lacquer
Home of Ethnic Minorities, Waterfalls, National Park, Ethnic Villages and Lak Lake.

7. Kontum
Feel like you have reached the end of the world. Traditional ways of living.

8. Quy Nhon
Pristine beaches, beautiful islands, beautiful mountains and peaceful fishing villages.



TOP 8 MOST BEAUTIFUL RICE FIELDS

1. Mu Cang Chai
Cross the perilous Khau Pha pass to get to the most beautiful scenery of rice terraces.

2. Pu Luong
Unique because of the bamboo waterwheels that are used to submerge rice fields.

3. Sapa
The rice fields have been around for hundreds of years, created by ethnic minorities.

4. Hoang Su Phi
A destination off the beaten track; one of the least visited places in Vietnam.

5. An Giang
The only place in this list in the south. The Mekong Delta is the "rice bowl of Vietnam".

6. Mai Chau
A rural area, where bright yellow and green rice fields grow in a mountainous landscape.

7. Bac Son
The valley is surrounded by mountains where you can hike and enjoy a great view.

8. Ninh Binh
Limestone mountains and rivers with green rice fields on both sides.



TOP 8 BEACH DESTINATIONS

1. Phu Quoc
White powdery beaches, clear waters, swaying palm trees and a few bars.

2. Nha Trang
Fantastic beaches surrounded by beautiful forests, with options for snorkeling or diving.

3. Con Dao
An archipelago of 15 islands with a total of 200 km of beautiful coastline and coral reefs.

4. Hoi An
An island-like strip of white sand with palm trees and a blue-green lake.

5. Cham Island
Consists of eight small islands off the coast of Hoi An, with the best beaches in Vietnam.

6. Quy Nhon
Offers the opportunity to enjoy the tranquility, with beaches that are almost hidden.

7. Mui Ne
A fishing village that happens to have a beautiful beach, now full of resorts and bars.

8. Phu Yen
A quiet place without tourists, powdery sand, blue water and a sleepy character.



TOP 8 MARKETS

1. Meo Vac Sunday market
Most authentic markets can be found in Ha Giang. The largest market is in Meo Vac.

2. Bac Ha market
Alleys and squares are filled with villagers from all over the area.

3. Khau Vai love market
Held once a year and notable for being a dating site for ex-lover.

4. Cai Rang Floating market
The largest floating market in the Mekong Delta, with many traders and boats.

5. Hoi An night market
Stalls sell local snacks, souvenirs, clothing, jewelry and are lit by lanterns.

6. Can Cau market
A fascinating open-air market that mainly specializes in livestock.

7. Dalat night market
Buy delicious food, warm clothes, and souvenirs, with a great atmosphere.

8. Hanoi Weekend Night Market
Roadside stalls and local eateries attract many locals and tourist.



TOP 8 BIKE DESTINATIONS

1. Mekong Delta
Many hiking trails through the flat landscape along rice fields, fruit orchards and forests.

2. Hoi An
Drive to the old town and explore the countryside around Hoi An by bicycle.

3. Mai Chau
Lush paddy fields surround picturesque villages of rural life.

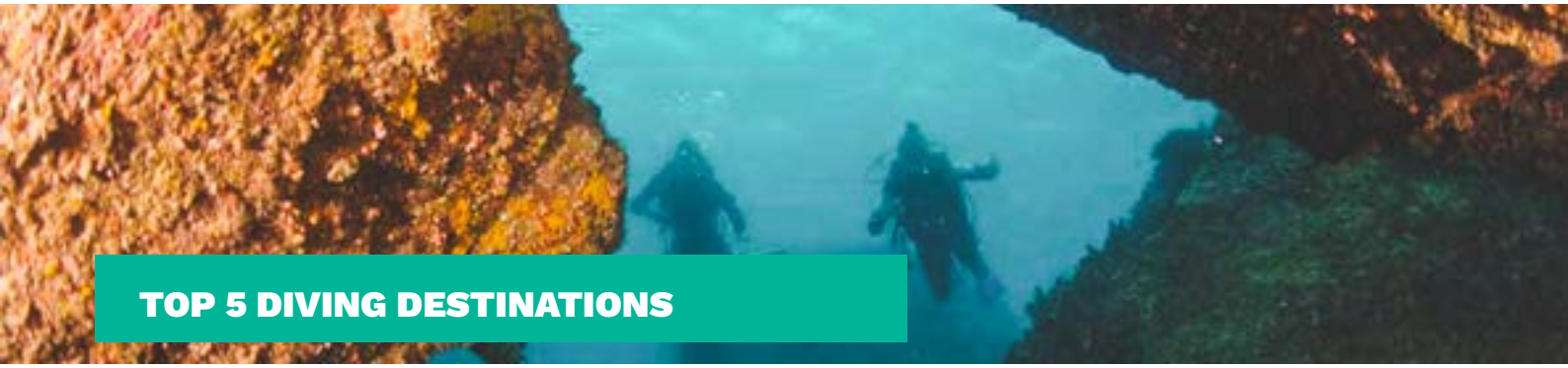
4. Hue
Great place to cycle to beautiful and impressive palaces, tombs and pagodas.

5. Dalat
Cool mountain air, great views and beautiful forest trails for mountain bikers.

6. Ninh Binh
Big limestone mountains and rocks here, but it's completely flat between these mountains.

7. Cat Tien National Park
A rich biodiversity of swamp and tropical rainforest, with many routes.

8. Hanoi
A bike ride through the city takes you to parks, colonial buildings and lakes.



TOP 5 DIVING DESTINATIONS

1. Con Dao
The most beautiful coral reef and known for its biodiversity; more than 1,300 species of marine life.

2. Whale Island
There are dive sites with walls, caves and beautiful reefs.

3. Hoi An
Around Cham Island, a cluster of 8 islands, with lots of coral, rock formations and tropical fish.

4. Phu Quoc
Most of the dive sites are very shallow so you can enjoy snorkeling too.

5. Nha Trang
Capital of diving, with more than 20 diving schools, to improve diving skills.



TOP 8 NATURE

1. Ha Giang
Huge mountains with remote hill tribe villages connected by winding roads.

2. Phong Nha
Both topsoil and subsoil one of the most impressive nature.

3. Halong Bay & Cat Ba
One of the Seven New Natural Wonders of the World.

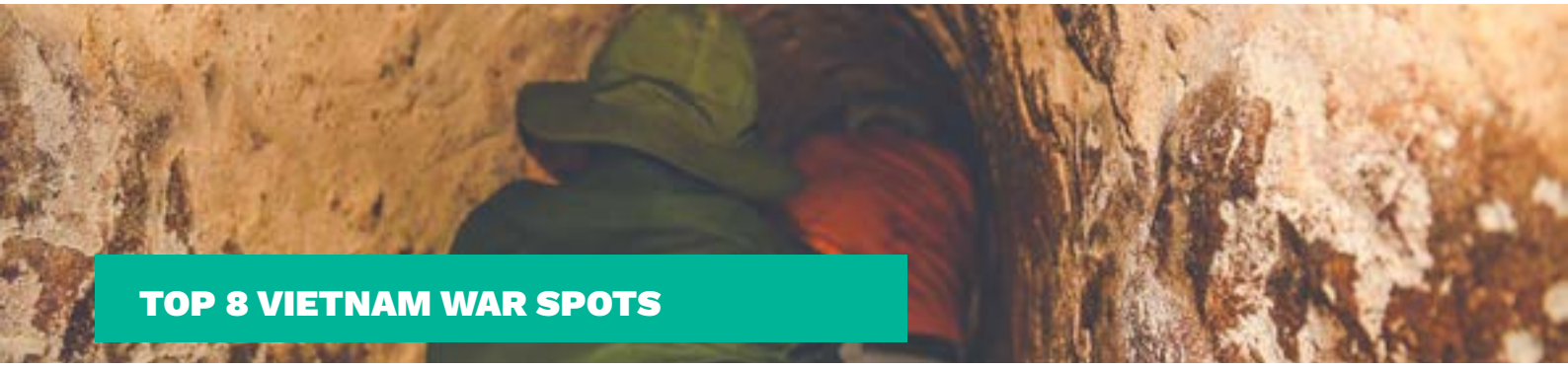
4. Pu Luong
Rich forests, limestone panoramas, beautiful rice terraces and breathtaking landscapes

5. Dalat
Lakes, waterfalls, forests, plantations, hidden French villas and pagodas.

6. Sapa & Mu Cang Chai
The terraced rice fields along the mountain slopes are iconic sights

7. Phu Quoc
Beautiful beaches with white sand, palm trees and a relaxed atmosphere.

8. Mekong Delta
Hundreds of rivers and canals, orchards, rice fields and underwater forests.



TOP 8 VIETNAM WAR SPOTS

1. Ho Chi Minh City
Here you will find Reunification Palace, War Remnants Museum and the Cu Chu Tunnels.

2. DMZ
The line between North and South Vietnam, including the Vinh Moc Tunnels and Khe Sanh Combat Base.

3. Hanoi
Visit the Hoa Lo prison where American prisoners of war were held.

4. Da Nang
Son Tra is home to the remains of a base and the Hai Van pass was an important route.

5. Hue
The battle for Hue in 1968 was one of the toughest and longest of the Vietnam War.

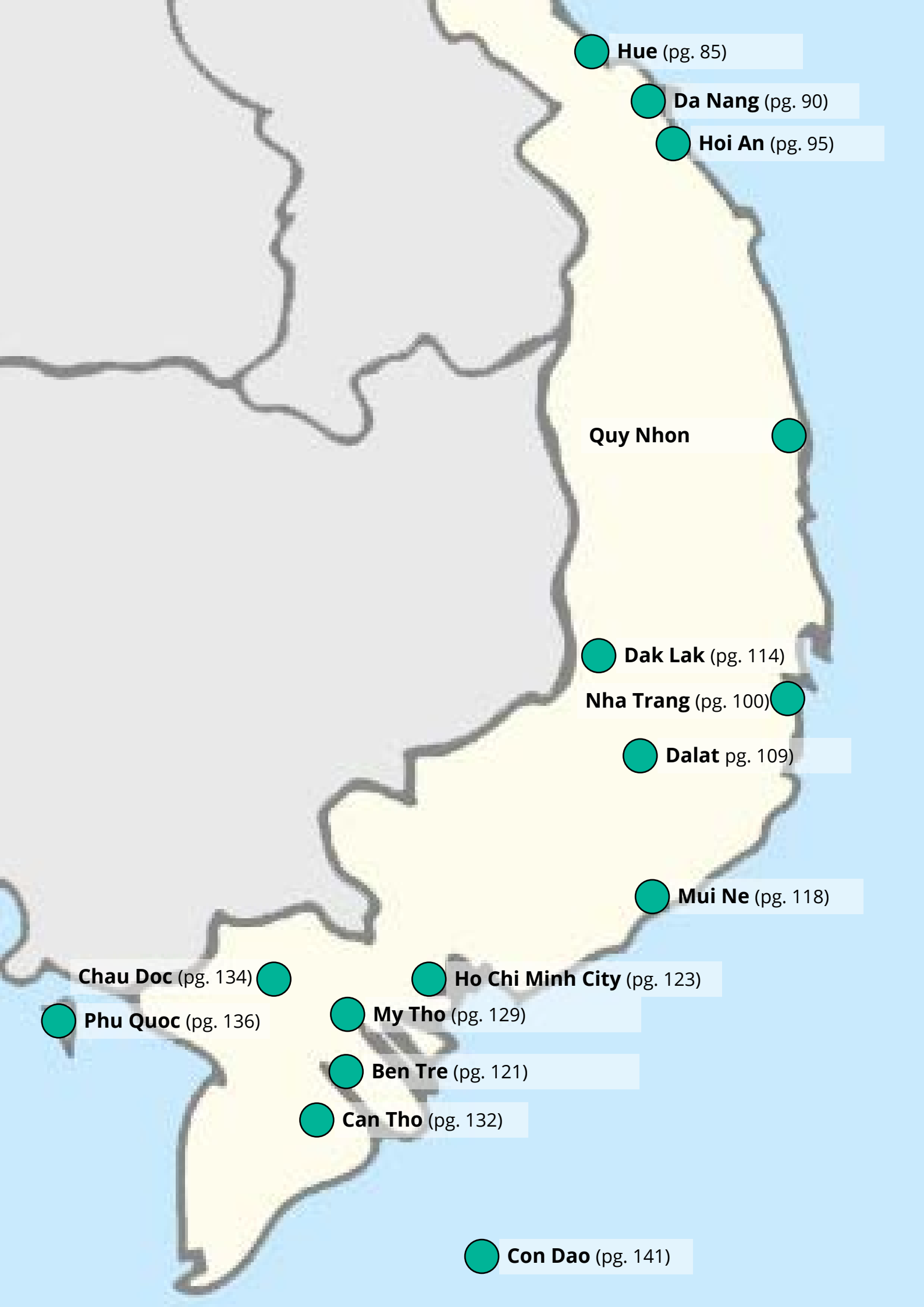
Serve Bien Phu
A bloody war has played out in this valley between the French and the Viet Minh.

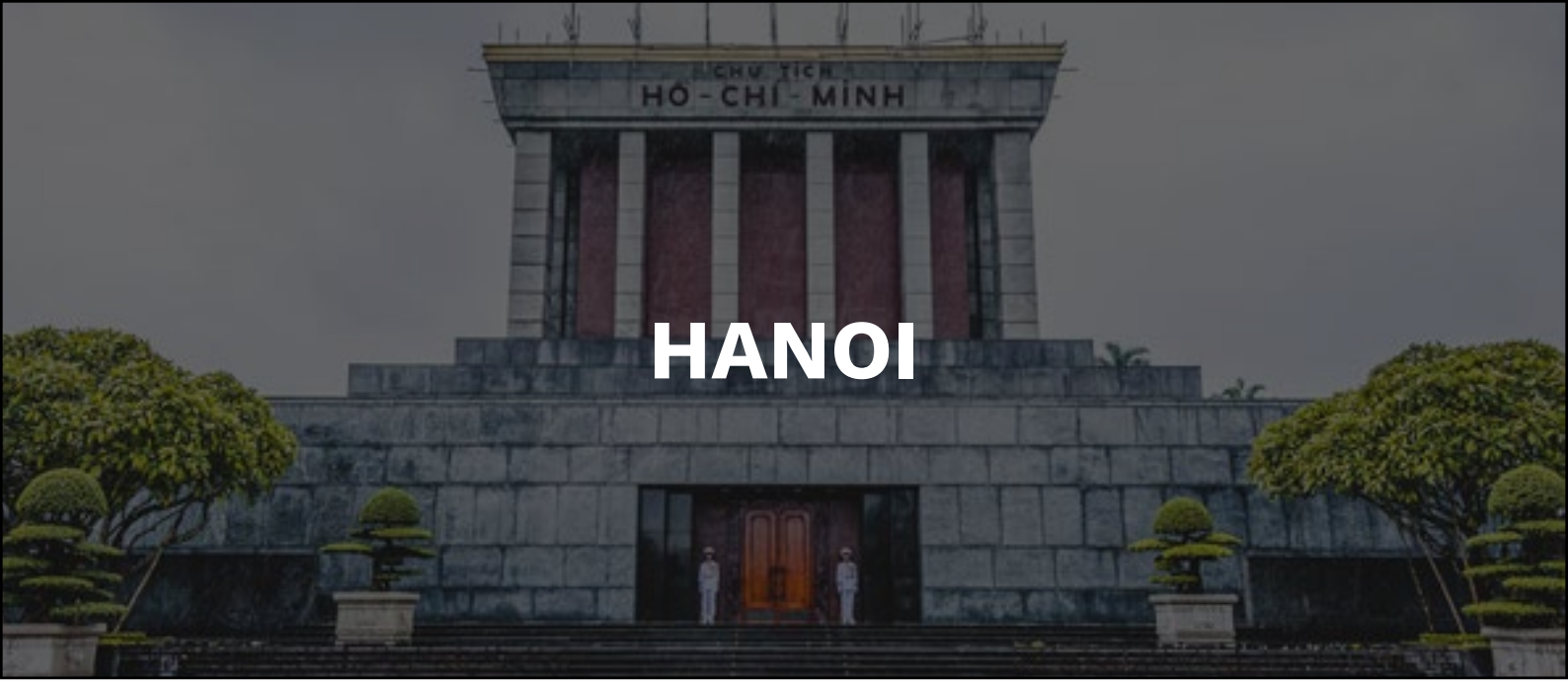
7. Con Dao
A notorious penal colony known as “Devil Island” full of prisons.

8. Phu Quoc
The prison was built by the French in 1949 and expanded by the Americans.

MAP OF VIETNAM




Hue (pg. 85)
Da Nang (pg. 90)
Hoi An (pg. 95)
Quy Nhon
Dak Lak (pg. 114)
Nha Trang (pg. 100)
Dalat pg. 109)
Mui Ne (pg. 118)
Chau Doc (pg. 134)
Ho Chi Minh City (pg. 123)
Phu Quoc (pg. 136)
My Tho (pg. 129)
Ben Tre (pg. 121)
Can Tho (pg. 132)
Con Dao (pg. 141)



HANOI

Hanoi is one of the oldest capitals in the world, where travelers can find well-preserved colonial buildings, ancient pagodas and unique museums in the center of the city. Hanoi still has a vibrant atmosphere. From the early hours until late at night, the streets swarm with moving motorcycles. You will find delicious food on every corner of the street. Don't forget that the peaceful countryside is a short drive away, with lush forests, green mountains and traditional villages, not to mention the iconic Halong Bay.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 2-3 days
You can see most of the sights in Hanoi in 2 days.

Best time to travel

- Fall (September - November) and Spring (March - April) are the two best seasons. Then the weather is pleasant with milder temperatures.
- Winter: During this period (December - February) it is quite cold in Hanoi when the temperatures can drop below 10 degrees.
- Summer: May - August is very hot in Hanoi, with July as the hottest month. A lot of rain can also fall.

Money
Hanoi has many ATMs. Changing money is often most beneficial at gold and jewelry stores. The rates in these stores are often surprisingly fair, at no extra cost.

Transport
Hanoi taxis have meters, but not all drivers want to use them. Use the Grab app to find drivers and see the price in advance.

Hanoi almost has a new metro network ready.

Cyclos are the bicycle taxis of Hanoi. Passengers ride in the front cabin, with the driver seated behind the passenger.

Xe Om are motorcycle taxis. You will find them mainly on street corners, but are also available in the Grab app.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Fly
Jetstar Airways, VietJet Air and Vietnam Airlines connect Hanoi to destinations all over Vietnam. Hanoi has fewer direct international flights than Ho Chi Minh City.

Bus
Hanoi has four major bus stations. Buses run from Hanoi to all over Vietnam, such as Sapa, Da Nang, Hue, Ninh Binh, Cao Bang and Ha Giang.

Train
The train station is in the center. You can buy tickets for trains that take you all the way south to Ho Chi Minh City, or north to Sapa and across the border into China.

RESTAURANTS

- **Bun Cha Ta** - Bun Cha is one of Hanoi's most popular dishes and is often eaten for lunch.
- **Hoang Cuisine** - Typical Vietnamese food of good quality.
- **Cha Ca La Vong Restaurant -** Serves only one dish: fried fish, served in a frying pan with vegetables and noodles and prepared according to an ancient recipe
- **Mama Rosa Restaurant** - Delicious pizza and pasta
- **Nha Hang Ngon** - Eating at communal tables and always busy with tourists and Vietnamese. Vietnamese specialties such as pancakes, salads and spring rolls.
- **The Hung Snake Restaurant -** Always wanted to try slang?
- **Madam Tran Restaurant**- Many Vietnamese dishes with plenty of vegetarian and vegan options.
- **Essence Restaurant** - Chic restaurant that is highly regarded. Often fully booked.

IN THE EVENING

Drinking beer on the street
What you really should have done is drink a bia hoi with the locals, or the cheapest beer in the world. Beer tents can be found all over the street, but the most popular spot is Bia Hoi Junction.

Attend shows
Another way to learn more about the local culture is to go to a show. The Hanoi Opera House has the AO Show and in the Thang Long theater you can watch traditional water puppet shows.

Hoan Kiem more
A walk along the illuminated Hoan Kiem lake should certainly not be missed. Locals come here to dance or exercise, young people to play games and students to practice English with tourists.

Bars & Clubs
The Old Quarter has plenty of bars and clubs for going out. Popular spots are Hero Club Hanoi, Savage bar, Craft Beer Pub and Dragonfly bar.

Weekend Night Market
Every weekend there is a night market with souvenirs, clothes and tasty dishes.

STAYING IN HANOI

Location

Hoan Kiem (Old Quarter) - The historical soul of the city, it is clear why most tourists stay here. Temples, old gates and traditional shops create a busy neighborhood that tickles all your senses! From luxury hotels to backpacker hostels, there is something for everyone. Hoan Kiem is the best area to stay in Hanoi if you want a convenient and cultural downtown experience!

Recommended accommodations

Hotel Sofitel Metropole From $311 Book via: booking.com

The most expensive hotel in Hanoi and is often fully booked. The hotel is housed in a renovated colonial building.

Hanoi Elegance Emerald Hotel From $71 Book via: booking.com

Centrally yet quiet. 21 comfortable rooms with a / c and bathroom.

Hanoi Golden Moment Hotel From $37 Book via: booking.com

Spacious and tidy rooms, right in the Old Quarter, but in a quiet area.

Hanoi La Siesta Hotel Trendy From $36 Book via: booking.com

Luxurious rooms, extensive breakfast in a quiet but good location.

Hanoi Holiday Diamond Hotel From $32 Book via: booking.com

Price compares favorably with other hotels in the more expensive budget class. Very popular, often fully booked

Luxury Backpackers From $9 Book via: booking.com

A hostel with very modern and luxurious rooms.

Central Backpackers Hostel – Old Quarter From $6 Book via: booking.com

Located in the center and one of the most popular hostels in Hanoi.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Walk through the Old Quarter

A fascinating part of the city where you can enjoy beautiful colonial architecture packed along narrow streets, with endless traffic of scooters zigzagging around merchants.

2. Water puppets show

The ancient art form of the water puppet show in Hanoi is certainly one of the best things to see. Dolls dance and glide elegantly across the water stage.





3. Hoan Kiem Lake

The lake is a central point in Hanoi and a popular meeting point for the locals. A temple is located on a small island in the lake and is connected by a bridge.

4. Drinking beer at Bia Hoi Junction

Several shop houses that have converted their entrances to street-side bars with plastic tables and stools. They serve fresh beer for only 0.30 cents.





5. Visit a museum

Good museums are Hoa Lo Prison, Ho Chi Minh Museum, Vietnamese Women's Museum, Vietnam Museum of Ethnology and Vietnam Fine Arts Museum.

6. Ho Chi Minh's Mausoleum

The final resting place of Ho Chi Minh, Vietnam's greatest and most popular leader ever.





7. Food tour

You will see street food everywhere in Hanoi. Go with a guide who will let you taste the best (and safe) food. Eat on a stool among the locals; amazing experience!

8. Imperial Citadel of Thang Long

The Imperial Citadel of Thang Long is one of the oldest sights in Hanoi and a beautiful remnant of Vietnam's history.





9. Visit a market

Visit the Hanoi Weekend Night market for a great atmosphere with lots of food or the famous flower market very early in the morning.

10. Hanoi Train Street

Walk on a stretch of track that cuts across a residential area. But beware, because there are still train drives here, right past the houses.



2 DAYS IN HANOI

Day 1

- Explore Old Quarter (optional by cyclo)
- Walk around Hoan Kiem Lake
- Watch a water puppet show
- Enjoy street food (per food tour)
- Have a beer at Bia Hoi Junction

Day 2

- Walk to Hanoi Cathedral
- Visit Hoa Lo Prison (Hanoi Hilton)
- Walk around the Temple of Literature
- Visit Ho Chi Minh Mausoleum
- Visit the imperial citadel
- Walk across the track in Hanoi train street
- Watch a show at the opera house



SAPA

Sapa is a small village located 350 km north of Hanoi, near the Chinese border. Sapa is known for having spectacular views of a rice field valley that can be seen on clear days, with mountains towering on all sides. The views of this epic landscape are often tempered by dense fog rolling over the peaks, but even when it is cloudy, the local hill tribes fill the city with color.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 2-3 days
You can see most of the sights in Sapa in 2 to 3 days, excluding travel time from Sapa.

Best time to visit

- The best time is from March to May and from September to November. During these times the weather is relatively stable with sunny days and cool nights.
- The view of the terraces of Sapa is at its best between September and October, when it is harvest season.

Money
There are ATMs in Sapa, but they don't always work well or have enough money. Many hotels and travel agencies can exchange euros and US dollars.

Transport
Trekking: The best way to explore the rice fields and villages is trekking.

Taxi: The price for a taxi in Sapa is almost the same as in Hanoi.

Walk: Places in the city of Sapa are easy to reach on foot as Sapa is small enough.

Motorbike: You can rent scooters and motorbikes to explore the area.

By tour: A comfortable way of traveling in Sapa is by tour. A guide will take you to the highlights in and around the city.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Bus
The bus from Hanoi to Sapa is the cheapest option. The advantage of a bus connection is that it goes directly to the city of Sapa, without stopping anywhere. Due to the newly constructed highway, this journey only takes about 5 hours.

Train
Many people who travel to Sapa choose the train because it is safe, comfortable, convenient and time-saving. However, the downside is that the train only takes you to Lao Cai station, from there you have to take a bus, minibus or taxi to Sapa (about 45 minutes).

RESTAURANTS

- **Moment Romantic Restaurant** - Popular restaurant with lots of choice and good food.
- **Little Vietnam Restaurant** - Extensive menu, friendly service and everything looks neat and tidy.
- **Anise Sapa Restaurant** - Another good restaurant with many choices.
- **Sapa Classic Vegan** - Very good vegan food
- **Good Morning View Restaurant** - Cozy restaurant serving both Vietnamese and European food.
- **Sapa Essence Restaurant** - Cozy restaurant serving both local and western food.

IN THE EVENING

Sapa is not known for its hectic nightlife. There are a few bars that provide a place to meet fellow travelers, have a few beers and play a game of pool. Most restaurants that sell beer and other beverages tend to close early in the evening.

- **Mountain Bar & Pub**: Cocktails, cold beer and games, this is the go-to bar for a night out.
- **Hmong Sisters**: A spacious bar with pool tables and a fireplace with great music.

STAYING IN SAPA

Where to stay

Cau May – Muong Hoa Street - Here you will find hostels, hotels and resorts. This area is usually more expensive than the other areas as the view is very nice.

Center of Sapa - Many options of quality hotels, from affordable to expensive luxury hotels.

Around the Lake - The cheapest place to book a room

Homestay - Great alternative to a hotel in the city itself. Stay with a local hill tribe among the rice fields, but don't expect much luxury.

Recommended accommodations

Silk Path Grand Resort From $80 Book via: booking.com

Beautiful hotel with spa. One of the more luxurious hotels in the city.

Eco Hills Homestay From $41 Book via: booking.com

Fantastically located outside Sapa, with bungalow style rooms on stilts.

Sapa Diamond Hotel From $34 Book via: booking.com

Very neat hotel, with a great view of the mountains.

Sapa Elite Hotel From $26 Book via: booking.com

Good location, near many restaurants. Neat rooms.

Phuong Nam Hotel From $18 Book via: booking.com

Centrally located near the center and nice view.

Valley View Homestay From $14 Book via: booking.com

Beautiful view, nice rooms and very affordable.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Trekking in Sapa

A trekking is without a doubt the highlight. There are many hill tribe villages to visit, with beautiful terraced rice fields along the way.

2. Mount Fansipan

The highest mountain in Vietnam with 3143 meters. If you want a challenge you can climb the mountain, but you can also take the cable car to the top.





3. Stay in a homestay

One of the most unique things you can do is stay in a homestay. Staying with a hill tribe means experiencing their life, their customs and traditions.

4. Tram Ton Pass

At 1900 meters, it is the highest mountain pass in Vietnam. Spectacular view from above.





5. Visit local markets

The place where you learn a lot about the hill tribes are the markets. Local people in traditional costumes trading livestock and local products. The most popular is Bac Ha market.

6. Discover waterfalls

The most popular are: Cat Cat waterfall, Silver waterfall (Thac Bac) and Love waterfall.





7. Rent a scooter

You can do it a scooter tour instead of a trekking. Visit various sights in Sapa and villages and rice fields beyond.

8. Visit local coffeshops

Take a break, enjoy the view or warm up when you visit Sapa in winter.





9. Moang Ho train

Vietnam's longest mountain railway between Sapa and the cable station to Fansipan Peak. Very spectacular with a viaduct, tunnels and great views.

10. Walk through Sapa Town

On Ham Rong Mountain you have a view over the entire city. Other places of interest in Sapa are the stone church and local market which gets very busy on weekends.



2 DAYS IN SAPA

Day 1

- Start the morning with a visit to the local market
- Go to Tram Ton pass and the Silver Waterfall
- Back in Sapa, take the train to the Fansipan cable car.
- Take the funicular up and enjoy the view (unless it's very cloudy).

Day 2

- Take a trekking through the rice fields
- When you have more time, make a 2-day trek, including a stay in a homestay



MU CANG CHAI

Mu Cang Chai is home to some of Asia's most beautiful cultivated topography. Rice terraces roll in ribbons around the hills to spectacular effect, attracting photographers, hikers and avid motorcyclists. Unlike Sapa or Ha Giang, Mu Cang Chai doesn't have much to do besides the terraced rice fields. But when the harvest season comes, it is very popular because who wouldn't want to see the most beautiful rice fields of Vietnam in the best season.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 2-3 days
Mu Cang Chai has no real sights outside the rice fields. Make a trekking of 2 days or rent a motorbike or car with driver to go around here.

Best time to visit

- The best time to travel to Mu Cang Chai is around mid-September to mid-October. This is the time of the harvest season, the period when the whole valley has yellow colored rice fields. The most suitable time is from September 15 to October 10 each year.
- The irrigation season is approximately between May and June. When the summer rains begin to pour over the mountain, the water is directed from the mountains onto the terraces. The dry ground is softened and prepared so that the rice can be planted. This is also the time when farmers start plowing for a new crop. Therefore, in the mountainous terraced fields, rice can only grow one crop per year. It is beautiful to see how the fields of water mirror the surroundings.

Money
There are no ATMs in the mountain areas and most accommodations are homestays that cannot handle credit card payments.

Getting around
The best way to explore the rice fields is with a trekking tour. You can opt for different day trips or multi-day trips, but in both cases it is highly recommended to walk with a local guide who knows the region.

Traveling in this region is very difficult, especially if you can't drive a motorbike. That is why most people opt for a tour. If you are an experienced motorcyclist, you can often rent a motorbike through your homestay. Keep in mind that the roads are not equally good everywhere and lead dangerously through the mountains.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

By tour
Both traveling to and traveling in Mu Cang Chai is not easy and that is why most tourists choose to take a tour here. It is also best to hike and trek with a local guide who can show you the roads and attractive routes.

Bus
There are direct buses from Hanoi to Mu Cang Chai. The price is from $10 and the ride takes almost 8 hours. There are also luxury minibuses starting at $14, which do the same journey in less than 6 hours.

Train
There are no direct trains from Hanoi to Mu Cang Chai. The closest and most convenient station is in Yen Bai. From here you can take the bus to Mu Cang Chai.

RESTAURANTS

There are only a few very local restaurants. You therefore always arrange meals at a homestay.

STAYING IN MU CANG CHAI

There are clean and simple hotels and restaurants in Mu Cang Chai town. For a unique and local experience, you can also stay in homestays spread over nearby villages.

Recommended accommodations

Mu Cang Chai Ecolodge From $28 Book via: booking.com

Located approximately 30 km from the city, it offers boutique bungalows and comfortable dormitories.

Hello Mu Cang Chai Homestay From $8 Book via: booking.com

This welcoming homestay is located in an impressive landscape with beautiful views.

Mu Cang Homestay From $7 Book via: booking.com

Very nice Homestay with a very sweet helpful family.

Indigenous homestay From $6 Book via: booking.com

Cozy family and a real local experience among the rice fields.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Trekking

The tunnels were used by the Vietcong to attack the Americans. Some of the Cu Chi Tunnels have been widened so that tourists can view them now.

2. Che Cu Nha

Che Cu Nha is the highest mountain with terraced rice fields. Here you will find very steep slopes and good views of the terraced rice fields.





3. La Pan Tan

The highlight is the terraced rice fields in Ta Pan Tan, located about 30 km from Mu Cang Chai and 5 km from Nga Ba Kim. These rice fields are ranked as one of the most beautiful in the world.

4. Sang Nhu – Horseshoe Hill

Sang Nhu Viewpoint is just 2 kilometers from Mu Cang Chai. The rice fields on Sang Nhu are best known for one hill called Horseshoe Hill or Horseshoe Hill - in the shape of a horseshoe.





5. Khau Pha Pass

The Khau Pha Pass is one of the most beautiful mountain passes in Northern Vietnam. Khau Pha is located right after the town of Tu Le and is more than 30 kilometers long. If you drive over this pass you will pass through an incredibly beautiful landscape.

6. Visit minority villages

Villages worth visiting are Ze Xu Phinh, Lim Thai, Sa Ren, Lim Mong and Hua Khat. Here you will find the real traditional life of the hill tribes, especially the Hmong minority.





7. Pu Nhu waterfall

The Pu Nhu waterfall is located near the village of Pu Nhu, about 10 kilometers away from the city of Mu Cang Chai. The waterfall is 20 meters high in an impressive rocky environment.

8. Mo (dream) waterfall

Mo waterfall is located between two cliffs. To get to the base of the waterfall you have to hike for about 30 minutes and if you want to see the amazing view from the 4th level of the waterfall you have to go a bit further.





9. Paragliding Festival

The annual paragliding festival takes place in September, organized by Vietwings Hanoi Club and the local government. Paragliding on Mu Cang Chai gives you the best view of the golden terraces below.

10. Riding a motorcycle

If you are experienced and adventurous, it is wonderful to drive through this area. Keep in mind that the roads are not of good quality everywhere.



2 DAYS IN MU CANG CHAI

Day 1

- Take a one day trek through the rice fields. Along the way, visit villages of local ethnic minorities and learn more about their culture.
- In the evening you will spend the night in a local homestay.

Day 2

- Visit some of Mu Cang Chai's famous viewpoints by car or motorbike, such as Horseshoe Hill, Che Cu Nha and La Pan Tan.



HALONG BAY

Halong Bay is one of the most famous spots in Vietnam and consists of a series of impressive lime-stone islands that are a UNESCO World Heritage Site. There are some 2000 islands in Halong Bay and many of them have beautiful lush vegetation, making them ideal for hiking. Many of the islands are also home to caves. The best way to explore Halong Bay is by cruise.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 2-3 days
Day trips from Hanoi are not recommended. The journey between Hanoi and Halong takes three hours. Hence it is best to opt for a 2 or 3-day cruise. In three-day cruises, you will continue to the quiet spots in the bay with fewer tourists.

Best time to visit

- The best time to visit Halong Bay is spring (March, April) and autumn (September, October). The weather is cool and you enjoy the best time of the year.
- Summer time lasts from May to early September as the bay is sunny and warm for swimming under a clear blue sky. There will be light rain on some days and even an unexpected typhoon that could cancel your cruise.
- Winter in Halong Bay lasts from November to March, leading to cold weather, especially in January and February; not ideal for swimming. The foggy days or the strong monsoon are also present in this period.

Getting around
The only option to see Halong Bay is by boat. There are day and multi-day boat trips, often by traditional junk.

The water in the bay is calm so you don't have to worry about seasickness.

An alternative is to visit Cat Ba Island, the largest island in Halong Bay. Here you can take bike rides and walks through the Cat Ba National Park.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

By organized tour
Almost all Halong Bay cruises include transportation to and from Hanoi.

Flights
There are seaplane flights between Hanoi and Halong.

Bus
There are buses and minibuses that run between Hanoi and Halong City. The journey takes about 3 hours.

There are also minibus connections between Halong and Ninh Binh.

RESTAURANTS

Each multi-day cruise features an onboard restaurant. Meals on board (breakfast, lunch and dinner) are also included in the price of the cruise.

Most boats also have a bar where you can enjoy drinks at your own expense.

NIGHTLIFE

Cruise boats often have activities in the evening, such as night fishing, karaoke, sunset cocktails and the very luxurious boats also have facilities such as a mini cinema and a spa.

STAYING IN HALONG BAY

Where to stay

Halong – The closest place in Vietnam. A huge area of limestone rocks and mountains rising out of the water. It is larger than Lan Ha Bay and Bai Tu Long Bay, but also by far the most visited. You have the most choice in boats, but take a good look at the programs. Some popular beaches and caves can become overcrowded with tourists.

Cat Ba & Lan Ha Bay - Lan Ha Bay is located around Halong's largest island, Cat Ba. With a stay on this island you can take day trips to Lan Ha Bay and hike through the national park. The landscape of Lan Ha Bay is similar to that of Halong Bay, but it is less visited.

Bai Tu Long Bay - It is about 30 km from Halong, but less visited as the bay is further away and the caves are less accessible. Bai Tu Long Bay is therefore very popular as an alternative to Halong Bay due to fewer boats and fewer tourists. The bay is smaller, but has similar views.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Cruise through Halong Bay

The best way to see Halong Bay is by cruise. There are many cruise boats operating, from budget options to luxury boats, with activities such as cooking classes, kayaking, and cave visits.

2. Sightseeing flight over the bay

Despite being quite expensive, a scenic seaplane flight over Halong Bay is one of the most exciting activities you can do.





3. Kayaking

With a kayak you can often get to hidden places that you can never reach with a boat. Most cruise boat trips have this included.

4. Floating Villages

Local residents have lived in floating houses for generations, as fishing is still the main income of the villagers. Visiting these villages is a fascinating experience.





5. Relax on beaches

There are several beautiful islands. Due to the steep nature, most of the islands are uninhabited and untouched by a human presence. Some of these islands also have beaches.

6. Explore Cat Ba Island

Halong Bay's largest island is a paradise for nature lovers and active travelers. Most of the island is a National Park with hiking trails and impressive lookouts.





7. Lan Ha Bay of Bai Tu Long Bay

Both similar to Halong Bay, only slightly smaller. The best part is that it is much less frequented by cruise boats, which automatically means less tourists and less pollution.

8. Exploring Caves

Among the thousands of jungle-covered peaks that rise from the waters of Halong Bay are a number of hidden caves. Around 60 caves have been discovered so far.





9. Beautiful viewpoints

To get a good picture of Halong Bay you have to look higher up. There are a number of viewpoints from which you have a great view. The most famous are Titop Island and Bai Tho.

10. Climbing

The bay is also one of the most majestic climbing areas in the world. It is a paradise for adventurous rock climbers as it has thousands of high limestone mountains here.





NINH BINH

Famous for its beautiful surroundings and incredible landscapes, from ancient temples to hidden caves and verdant rice paddies, Ninh Binh is one of the top destinations in Vietnam. It is also known as the Halong Bay on land.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 2-3 days
In the province of Ninh Binh there are many places of interest to do. It is also a beautiful area to rest for a day.

Best time to visit

- Best time to visit: From November to April you can enjoy fairly cool and dry weather, but bring something warm.
- May to October: The weather is warmer, more humid and the chance of rain is very high.

Money
There are a number of ATMs in Ninh Binh, but bring cash when exploring the countryside and into local villages.

Getting around
The most popular way to explore Ninh Binh is by bicycle. Most sights are within cycling distance of each other. The scenery between these sights is beautiful with rice fields and mountains. Bicycles and scooters can be rented at most hotels and hostels. The roads in the area are flat, so it's not tiring.

Taxi: Alternatively, you can hire a taxi or car with a driver to commute between the sights.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Bus
There are plenty of buses to and from Ninh Binh: Hanoi (2 hours), Halong City (4 hours), Hue (10 hours), Phong Nha (8 hours). Ninh Binh is also a stop for open tour buses between Hanoi and Hue.

Train
There is also a train station in Ninh Binh. You can reach from both Hanoi in the north and Hue in the south. There are a minimum of 4 trains per day for both directions. To Hanoi takes about 3 hours.

RESTAURANTS

- **Trung Tuyet** - The most popular restaurant in Ninh Binh, with arguably the best food. Prices from 40,000 VND.
- **Bamboo Bar and Restaurant** - Cozy restaurant and good service with typical Vietnamese food.
- **Chookie's** - Good value Vietnamese and western meals and cheap beer.
- **Family Restaurant** - Popular place for really local and good Vietnamese food.
- **Bao Anh Restaurant** - Another popular place with tasty meals and cheap beers. There is also a separate vegetarian menu.

STAYING IN NINH BINH

Where to stay

Ninh Binh city – Not recommended. There are many hotels and hostels for all budgets. You will also stay among many restaurants and close to the bus station and train station. However, you miss the rural atmosphere of the beautiful countryside.

Tam Coc – More rural location, with plenty of options for restaurants and closer to attractions than Ninh Binh town.

Trang An / Hoa Lu – Fewer restaurants around, but much quieter and nicer environment.

Recommended accommodations

Ninh Binh Hidden Charm Hotel & Resort From $84 Book via: booking.com

Very stylish resort with modern rooms.

Bai Dinh Garden Resort From $66 Book via: booking.com

Beautiful resort with bungalow style rooms. Good restaurant and swimming pool.

Trang An Retreat From $31 Book via: booking.com

Top rated accommodation. Good and beautiful location, with restaurant and swimming pool.

Tam Coc Holiday Hotel & Villa From $30 Book via: booking.com

Good location, nice bed, spacious bathroom with rain shower, nice pool.

Tam Coc Sunshine Homestay From $20 Book via: booking.com

A very helpful family with a homestay in a good location.

Trang An River View Homestay From $6 Book via: booking.com

Beautiful homestay with swimming pool. Popular among backpackers.

For You Homestay From $5 Book via: booking.com

Nice location, great views and a great pool.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Tam Coc

Take an amazing boat trip through the rice fields and mountains of Tam Coc. In this gentle two-hour tour you will also pass through a few caves.

2. Trang An

The most popular boat trip in Ninh Binh takes you down a river past the most impressive limestone mountains in the province. There are also a number of river caves.





3. Mua Cave

The best view of Ninh Binh can be found here. About 15 minutes of climbing takes you to a panoramic view at the top, over the river, mountains and rice fields.

4. Cuc Phuong National Park

One of the most important places of biodiversity in Vietnam and the largest nature reserve in the country. You can go cycling and hiking.





5. Cycling

The best way to see Ninh Binh is from the saddle of a bicycle. Between the steep mountains you will find a flat landscape, with paths between beautiful rice fields. Hotels offer free bicycles to borrow.

6. Van Long Nature Reserve

The largest wetland area in North Vietnam. The wildlife sanctuary is also home to many primate species, including the endangered Langur.





7. Hoa Lu

The city was the capital of Vietnam in the 10th and 11th centuries. Today, Hoa Lu is a cultural center full of ancient pagodas and citadels.

8. Bai Dinh Pagoda

The largest complex of temples in Southeast Asia and an important destination for religious pilgrimages.





9. Bich Dong Pagoda

A cluster of majestic mountain cave temples that grace the area. These ancient shrines and historic pagodas are scattered along the hillside.

10. Thung Nham Bird Garden

The park is mainly known for the many birds that live here. The best time to go is late afternoon or early morning before the birds leave.



2 DAYS IN NINH BINH

Day 1

- Mua Cave view point
- Cycling to next point
- Tam Coc boat trip
- Cycling to next point
- Bich Dong Pagoda

Day 2

- Trang An boat trip
- Cycling to next point
- Hoa Lu ancient capital
- Back to accommodation
- Van Long Nature Reserve in late afternoon (taxi)



MAI CHAU

Located in a rural valley with towering cliffs, Mai Chau offers a unique culture and relaxed atmosphere, only a three-hour drive from Hanoi. Spend the day exploring the local villages and cycling around the beautifully green rice paddies and enjoy traditional Tai dances in the evening.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here 2 days
If you don't plan to go to Pu Luong, two days are enough. Mai Chau does not have many sights, but it is very quiet and you can enjoy cycling.

Best time to visit
- Best time to visit: From December to May. The first 2 months it can still be cool, but after that it gets warmer. There is also little rain during this period.
- From November to February it is winter and the temperature can drop to 10 degrees.
- The rainy season is from June to September.

Money
There are a number of ATMs in Mai Chau, but sometimes hard to find. Take enough cash with you. Most hotels accept a bank card or credit card, but homestays often don't yet.

Getting around
Walking and cycling – The area is perfect to explore by bike or on foot. There is almost no traffic between the small villages.

Golf cart – Mai Chau and the various accommodations have electric golf carts that shuttle between the villages.

Car with driver or tour – If you want to go to Pu Luong or to the waterfall, caves and Hoa Binh lake, it is best to go with a car. Arrange a tour or a driver with car.

Rent a scooter – If you have experience driving you can also rent a scooter. If you want to go to Pu Luong, leave on time, because the distance and roads to this park take a lot of time.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Bus
Direct buses to Mai Chau depart from My Dinh bus station in Hanoi at 6:00 AM, 8:30 AM and 11:00 AM. The trip costs around 80,000-100,000 and takes between 3.5 and 4 hours. If you want to stay in the villages of Lac or Pom Coong, ask the bus driver to drop you off there. You will be dropped off at the crossroads, just a short walk from both villages.

A better alternative are the minibuses that pick you up directly from your hotel in Hanoi and bring you to your hotel in Mai Chau. Or arrange your private transfer from Hanoi.

Direct transfer to your hotel is also included in most tours from Hanoi. This is therefore a popular option.

RESTAURANTS

There are a few restaurants. You often eat at your homestay or hotel. Food at a homestay is often included in the price and the food is great. There is then no menu; classic country dishes are served from a set menu for lunch and dinner.

- **Quan 3 Chi Em** - Well made Vietnamese food, in a small cozy family restaurant.
- **Sunset Bar** - The best restaurant to come for sunset, overlooking the rice fields.

STAYING IN MAI CHAU

Where to stay

Lac and Pom Coong – These are the two most popular villages where tourists stay. Most accommodations consist of homestays, but there are also a few hotels and luxury resorts. The villages are right next to each other and you will find shops and a few restaurants.

Recommended accommodations

Mai Chau Ecolodge From $93 Book via: booking.com

The most famous and luxurious resort in Mai Chau. Often fully booked.

Maichau HideAway From $80 Book via: booking.com

Luxury rooms. Great location for rest and relaxation by a huge lake but away from the rice fields.

Mai Chau Nature Lodge From $35 Book via: booking.com

Nice bungalows with direct view on the rice fields.

Mai Chau Valley View Hotel From $33 Book via: booking.com

Nice hotel with good rooms and a view of the rice fields.

Mai Chau Countryside Homestay From $5 Book via: booking.com

Simple but attractive homestay, including bungalows on stilts.

Little Mai Chau Home Stay From $5 Book via: booking.com

Unique location against a mountain and surrounded by rice fields. Bungalow style rooms and a dorm.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Pu Luong Nature Reserve

Vietnam's hidden paradise. In this beautiful landscape you will find beautiful rice terraces that are submerged by water wheels made of bamboo.

2. Thung Khe pass

From this mountain pass you have a great view over the Mai Chau valley. You can go there with a tour or rent a scooter yourself and drive over this pass, but be careful.





3. Cycling through the valley

The flat valley is best explored by bicycle. Cycle between the rice fields and explore villages of ethnic minorities. You can go on a tour or borrow bicycles for free from your accommodation.

4. DExplore villages

With stilt houses and lush, green rice paddies, the villages in Mai Chau are picturesque and serene. This is where ethnic Thai minorities live who are very hospitable.





5. Watch a traditional show

Every evening there are traditional dance shows performed by the locals at various hotels, homestays and resorts.

6. Climbing

The most adventurous activity you can do in Mai Chau is rock climbing. Climb up to have a beautiful view over the Mai Chau valley.





7. Staying in a homestay

One of the best things you can do in Mai Chau is to stay in a homestay of a local ethnic minority. You will learn more about their culture and traditions here.

8. Go Lao Waterfall

About 20 meters high and located in a beautiful setting. After you descend the unpaved stairs you are next to the waterfall and you can even swim there.





9. Explore the caves of Mai Chau

The shape of Mai Chau's mountains comes from karst limestone soils. You will find many caves in this type of mountain range. The two largest are Mo Luong Cave and Chieu Cave.

10. Hoa Binh Lake

It is the largest lake in Vietnam, with 47 large and small islands. You can rent a boat to explore the lake.



2 DAYS IN MAI CHAU

Day 1

- The first day is a day of relaxation. Rent a bicycle and explore the Mai Chau valley. Drive through peaceful villages, past rice paddies and see how the locals live.
- In the evening you watch a traditional show

Day 2

- Visit the highlight of Mai Chau: Pu Luong Nature Reserve. Plan an organized trekking or day tour by motorcycle or car through this area.



MOC CHAU

Moc Chau is a dreamy region of the northern mountainous region. The area has beautiful traditional villages of Vietnamese hill tribes and is best known for the many beautiful flowers, ranging from plum blossom to cherry blossoms. There are also many hills with tea plantations where mainly young Vietnamese tourists come to take pictures.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here 2 days
Moc Chau does not have a lot of sights. For that reason you can see all the highlights within 2 days. If you want to make a trekking to Pha Luong or Ta Xua, you should plan more time for this region.

Best time to visit
- Between February and March, the peach blossom and plum blossom season blooms.
- Around March is the time when white orchids bloom and on March 26 there is also the Hết Chá festival.

Money
There are ATMs in Moc Chau, but when you explore the area you should bring cash.

Getting around
If you want to explore the area around Moc Chau you need to rent a motorbike or car with driver. Most hotels and homestays offer motorbike rentals with the average price of $10 per day. Often they can also help you arrange a car or you can arrange it in advance via localvietnam.nl.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Bus
The distance between Hanoi and Moc Chau is 190 km, so it takes about 4-5 hours to get there. A number of buses depart every day to Moc Chau. Most start from My Dinh bus station in Hanoi. Also all buses to Son La and Dien Bien always go through Moc Chau.

A number of minibus operators can pick up travelers from the center (Old Quarter). Another option is to arrange a car with a private driver.

RESTAURANTS

There are plenty of restaurants in Moc Chau. Many ethnics minorities live in Moc Chau-Son La; therefore, the cuisine in the northwest is very diverse, abundant and unique. If you stay in a homestay, you can book meals with traditional food from ethnic minorities and enjoy performances in some villages.

STAYING IN MOC CHAU

Where to stay

Moc Chau has two spots; Moc Chau Town and Moc Chau Farm Town. Both have a number of hotels to choose from.

Recommended accommodations

Muong Thanh Holiday Moc Chau From $50 Book via: booking.com

Not a cozy rural hotel, but very modern and luxurious if you need it.

Stella Moc Chau Hotel From $31 Book via: booking.com

Beautiful accommodation in an authentic wooden chalet with swimming pool.

House by Lake From $17 Book via: booking.com

Cute bungalows on a river with a large garden.

The November - Moc Chau From $15 Book via: booking.com

Nice place with nice bungalows, with space to sit outside and inside.

Homestay Moc Chau From $4 Book via: booking.com

Simple rooms, but located directly between the tea plantations.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Tea plantations

Some major tea plantations can be found in Chi Lon Village, Doi Che Trai Tim, about 20 km north of the city. The best known are found in the Dai-loan area and the Tan-Lap area.

2. Flower fields

From the end of October to the beginning of November is the time when white mustard flowers are in bloom. The places where you can see this are Ba Phach Village, Thong Cuong Village and Pipe Hill in Ang Village.





3. Pha Luong

This 2000 meter high mountain is the roof of the region and a much photographed place. The trekking to the top is mainly for the adventurous traveler.

4. Ta Xua

Known for a special phenomenon around the mountains: the formation of thick clouds, which makes you feel like you are in the sky. It is hardly visited by foreign tourists.





5. Dai Yem waterfall

Dai Yem Waterfall is most beautiful from April to September. In the rainy season, a large amount of water flows into the waterfall.

6. Ban Ang pine forest

The forest has a natural lake with an area of five hectares, surrounded by green pine forests.





7. Hang Doi (Bat Cave)

The cave is remarkable with strange stalactites and a winding path leading to it.

8. Stay in a homestay

You can stay in a homestay of a local ethnic minority, but you can also choose to stay in a modern homestay in a beautiful location.





9. Visit local villages

Moc Chau has a unique culture of ethnic minorities; mainly Hmong and Thai. Recommended places are Long Luong, Pa Phach Village, Thung Cuong Village and Na Ka Plum Valley.

10. Chieng Khoa waterfall

A small waterfall that hasn't been put into touristic activity yet, so it's quite wild and natural.



2 DAYS IN MOC CHAU

Day 1

- Explore the beautiful surroundings of Moc Chau. Visit some tea plantations, flower fields, pine forest and Hang Dơi cave.

Day 2

- Take the motorbike or car towards Pha Luong, 33km from Moc Chau Town. Hike up the mountain and don't forget to bring your passport which you have to show at the police station as you are very close to the border of Laos. Enjoy the great view.
- On the way back, visit the Dai Yem waterfall.



HA GIANG

Ha Giang Province is one of the most adventurous destinations in the country. Filled with beautiful karst mountains, steep mountain passes, winding roads and misty villages. The province is home to a great diversity of local ethnic minorities who still preserve their traditional culture and lifestyle. The remote areas of Ha Giang offer an experience like no other, the cultural diversity and unique, beautiful landscapes remain pure and authentic.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here 3-5 days
If you're short on time, you can do the run in 3 days. But 4 or 5 days is recommended, because you don't want to rush Ha Giang, as this is the most impressive region of Vietnam.

Best time to visit
Ha Giang is a good place to visit almost any time of the year. The warm and rainy season runs from April to October. The cold and dry season starts in November and ends in March.

Money
ATMs are available in Ha Giang Town and Dong Van. Take enough cash with you when going into remote villages.

Getting around
Ha Giang is a huge province. Unlike other destinations in Vietnam, you don't visit this region from one central point, but move yourself to a different place every day, visiting sights along the way. This entire route is a walk that you can do in 3 to 5 days.

You can do this loop in three ways:

- Car with driver: comfortable and protected against the elements.
- On the back of the bike: Less comfortable, but the sense of adventure is great. In addition, you can easily stop on roads where cars can't go and see a lot more.
- Self-driving on a motorbike: Lots of freedom and a great sense of adventure. Please note that driving in Vietnam and through the mountains is not without danger. In addition, you are not fully insured in an accident without the right documents; IDP or Vietnamese driver's license.

START THE LOOP

You start the loop in Ha Giang City. Tours where you go by car and driver or on the back of the motorcycle can be arranged through Local Vietnam. If you want to drive yourself, you can contact the following rental companies:

- QT Motorbikes and Tours (website)
- Mama's Homestay (website)
- Ha Giang Amazing Hostel (website)
- Ha Giang Chopai Hostel (website)
- Rentabike Vietnam (website)

HA GIANG LOOP ROUTE

3 dagen Ha Giang loop

- Day 1 (126 km): Ha Giang City – Quan Ba Pass -Yen Minh town – Tham Ma Pass – Sa Phin [map]
- Day 2 (45 km): Sa Phin – Dong Van Old Town – Ma Pi Leng Pass – Meo Vac [map]
- Dag 3 (145 km): Meo Vac – Mau Due – Du Gia – Ha Giang [map] of (159 km) Meo Vac – Mau Due – Yen Minh – Quan Ba – Ha Giang [map]

4 dagen Ha Giang loop

- Day 1 (112 km): Ha Giang City – Quan Ba Pass – Lung Khuy Cave – Yen Minh town [map]
- Day 2 (86 km): Yen Minh town – Tham Ma Pass – Sa Phin – H'Mong King Palace – Lung Cu Flag Post – Dong Van town [map]
- Dag 3 (101 km): Dong Van town – Ma Pi Leng Pass – Meo Vac – Mau Due – Du Gia [map]
- Dag 4 (73 km): Du Gia – Ha Giang City [map]

5 dagen Ha Giang loop

- Day 1 (112 km): Ha Giang City – Quan Ba Pass – Lung Khuy Cave – Yen Minh town [map]
- Day 2 (60 km): Yen Minh town – Tham Ma Pass – Sa Phin – H'Mong King Palace – Lung Cu Flag Post [map]
- Dag 3 (53 km): Lung Cu – Dong Van town – Ma Pi Leng Pass – Meo Vac [map]
- Dag 4 (73 km): Meo Vac – Mau Due – Du Gia [map]
- Dag 5 (73 km): Du Gia – Ha Giang City [map]

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Bus

In Hanoi you can take a sleeper bus to Ha Giang from the Mỹ Đình bus station. Buses depart almost every hour from 4:30 AM to 1:30 PM. The night buses depart between 6:00 PM and 9:30 PM. The ticket costs around 200,000 dong. The bus takes about 7 to 8 hours.

There are also luxury vans that run both during the day and at night and pick up from the center. For those on a tighter schedule or traveling with a small group, the best option is to arrange private transportation or go on a tour from Hanoi.

Hoang Su Phi – If you want to go to Hoang Su Phi, it is best to go with a tour. With public transport it is very inconvenient to get here and also to go around. If you are an experienced motorcyclist you can alternatively rent a motorbike and drive here

STAYING IN HA GIANG

Hotels en homestays in Ha Giang City

Ha Giang Historic Hotel Book via: booking.com

Best hotel in town. Great location, nice garden, clean rooms and tasty family dinner.

Ha Giang 1 Hostel Book via: booking.com

Rated as best hostel in Ha Giang City. Nice staff and great atmosphere.

Ha Giang Riverside Hostel Book via: booking.com

Rooms are ok but the location is great along the river and close to the bus stop.

Hotels en homestays in Yen Minh

Homestay BongBang Book via: booking.com

Best place to stay in Yen Minh. Great soft beds, good atmosphere with family dinner and campfire at night. Staff speaks English.

Hà Anh Homestay Book via: booking.com

A nice family dinner and the hostel has a good social atmosphere. The staff are very friendly and helpful.

Hotels en homestays in Lung Cu

Sister's House Book via: booking.com

The rooms at this homestay are very basic, but there is a large communal area with a pool table. Also the family is very friendly.

Lolo Eco House Book via: booking.com

For a real local experience, stay here. Beautiful traditional house which is very nicely located. Run by an ethnic minority who provide good service.

Hotels en homestays in Dong Van

Green Karst Hostel & Bar Book via: booking.com

Clean and comfortable, close to restaurants and bars. Everything you need after a long day of driving.

Hoang Ngoc Hotel Book via: booking.com

One of the better hotels in Dong Van. Room is clean and tidy. Located in the center of town, close to restaurants.

Triệu Nghị homestay Book via: booking.com

A favorite for many backpackers following the Ha Giang loop. Friendly family and good dinner.

Lam Tung Hotel Book via: booking.com

Very decent hotel right in the center of the city, with nice rooms.

Binh Minh Hostel Book via: booking.com

Located in the city. Nice big room with clean bathroom. Perfect for an overnight stay during the course. Plenty of food options nearby.

Hotels en homestays in Meo Vac

Little Yen's Homestay Book via: booking.com

One of the top rated homestays in the loop. Staff speak good English and great atmosphere.

Ong Vang Meo Vac Hotel Book via: booking.com

Nice location, quiet and relaxing. Rooms are small but clean.

Hotels en homestays in Du Gia

Panorama Homestay

Comfortable and local. The best accommodation in the village. Great atmosphere, perfect location with great view.

Du Gia homestay Book via: booking.com

The first homestay in Du Gia. Nicely located and good atmosphere in an old traditional stilt house.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Ha Giang Loop

The best way to discover Ha Giang is by car or motorcycle. The most impressive places along the way are the Ma Pi Leng Pass, Quan Ba Pass and Dong Van Geopark.

2. Hoang Su Phi

Hoang Su Phi is one of the most beautiful rice fields in Vietnam. It is also the least visited region in Ha Giang, mainly because it is difficult to access.





3. Khau Vai Love Market

This market is also only once a year around April. The people who come here don't sell or buy any goods. Instead, it is the dating site for ex lovers.

4. Local markets

Meo Vac Market is the largest market in the region, but others are Dong Van Market and Sa Phin Market. Here hill tribes come together in traditional clothing with many and local products.





5. Chieu Lau Thi Mountain

The third highest mountain in Vietnam and the second highest mountain in Ha Giang. The climb is tough and exhausting, but you will be rewarded with a beautiful view.

6. Lung Cu

The Lan Cu flagpole is located on Dragon Mountain (Long Son), in the northernmost tip of Vietnam, a few kilometers from the border of China.





7. Hmong Kings' Palace

In 1902, with the consent of the French colonial rulers, Chinese merchants built a wooden palace. Two Hmong kings ruled from here.

8. Noong lake

When you visit the lake, you can not only enjoy the wild nature, but you can also learn more about the customs, culture and daily life of the ethnic groups.





9. Nho Que rivier

There are epic views from Ma Pi Leng pass over the Nho Que River. At some mating spots you can also drive down to the river bank via zigzagging roads.

10. Trekking through villages

With these local villages, forests and mountains with great views, Ha Giang is a very nice place for a trekking. You will encounter little to no other tourists.





CAO BANG

Tucked away in a remote area of Northern Vietnam, Cao Bang Province is bursting with beautiful geo-cultural sites. With five major river systems and 47 lakes, water plays a vital role in shaping the landscape and local life. Much of Cao Bang is protected as a UNESCO Global Geopark. The province's extraordinary diversity makes it a spectacular place to explore, especially for adventure travellers, culminating in the Ban Gioc Waterfall.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here 2-4 days
If you only come for Ban Gioc, you will have seen Cao Bang within a day. If you have time, take a few days to see one of the most beautiful landscapes of Vietnam..

Best time to visit

- In general, the cool climate of Cao Bang province is suitable for tourism all year round. However, due to the beautiful scenery of forests, mountains and natural destinations, you should be here in the spring season, from February to May, to avoid heavy rainfall.
- The best time to visit Ban Gioc Waterfall is from May to September when it rains sometimes so you can see a big waterfall.

Money
In the city of Cao Bang you have ATMs. If you are going to explore the area, it is useful to bring cash with you.

Getting around
Cao bang is a huge province. The only way to see it properly is by car or motorcycle. You can explore Cao Bang by tour or rent a car with a driver yourself. Motorbikes can be rented in Cao Bang city, but if you have no experience with self-driving, it is best to ride on the back of an experienced guide.

From Cao Bang City to Ban Gioc
The only way is to travel by bus or motorbike. There are some local buses in Cao Bang city, for an up-to-date schedule it is recommended to ask at the bus station or your hotel. If you can, rent a motorbike in Cao Bang city and travel and explore this very beautiful area for yourself.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Bus
Several bus companies have buses from Hanoi (My Dinh or Gia Lam bus station) to Cao Bang. There are morning and night buses from Hanoi to Cao Bang, with a ticket price of about 160,000 – 200,000 VND, and it takes about 6-8 hours. There are also more luxurious minibuses that depart from the center of Hanoi.

Tour
Because Cao Bang is difficult to access, most travelers choose to visit this province by tour. However, many tours only go to the Ban Gioc waterfalls in combination with Ba be lake and do not drive through the beautiful mountains of this province.

STAYING IN CAO BANG

Cao Bang city offers many options of different accommodations – hotels, homestays and guest houses. It is no problem to book some of these accommodations online. You can also find some accommodation around the Ban Gioc Falls area.

Recommended accommodations

Lan homestay From $4 Book via: booking.com

Traditional homestay on stilts near Ban Gioc waterfall. Beautifully situated between the mountains and a river right in front of the homestay.

Khuoi Khon homestay From $6 Book via: Airbnb

Beautiful homestay with impressive views, located in an authentic village of the Black Lo Lo ethnic minority near Bao Lac.

Jeanne Hotel From $18 Book via: booking.com

Hotel located in the center of Cao Bang city. Good service and great looking rooms.

Max Boutique Hotel From $29 Book via: booking.com

Great hotel with comfortable beds and nicely furnished rooms in Cao Bang city.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Ban Gioc waterfall

The absolute highlight of Cao Bang is the Ban Gioc waterfall, the most impressive waterfall in Vietnam on the border with China.

2. Phong Nam valley

The Phong Nam valley is a fairytale-like valley, with high mountains, vast rice fields and a magical river that flows through the valley.





3. Nui Thung mountain

This mountain is also called the Eye of an Angel. It is a beautiful location in the mountain area of Cao Bang.

4. Me Pja Pass

The Me Pja Pass is also called “the mountain pass with 14 bends” in Vietnamese.





5. Cao Bang Pass

You will find this mountain pass when you drive from Cao Bang city to Bao Lac. Similar mountain ranges as Ha Giang province can be found here.

6. Thang Hen lake

This lake is hidden among the mountains far from the beaten track. You can combine this lake well with the Nui Thung mountain.





7. Phia Oac – Phia Den

A special forest and with a peak of 1,931 meters high, Phia Oac is the roof of Cao Bang province and northeastern Vietnam. Phia Oac also sometimes has snow which creates a unique vegetation for this country.

8. Phat Tich Truc Lam Ban Gioc Pagoda

The first pagoda built in the northern border of the country, on Mount Phia Nhu, about 500 meters from Ban Gioc Waterfall. From the pagoda you can see the whole Ban Gioc waterfall.





9. Nguom Ngao cave

This is a large cave formed from limestone. The system of stalactites and stalagmites has created an extremely beautiful and interesting landscape.

10. Pac Po Relic

Here is where Ho Chi Minh worked on North Vietnam's revolution. He chose Cao Bang because most people were on his side and Cao Bang borders China.



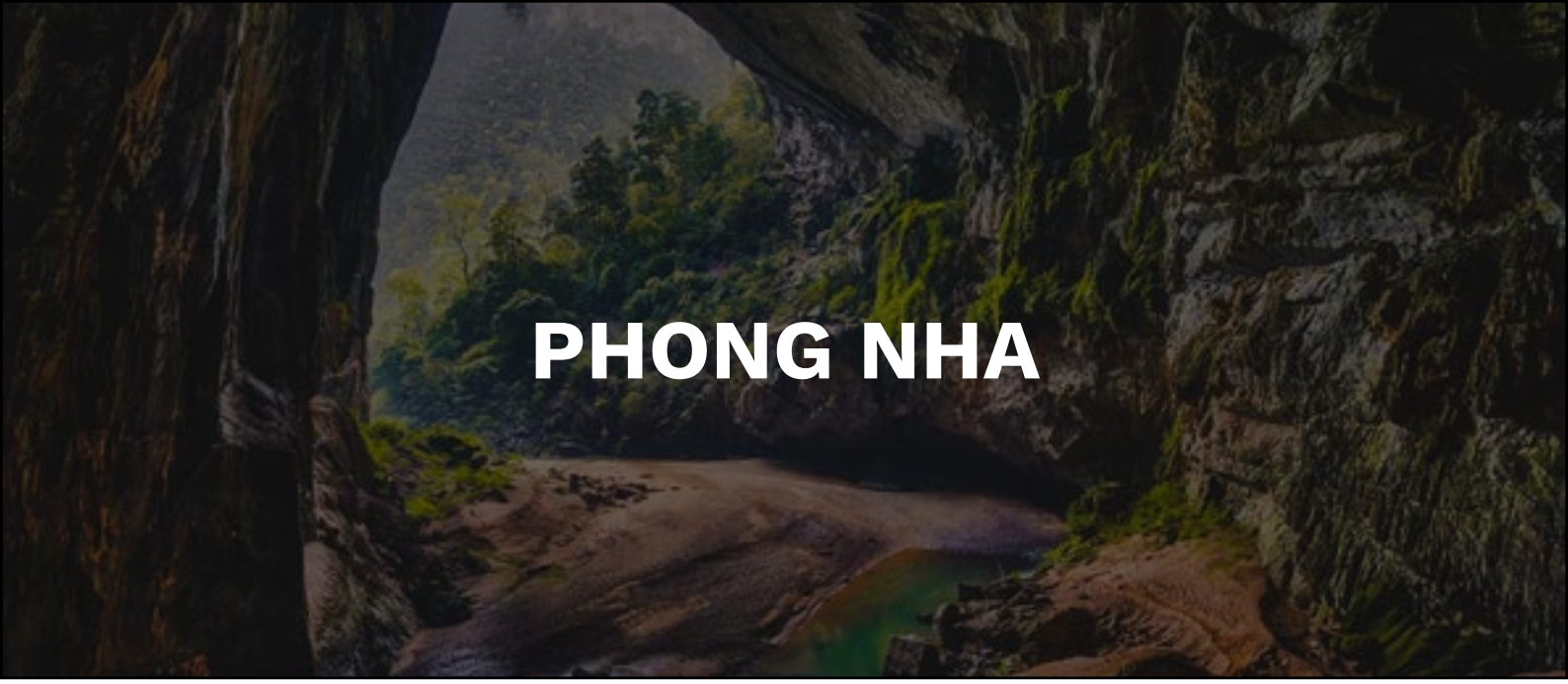
2 DAYS IN CAO BANG

Day 1

- From Cao Bang City to Ban Gioc Waterfalls
- Behold the huge waterfalls
- Visit the Ban Gioc Pagoda
- Walk through the Nguom Ngao cave

Day 2

- Explore the beautiful Phong Nam Valley
- Climb to the viewpoint
- On the way to Cao Bang city you go to Nui Thung mountain and Thang Hen lake



PHONG NHA

Phong Nha Ke Bang National Park is an impressive place where you will find the largest cave in the world, Son Doong. Mountains, lakes, caves, jungles and exotic wildlife, this destination has it all. Phong Nha is a paradise for adventurers. Colossal caves may be the main draw, but linger longer and Phong Nha reveals hiking trails, secluded country lanes and rivers perfect for kayaking.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 2-3 days
Phong Nha is a region where you can plan a day full of activities as well as relax by the pool with great views. In addition, there are also cave expeditions that last 2 to 4 days.

Best time to visit

- Best time to travel: From June to August. These are also the hottest months.
- December to February: These months can be considerably colder.
- The flood season is normally from mid-September to mid-November each year and is periodic and not continuous. Be sure to check the weather forecast before traveling to Phong Nha. Severe flooding affects tour availability.

Money
There is an ATM in Son Trach, but it is wise to bring enough Vietnamese dong with you.

Getting around
Motorbike: Easily drive around the national park by yourself, but not recommended for inexperienced drivers.

Easy Rider: You hop on the back of a motorbike driven by a local guide, and they show you the best of what Phong Nha has to offer.

Tour: In fact, in many cases it is the only way to see some parts of the National Park, especially the caves.

Private Transport: If you are with a family, or just want to keep things really easy, it is possible to hire cars and minibuses with a driver to take you to all the local tourist destinations.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Bus
There are three major bus companies that operate night buses to Phong Nha from Hanoi, Hue, Hoi An and Da Nang: Hung Thanh, Queen Café and Camel Travel. Tickets can be obtained from all hotels and hostels in every major city in Vietnam.

Train
The nearest railway station is in Dong Hoi. The train tickets can be booked at the train station or online. Dong Hoi Railway Station is about 1.5 km from the bus terminal. From Dong Hoi you can take a taxi or bus to Phong Nha (Son Trach).

Flights
A slightly more expensive way to travel to Phong Nha is to take the plane to Dong Hoi and then travel to Phong Nha by bus or taxi.

RESTAURANTS

- **Phong Nha Veggie Box** - The best choice if you want to eat vegetarian.
- **Phong Nha Underground** - Lots of western food on the menu, such as burgers and pastas
- **Nguyen Shack Art Restaurant** - Good food and above all a lovely place to hang out
- **Phong Nha Bamboo Cafe** - Good food and extensive menu with Vietnamese and Western dishes

NIGHTLIFE

- **Jungle Bar**: Easy Tiger hostel's bar is the liveliest place in Son Trach, with cheap beer, pool tables and live music a few nights a week.
- **East Hill:** Located on a hill, this bar is a relaxed place to watch the sunset and have a beer.
- **Bomb Crater Bar**: A small bar on the river between Phong Nha and Bong Lai.
- **Andy Bar & Disco**: Opens at 11pm when the Easy Tiger closes. Music and drink. Free shuttle from Easy Tiger.

STAYING IN PHONG NHA

Where to stay

Son Trach (Phong Nha Town) - The gateway to the Phong Nha-Ke Bang National Park. Sandwiched between the huge karst mountains and the Son River. You will find some decent hostels, 2 – 3 star hotels, new budget accommodations and small family-related homestays that offer a more personal experience.

Recommended accommodations

Victory Road Villas From $68 Book via: booking.com

Very modern and luxurious rooms

Phong Nha Lake House Resort From $42 Book via: booking.com

Beautiful location next to a lake with lovely rooms.

Jungle Boss Homestay From $30 Book via: booking.com

Nice homestay with swimming pool and free bicycles to borrow.

Son Doong Riverside From $12 Book via: booking.com

Good rooms, good service.

Phong Nha Hillside View Bungalow From $12 Book via: booking.com

Comfortable bungalows with a swimming pool, just outside the town.

Easy Tiger Hostel From $11 Book via: booking.com

Nice and big hostel. Live music every night in the large common room. Easy to meet other people.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Hang Son Doong Cave

The largest cave in the world with its own ecosystem with a rainforest of trees up to 30 meters high, its own population of bats, birds and monkeys.

2. Paradise Cave

The largest cave in the world with its own ecosystem with a rainforest of trees up to 30 meters high, its own population of bats, birds and monkeys.





3. Phong Nha Cave

With a length of 7,729 meters it is the longest underground river in the world. You can take a boat trip through this cave.

4. Dark Cave

One big adventure; zipline from a tower to the cave entrance, to go barefoot with helmet and headlamp through the mud cave in the dark including a mud bath.





5. Hang En Cave

This cave is one of the most photogenic caves in the national park. The wide entrance opens directly into the lush jungle and light shafts illuminate a sandy lake.

6. Tu Lan Cave

Another adventurous cave, with underground waterfalls, green lakes, beautiful stalagmites and stalactites. In a 2 or 3 day trip you will swim, climb and abseil.





7. Hang Va Cave

You need to be quite fit to explore this cave, walking over rocks, swimming through underground rivers and climbing. This cave is for the more adventurous traveler.

8. Tien Song Cave

The oldest discovered cave in the region is often skipped as it is very similar to Phong Nha Cave. Tien Son Cave is also 100 meters above Phong Nha Cave.





9. Tra Ang Cave

A fascinating part of the city where you can enjoy beautiful colonial architecture packed along narrow streets, with endless traffic of scooters, zigzagging around merchants.

10. Pygmy Cave

This cave has only just been opened to tourists and that is why there have really only been a few tourists. It is said to be the fifth largest cave in the world.



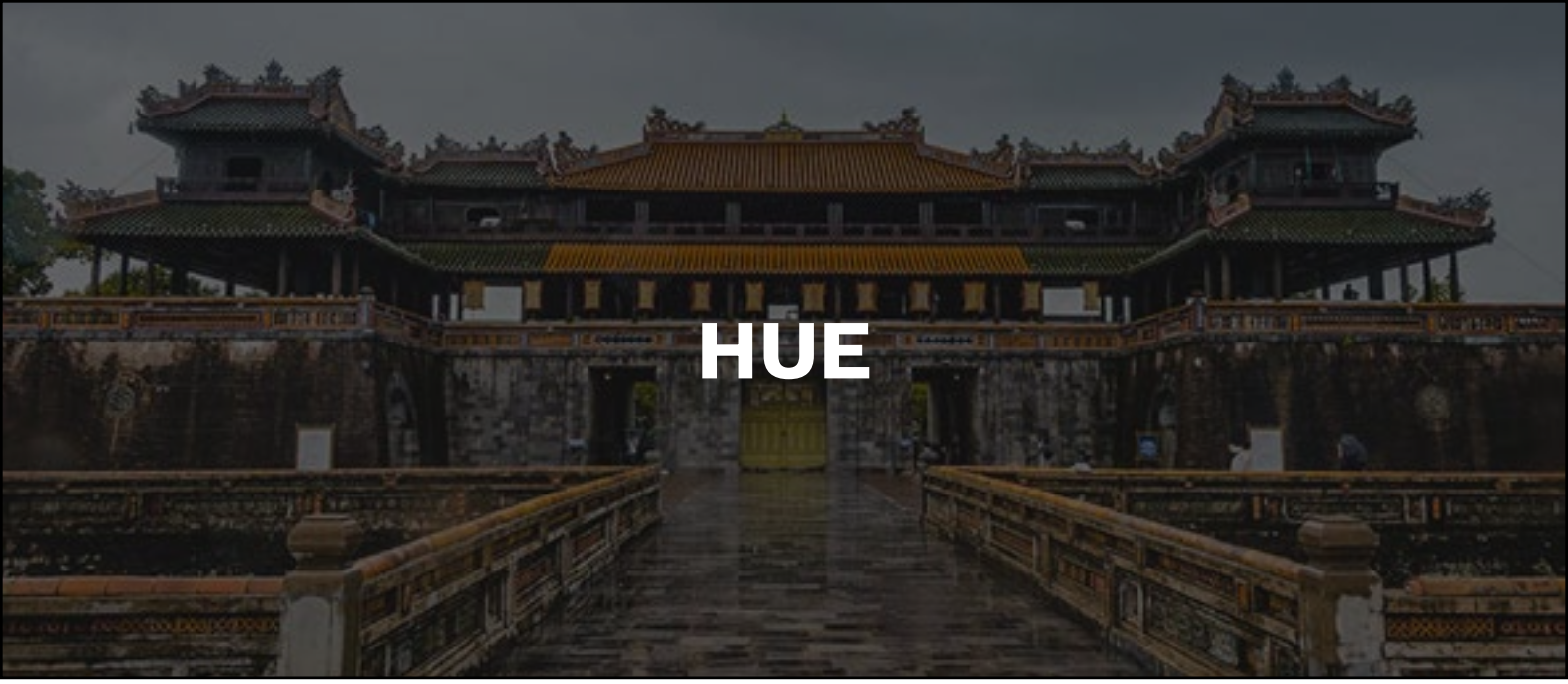
2 DAYS IN PHONG NHA

Day 1

- On the first day you will visit Paradise cave and Phong Nha cave.

Day 2

- On day 2, go to the Dark Cave in the morning. In the afternoon, explore the Phong Nha Park on your own on a motorbike or on the back of an Easy Rider. You can also check out the Botanical Gardens or the Mooc eco-route if you want to see more of Vietnam's wildlife.



HUE

The ancient city of Hue was the capital of Vietnam during the Nguyen Dynasty in the early 1800s, and during the Vietnam-US War, some of the most intense conflicts took place in this region. One of the main tourist attractions of Hue is the Royal Palace of the Imperial City. There are also a number of sights left over from the Vietnam War, such as a military base and tunnels in the DMZ.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 1-2 days
You can see most of Hue's highlights in 1 day. If you still want to go to the DMZ or Bach Ma National Park, choose an extra day.

Best time to visit

- Best time to travel: From January to April, with 20 to 25 degrees and almost no rain.
- Dry season: The complete season when there is little or no rain is from March to August.

Money
Hue is a big place, there are plenty of ATM's.

Getting around
Taxis are everywhere in Hue, although there are a few that will take you on quite a detour if you're unfamiliar with the area. To avoid this, look out for the Green Mai Linh or Yellow Taxi Vang, which use both meters.

Cyclos and motorcycle taxis are very popular. Drivers will quote an amount they think they can get, so you should come up with a price that you think is reasonable.

Cycling is best suited for those who want to do sightseeing on their own in and around downtown Hue. There are plenty of hostels and bike shops with daily rates between VND 25,000 and VND 30,000.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Flights
Hue has a small international airport, Phu Bai International Airport, with daily flights from Ho Chi Minh City and Hanoi.

Bus
Hue is connected to other cities in Central Vietnam by bus. Buses run daily from Hoi An, making the journey to Hue in about three and a half hours. There are also daily buses from other cities, such as Phong Nha, Dong Hoi, Da Nang and even from Ho Chi Minh City and Hanoi.

Train
Hue train station is one of several stops on the Hanoi to Ho Chi Minh City train route that runs through most of Vietnam. The train journey from Hue to Da Nang is a very beautiful route that is even worth doing as an excursion.

RESTAURANTS

- **Serene Cuisine Restaurant**: Good food with many different dishes.
- **Les Jardins de La Carambole**: Nice restaurant with a nice mix of French and Vietnamese cuisine.
- **Nook Eatery**: It is quite remote and offers Vietnamese and Western food.
- **Cafe on Thu Wheels**: Cozy restaurant with friendly service.
- **Ancient Hue Garden Houses**; Popular restaurant in a temple-like building in a remote location.
- **COZY Restaurant & cafe**; Cheap and small restaurant with an extensive menu.
- **Madam Thu Restaurant**; The set menu is recommended, you can also try a few different dishes.

NIGHTLIFE

- **DMZ Bar**: one of the city's most popular bars, with a wide range of cocktails.
- **Why Not? Bar**: This bar has a more relaxed atmosphere than some of the others in town.
- **Secret Lounge Hue**: An open air bar in a tropical garden setting, with pool tables and a live band every night.

Explore the city in the evening
Visiting the Hue Citadel at night is a truly unique thing to do. There are also a few other spots that are open at night that are nicely lit.

STAYING IN HUE

Where to stay

City Center - The best area to stay in Hue is the city center, in the area closest to the Imperial City, Hue's main attraction, located on the river bank. This is where you will find the vast majority of the city's hotels. The area also offers a wide variety of restaurants, bars and shops nearby.

Recommended accommodations

Indochine Palace Hotel From $100 Book via: booking.com

Located in the center of Hue, near many attractions. Modern hotel with swimming pool and luxurious rooms.

Vedana Lagoon Wellness Resort & Spa From $80 Book via: booking.com

Very luxurious, out of the center, but in a great location with beautiful views.

Pilgrimage Village Boutique Resort & Spa From $80 Book via: booking.com

Great location with great pool and beautiful garden.

Moonlight Hotel Hue From $45 Book via: booking.com

Modern and nice hotel in the center of Hue.

The Scarlett Boutique Hotel Hue From $50 Book via: booking.com

Small hotel with nice modern rooms in a good location.

Beaulieu Boutique Hotel From $30 Book via: booking.com

Nice clean rooms within walking distance of several attractions.

Hong Thien Ruby Hotel From $15 Book via: booking.com

Great hotel and a good location.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Hue Imperial City

The Imperial City is a walled city where the emperors of Vietnam lived. Here you will find the Forbidden Purple City, dozens of tombs, pagodas, temples and royal chambers.

2. Lang Co beach

Lang Co Beach is one of the most beautiful beaches in Vietnam. You can combine a visit to this beach with your journey from Hoi An to Hue, where you drive along the coast over the Hai Van Pass.





3. Tombs and Temples

You will find temples not only inside the Imperial City, but also outside. These are the Minh Mang Tomb, Tu Duc Tomb, Hon Chen Temple and The To Mieu Temple.

4. Hai Van Pass

The views from the mountain pass are spectacular. This route is incredibly popular with those traveling by motorbike in the area. But you can also travel on the back of the motorcycle, by jeep or car.





5. Bach Ma National Park

An old French hill station stretching over 40,000 hectares, it offers great hiking trails, dilapidated French villas, waterfalls, a campground and plenty of wildlife.

6. Dong Ba markt

The largest market in Central Vietnam and is the perfect place to see local life.





7. Perfume river

Some of the sights such as temples and villages are located along the river. Boat trips, paddle boats and dinner cruises are available that take you across the river.

8. Cycling

Many travelers choose to rent bicycles and cycle along the perfume river and visit various attractions in Hue such as the temples, pagodas and tombs.





9. DMZ

In the DMZ you will find the Hien Luong Bridge, an American army base, Khe Sanh, with tanks, helicopters and planes. You also have the Vinh Moc Tunnels, an underground tunnel system.

10. Abandoned Water Park

Ho Thuy Tien is a small lake with an abandoned water park, popular for photography enthusiasts and explorers.



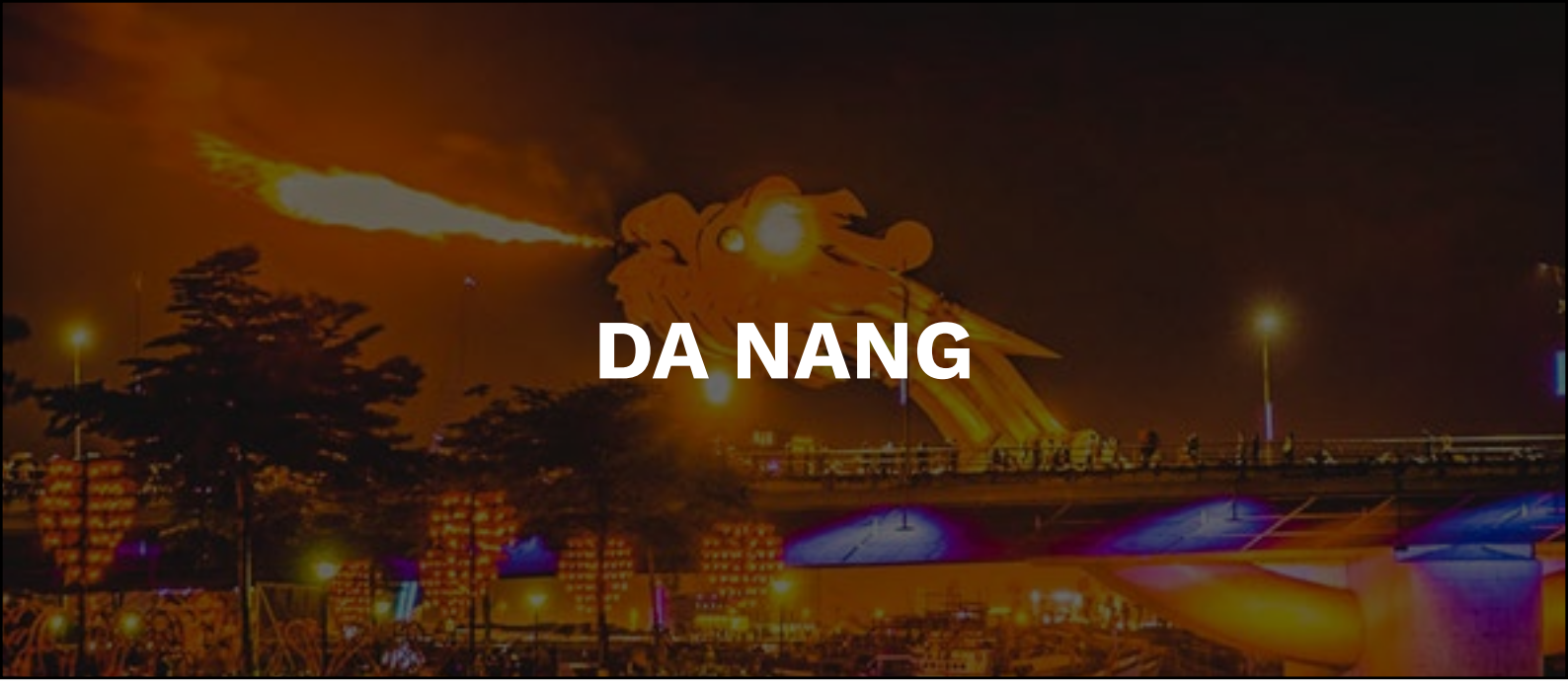
2 DAYS IN HUE

Day 1

- The morning in Hue starts with a walk around Hue Citadel and the Imperial City.
- In the afternoon, rent a bicycle or motorbike taxi to Thien Mu Pagoda along the romantic Perfume River. If you have more time, you can cycle even further.
- At night you take a boat trip along the Perfume River, where you can enjoy live music.

Day 2

- Option 1: Take a day trip through the DMZ. Visit the Vinh Moc Tunnels and the Khe Sanh Combat Base, among others.
- Option 2: Take a day trip to Bach Ma National Park and hike here.
- Option 3: Drive over the Hai Van Pass and visit Lang Co Beach.



DA NANG

Da Nang is located halfway between the capital Hanoi in the north and Ho Chi Minh City in the south. It is the fourth largest city in Vietnam. Aside from some historical sites, the famous Hai Van Pass, Son Tra Peninsula and beaches are the main reason for staying here.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Verblijf hier 1 - 3 dagen
Da Nang is a beautiful city, but lacks real sights. You can visit Hoi An from this city, relax on beaches and visit various national parks.

Best time to visit
- Dry season: April – August
- Monsoon season: September – March
- Hottest months: June – August (with the highest average temperature of 35C)
- Coolest months: November – January (with lowest average temperature of 18C).

Money
There are ATMs all over the city, including some at international banks.

Getting around
Grab/Taxi: It's quite easy to get a Grab taxi anywhere in Da Nang. This saves money compared to a normal taxi. If you find it difficult to use Grab, you should use normal taxis. To avoid expensive taxis, you should choose a well-known taxi brand: Mai Linh Taxi, Vinasun Taxi, Tien Sa Taxi.

Motorbike rental: Traveling by motorbike is the most fun option of all. The average price to rent a motorcycle is 130,000 VND ($6) per day.

Private car: If you want to take a day trip to certain sights or a place outside Da Nang, you can rent a car with a driver.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Flights
Danang's busy airport has many domestic connections and popular international flights to Kuala Lumpur, Hong Kong and Singapore. Domestic flights to destinations such as Ho Chi Minh City, Hanoi, Dalat and Nha Trang are served by regional airlines, including Vietnam Airlines, VietJet Air and Jetstar.

Bus
There are regular buses between Da Nang, Hue and Hoi An. There is a major Danang bus station on Dien Bien Phu Street, 3 kilometers west of the city center. From there, there are buses to all major destinations in Vietnam, including Quy Nhon, Hue, Nha Trang and Hanoi.

Train
Da Nang train station is located just outside the city center and you will find a train connection here that can take you anywhere in Vietnam. The train ride to Hue is one of the best in the country and well worth taking as an excursion in its own right.

RESTAURANTS

- **Banh xeo Ba Duong** - Come here for Vietnamese pancakes.
- **Tamarind Tree Da Nang Restaurant** - Small cozy restaurant with good local food.
- **Bep Cuon Da Nang** - Atmospheric restaurant with great Vietnamese food.
- **Thien Ly Danang-style** - Delicious Vietnamese food and good service.
- **Burger Bros** - The best burgers in Da Nang.
- **My Casa** - Delicious Spanish and Italian food.
- **Panorama Restaurant** - Reasonably priced Korean BBQ
- **Citron Restaurant** - The restaurant is one of the most luxurious resorts in Vietnam, so expect good food in a beautiful setting.

NIGHTLIFE

- **Sky 36**: The most popular rooftop bar in Da Nang is located on the Novotel and offers stunning views of the Han River and the Dragon Bridge.
- **Brilliant Top Bar**: Te found on the roof of Brilliant Hotel, with beautiful view.
- **New Phuong Dong Nightclub**: A spacious dance floor, spectacular laser show and a central stage where prominent local DJs, dancers and bands perform every night.
- **Golden Pine**: One of the most famous bars in Da Nang. Loud EDM music and cheap drinks mainly attract young crowds.
- **OQ Bar**: Good place to visit last on a night out with good music.
- **The Dawn**: Good live music, reasonably priced drinks and perfect location at My Khe Beach.
- **Seventeen Saloon**: Waitresses in sexy cowgirl costumes, ice cold beer and musicians performing every night, mostly expats and backpackers.
- **Bamboo Bar 2**: The most popular expat hangout in Da Nang. The top floor has pool tables and a sitting area with nice views of the river and Dragon Bridge.
- **7 Bridges Brewery**: Da Nang's first home-brewed beers.

STAYING IN DA NANG

Where to stay

Hoi An - Hoi An - Most tourists choose to stay in Hoi An for a better atmosphere and take a day trip to Da Nang. It is only 45 minutes from Da Nang to Hoi An.

Aan de Han Rivier - A very popular place to look for a hotel with many restaurants, bars and good nightlife. During the Da Nang International Fireworks Festival, a hotel along the Han River offers a good view to see fireworks.

Aan het strand - There are many hotels and resort near the beach. Most of the beachfront hotels are located on Nguyen Tat Thanh Street and Vo Nguyen Giap Street. Vo Nguyen Giap street is also the road to Hoi An.

Recommended accommodations

InterContinental Danang Sun Peninsula From $364 Book via: booking.com

Extremely luxurious hotel where Trump, Putin, and Trudeau, among others, stayed overnight.

Grandvrio Ocean Resort Danang From $150 Book via: booking.com

Luxury hotel with free shuttle bus to Hoi An and Da Nang City.

Monarque Hotel Danang From $60 Book via: booking.com

Right on the beach with nice spacious rooms.

Frangipani Boutique Hotel From $37 Book via: booking.com

Cozy boutique hotel which is run by a family.

Avora Hotel From $32 Book via: booking.com

Mooi en heel modern hotel, 10 minuten van het vliegveld en 5 minuten van de drakenbrug.

Travellers Nest Hostel From $5 Book via: booking.com

Simple and great hostel, friendly staff and excellent breakfast.

Danang Backpackers Hostel From $4 Book via: booking.com

Very cheap hostel including breakfast. In good location with rooftop bar.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Hai Van Pass

Made famous on an episode of the TV show Top Gear, this 21km mountain pass between Da Nang and Hue offers some of the most incredible ocean views.

2. Son Tra

A beautiful rainforest on a peninsula. Go to the top for a great view and if you are lucky you can spot the rare red duoc langars. There are also a host of pristine beaches.





3. Marble Mountains

A cluster of marble and limestone hills filled with caves, tunnels and Buddhist shrines for you to explore.

4. Ba Na Hills

It is a mountain village that looks like a medieval castle. The newest addition is the golden bridge held by two giant stone hands.





5. Stranden

The more popular beaches, such as My Khe and Non Nuoc are relatively close to the city center, with local restaurants serving fresh fish and specialities.

6. Dragon Bridge

A fascinating part of the city where you can enjoy beautiful colonial architecture packed along narrow streets, with endless traffic of scooters, zigzagging around merchants.





7. Cham Island

If you want to see coral reefs, colorful fish, tropical beaches and islets, take a trip to the Cham Islands.

8. Cham Museum

Cham Museum showcases the ancient culture, lifestyle and customs of the indigenous Cham tribe in Vietnam, dating back to 192AD.





9. My Son

My Son is a large temple complex of the Cham people. It is about a 40-minute drive from Da Nang.

10. Hoi An

The most famous landmark in the region is the old town of Hoi An. If you are not planning to stay in Hoi An itself, this is the best thing to do from Da Nang.



2 DAYS IN DA NANG

Day 1

- Option 1: In the morning you take a trip to the Marble Mountains. Explore the caves and temples here or choose rock climbing.
- Option 2: Explore the Son Tra peninsula.
- When you return to Da Nang, explore the city, which includes the Cham Museum and the Dragon Bridge.
- The late afternoon you enjoy the beach where you stay for dinner and a drink.

Day 2

- You rent a motorbike or cross the Hai Van Pass by tour. You stop at a number of viewpoints and make a dip in the river at a waterfall.
- Later in the evening you can enjoy the view of a rooftop bar by the river.



HOI AN

Hoi An Town is an exceptionally well-preserved trading port from the 15th to 19th centuries. It is also known for being the most atmospheric city in Vietnam, if not all of Southeast Asia. The city is full of picturesque historic houses, pagodas and cafes. It is extremely popular to buy handmade clothes. But even if you don't want to shop, Hoi An provides a relaxing destination in an otherwise hectic country. After all, a day at the beach is only a 20 minute bike ride from the city.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here 2-4 days
The town is small and can be seen in half an afternoon. However, the atmosphere is so good that you often stay longer. There are also plenty of attractions outside the city, beautiful countryside and some relaxed beaches.

Best time to visit

- February to April: pleasant temperatures, low humidity.
- From June to August: the temperatures are the warmest, up to 38 ° C
- From September to January: Hoi An's rainy season. October and November are the wettest
- November to January: Coldest temperatures ranging from 19 to 24 °C
-

Money
ATM's can be found everywhere in Hoi An.

Getting around
Walking - Hoi An is small enough to walk through the old town without difficulty. Every day from 08:00 to 11:00 and from 15:00 to 21:30, the old town is closed to motorized vehicles and only accessible to pedestrians and cyclists.

Cycling - A bike gives you more range and is a cheap option for getting to the beaches and exploring the countryside. Most hotels offer free bicycles to guests or cost a euro or two per day.

Cyclos - A fun way to explore the old town. Expect to pay around 100,000 dong for a one hour tour.

Scooter/Motorcycle - If you're a confident motorcyclist there are some great rides through the countryside, to the many islands and further afield over the Hai Van Pass and the Lang Co area.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Flights
The nearest airport to Hoi An is Da Nang International Airport (DAD), located in the heart of Da Nang. It is 30 kilometers from Hoi An. From the airport, the taxi ride to Hoi An takes about 30 minutes.

Bus
Hoi An has two bus stations with buses to and from many destinations in Vietnam, such as Nha Trang (10 hours) and Hue (2.5 hours). Between Hoi An and Da Nang there is a public bus that stops just outside Hoi An city center and travels through Da Nang city center.

Train
The nearest train station is in Da Nang. Several trains a day arrive from Quy Nhon (6 hours), Hanoi (5 hours), Ho Chi Minh City (5 hours), Hue (3 hours), Nha Trang (11 hours) and Mui Ne (4 hours). At the station you will have no problem finding a taxi to take you to Hoi An.

RESTAURANTS

- **Phi Banh Mi** - Perhaps the most famous Banh Mi (Sandwich sandwich) place in Vietnam.
- **Nhan's Kitchen** - Inexpensive with a menu of local dishes, pasta and recommendations.
- **FireFly Restaurant & Bar** - Small family restaurant that makes really good food and has great service.
- **Red Bean Restaurant** - Nice luxurious look. Slightly more expensive but very good food.
- **Restaurant & Cafe Tuan** - Located a bit outside the center, but coming here is definitely worth it.
- **Aubergine49 Restaurant** - Great western and asian food.

NIGHTLIFE

Visiting Hoi An in the evening is a must! The lanterns and lights of the houses transform the small city center into something magical. Also don't forget to visit the night market. If you want a drink, you can go to the following bars:

- **Dive Bar**: Cham Island Diving's bar is a popular place for tourists to have a drink with the occasional live music.
- **Mango Mango**: After dinner, the upstairs is a nice place for a cocktail and often with live music downstairs.
- **Dublin Gate Irish Pub**: Live music most evenings, with sports on TV screens and a cozy atmosphere.

STAYING IN HOI AN

Where to stay

The Old Town - At the heart of Hoi An is the Old Town. Here you will find Hoi An's most famous and iconic sights, including the covered Japanese bridge, colorful shophouses and streets decorated with lanterns. There is not much accommodation right in the old town.

Countryside of Hoi An - Cam Chau and Cam Thanh - are located between the beach and the ancient town of Hoi An. It is about a 10-minute bike ride to the old town and a 15-minute bike ride to Cua Dai Beach. Many luxurious and beautiful accommodations can be found.

Beach - If you prefer to spend most of your time on the beach and visit the old town once or twice, An Bang Beach is a good option.

Recommended accommodations

La Siesta Hoi An Resort & Spa From $50 Book via: booking.com

Good hotel with nice view on the river just outside the center.

Hoi An Silk Marina Resort and Spa From $70 Book via: booking.com

Luxury resort with large pool in a good location.

Hoi An Central Boutique Hotel & Spa From $40 Book via: booking.com

Nice atmospheric hotel with swimming pool within walking distance of the Japanese bridge in the center.

Royal Riverside Hoi An Hotel From $120 Book via: booking.com

Very nice resort in Hoi An style, with swimming pool and spacious rooms.

Golden Pearl Hoi An Hotel From $40 Book via: booking.com

Between the beach and the city, near the countryside. Neat hotel with swimming pool.

Pham Gia Boutique Villa From $25 Book via: booking.com

Cozy small hotel with swimming pool and attractively decorated with plants within walking distance of the city center.

The Seaside Bungalow From $20 Book via: booking.com

Cozy place right on the beach, but very basic. Popular among backpackers.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Walk through the old town

A fascinating part of the city where you can enjoy beautiful colonial architecture packed along narrow streets, with endless traffic of scooters, zigzagging around merchants.

2. Explore the countryside by bike

Take a bike ride on narrow paths along the rice fields. From the center it is only a 10-minute bike ride to the countryside with water buffalos and green fields.





3. Take cooking class

The most popular place in Vietnam for a cooking class and more than just cooking, including visiting a local market, boat trips, cycling and visiting craft villages.

4. Relax on the beach

The two most popular are An Bang Beach and Cua Dai Beach. You can easily reach these beaches by bike from the center.





5. Take a boat trip

Enjoying some of the city's many river roads is a must – rent a boat, go paddle boarding or take a tour to see life on and along the water.

6. Have tailor-made clothes made

Tailors use their magic to produce excellent quality clothing at a bargain price.





7. Visit markets

In the middle of the city next to the river you will find the central market where you can really find everything and every evening there is a Night Market completely lit with lanterns.

8. Visit craft villages

The most popular are Kim Bong, a place where carpenters work to make furniture, and TraQue, a vegetable village, shows you the farming techniques of the locals.





9. From Hoi An to Hue

The route from Hoi An to Hue is very impressive and is an activity in itself, with the highlights being the Hai Van Pass, Lang Co Beach and the Marble Mountains.

10. Take a day trip

1. My Son: A collection of ancient temples. 2. Cham Island: The most beautiful beaches, with palm trees and clear water. 3. Marble Mountains: Limestone mountains with caves and religious sites.



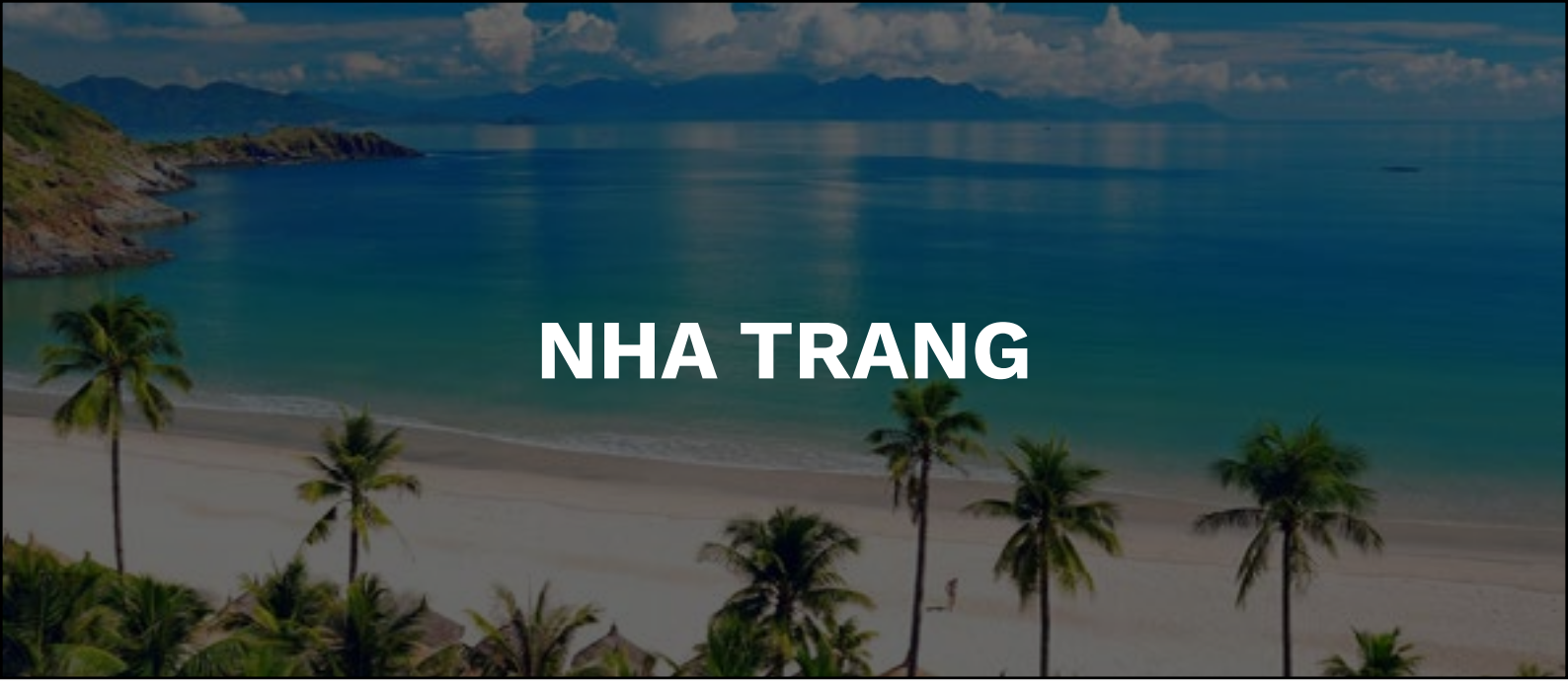
2 DAYS IN HOI AN

Day 1

- Stroll through the old town and visit the most famous sights.
- Take a boat trip on the small waterways and see the local life.
- In the evening you walk through the city again to see everything lit up with lanterns. Also visit the Night Market (night market)

Day 2

- Rent a bike and ride around the area of Hoi An. Explore the countryside and visit local craft villages.
- Cycle to Bay Mau Coconut Forest to take a short trip in a bamboo basket boat.
- Then cycle to the beach to enjoy the sea for a while.
- In the evening you will take a Vietnamese cooking class.



NHA TRANG

Nha Trang is the popular beach destination in Vietnam. The city has six kilometers of coastline where you can enjoy a day of island hopping, diving, swimming or just relax and take in the beautiful sunset views. The vast countryside is great to explore by bike or motorbike.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 1 day
Nha Trang is not the nicest place in Vietnam and there are few sights. If you want to rest on the beach, you can consider staying here for a day or two.

Best time to visit

- Best time to visit: Between February and May
- April to August: Best time for diving, due to the best visibility.
- Rainy season: September to December.

Money
There are ATMs everywhere in Nha Trang.

Getting around
Cycling: Most of Nha Trang is quite flat, so it's easy to see all the sights by bike. Many hotels have bicycles for rent from 30,000 per day.

Taxi: It is safer to take a meter taxi from a well-known company, such as Mai Linh.

Motorbike: Renting a motorbike is the best option if you want to explore the countryside of Nha Trang at your own pace. The cost is between VND 60,000 and VND 100,000 per day.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Flights
Nha Trang Airport is called Cam Ranh Airport and it is about 30 km away from the city center. From there you can take a 45 minute taxi ride which costs about $15 or you can take a shuttle bus for about $3. The Nha Trang airport has good connections with other destinations in Vietnam, such as Hanoi, Ho Chi Minh City and Da Nang.

Bus
The main bus terminal is Phia Nam Nha Trang. There are daily buses north to Da Nang (12 hours) and Hoi An (13 hours) and south to Mui Ne (6 hours), Dalat (5 hours) and Ho Chi Minh City (13 hours). Nha Trang is an important stopping point of all open tour buses.

Train
Nha Trang Railway Station is located in the center of the city. It has good connections to Danang and Ho Chi Minh City, among others, both of which take about 8 hours.

RESTAURANTS

- **Same Same But Different Cafe** - Cheap restaurant with a wide range of Vietnamese and Thai food.
- **Rainforest** - Uniquely decorated jungle restaurant with good food.
- **Feast** - Comfortable and luxurious restaurant that mainly focuses on fresh fish and seafood.
- **LIVIN Collective** - American BBQ grill restaurant.
- **Skylight Nha Trang** - Delicious food, but you come here mainly for the view, because the restaurant is located on the 45th floor.
- **Sandals** -An upscale beachfront eatery in the iconic sailing club, with a menu serving Vietnamese and Mediterranean delicacies.
- **Lanterns** - A striking Hoi An style restaurant decorated with traditional colorful Hoi An lanterns.

NIGHTLIFE

- **Louisiane Brewhouse & Restaurant**: Good beer, good food and a wide selection of other drinks right on the beach.
- **QUI – Cuisine Mixology**: Luxurious and relaxed atmosphere, perfect for a cocktail night out.
- **Why Not Bar**: One of the few places in Nha Trang that is crowded even after 3am.
- **Sailing Club**: The best nightlife in Nha Trang, with a great location, extensive drink lists, good music and big dance floor.
- **Skylight Skydeck & Rooftop Beach Club**: Offers panoramic views, with three bars, four event spaces, and a swimming pool.

STAYING IN NHA TRANG

Where to stay

Nha Trang beach - The beach has a beautiful promenade along the sea where many resorts, budget hotels, museums, eateries and bars are located. You can also enjoy a wide range of activities such as surfing, snorkeling, cycling tours.

Resorts on islands off Nha Trang - Nha Trang is surrounded by the Ninh Van bay. Whale Island, Hon Tre Island and Hon Tam Island, are all a short ferry ride away. Great for well-heeled travelers as these islands are dotted with luxury resorts.

Recommended accommodations

Amiana Resort and Villas Nha Trang From $190 Book via: booking.com

Extremely luxurious and beautiful resorts, including options for villas with private pool.

Sheraton Nha Trang From $100 Book via: booking.com

Right on the beach with free sunbeds. Clean and spacious rooms in a luxury hotel.

Liberty Central Nha Trang Hotel From $60 Book via: booking.com

Well located and modern hotel, with free sunbeds on the beach.

Gosia Hotel From $40 Book via: booking.com

Modern hotel with neat clean rooms. Rooftop pool and good location in town.

Aaron Hotel From $30 Book via: booking.com

Central hotel, with nice rooms and close to the beach.

Backpack Abode Hostel From $4 Book via: booking.com

Clean hostel with good atmosphere, close to the beach, restaurants and shops.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Diving and snorkeling

Nha Trang Bay has over 12,000 hectares of reef known as Hon Mun Marine Park. Most of the diving and snorkeling is done here and the shallow water is the best place for beginners.

2. Relax on the beaches

Nha Trang has a beautiful six kilometer coastline with a wide variety of dining and accommodation options along the white sandy beaches.





3. Island hopping

You visit a number of islands by boat, including snorkeling and often a BBQ lunch. Prices start at 6 euros, but these are fully loaded boats where not everything is included.

4. Van Phong Bay

One of the most beautiful bays in central Vietnam with its pristine natural beauty.





5. Ba Ho waterfall

Nha Trang is known for its waterfalls and some of the most famous are Ba Ho and Fairy Spring waterfalls. These offer you the perfect opportunity to get out and about.

6. Long Son Pagoda & White Buddha

Long Son Pagoda is a multi-level Buddhist temple that sits gracefully on a hill. It is also where you can see the large white Buddha image.





7. Cho Dam market

The Dam market is the most popular market in the city in a huge imposing four-storey concrete structure, with clothing, accessories, electronics and household items.

8. Po Nagar

These are some of the best preserved buildings of Cham architecture in Vietnam, similar to the My Son near Da Nang and Hoi An.





9. Salt Fields

The Hon Khoi Salt Fields are some of the most unique sights in Nha Trang, where women harvest natural salt from shallow fields between the months of January and June.

10. Nha Trang Cathedral

Despite being built with simple blocks of cement, the cathedral looks surprisingly elegant. Mass is held several times a day.



2 DAYS IN NHA TRANG

Day 1

- Start the day with the sunrise on the beach.
- Visit the Dam Market and Nha Trang Church.
- In the afternoon you will visit Po Nagar Cham Towers and the rest of the afternoon you will relax on the beach.
- In the evening you can enjoy a drink on the beach.

Day 2

- Option 1: Take an island hopping tour. Visit different islands, enjoy the BBQ on the boat and explore the underwater world with snorkeling.
- Option 2: Take a diving excursion.



KON TUM

The remote province of Kon Tum is the northernmost region of Vietnam's central highlands. Despite being easily accessible from coastal towns such as Da Nang and Hoi An, it attracts few travelers, especially when compared to the popular city of Dalat. Travelers who do come usually come for a night with an Easy Rider motorcycle tour. Nevertheless, this region with impressive mountains and unique culture of ethnic minorities is more than worth a visit.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 2-3 days
The sights in Dak Lak are spread all over the province. If you want to see these highlights, you need at least 2 days.

Best time to visit

- Dak Lak is located in the highland climate area with two distinct seasons: rainy season (from May to October) and dry season (from November to April). The ideal time to visit this place is from December to March as this is the time when wildflowers bloom in the Central Highlands and also the time for many festivals.

Money
You will find ATMs in Kon Tum town and Mang Den, but not in villages around it.

Getting around
Taxi – For short distances within the city you can simply use a taxi, such as Mai Linh.

Car with driver – For larger distances and when visiting several places of interest, you can go with a car with private transport. There are also several tours (often private) that take you around the area, such as to minority villages and war sites.

Scooter/motorcycle – You can go with a guide on the back of the motorbike, or if you are brave enough you can also rent a scooter or motorbike yourself to drive around the area

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Flights
The nearest airport is in Pleiku, 48 kilometers south of Kon Tum. Local buses and minibuses make the journey in just an hour. There are direct flights from Ho Chi Minh City and Hanoi.

Bus
The bus station is located two kilometers northwest of the city center on Phan Dinh Phung road. There are daily buses and minibuses to destinations in the central highlands and the coast. To Dalat (11 hours), Pleiku (1 hour), Buon Ma Thuot in Dak Lak (5 hours), Da Nang/Hoi An (8 hours), Nha Trang (9 hours), Hue (9 hours) and Ho Chi Minh City (1pm).

Easy rider
Many travelers who visit Kon Tum come here by Easy Rider tour. These are guides that take you on the back of the bike for several days.

Own transportation
You can rent a car with a driver here, which is especially ideal if you want to visit multiple destinations in the central highlands, stopping at sights along the way.

STAYING IN KON TUM

Where to stay

You can choose to stay in Kon Tum town, in Mang Den or elsewhere in an ethnic minority homestay.

Recommended accommodations

TOKI Boutique Mang Den From $25 Book via: booking.com

Nice location in the woods of Mang Den. Well decorated and boutique style.

Nang House 82 From $13 Book via: booking.com

Nicely decorated homestay with private rooms and dorm and helpful employees. Near Kon Tum town.

Kontum Home Sweet Homestay From $8 Book via: booking.com

A cozy and well appointed homestay with helpful host. Near Kon Tum town.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Visit ethnic Ba Na villages

In Kon Tum you will find a unique ethnic culture of the Ba Na people. Learn about their culture and visit a traditional Rong house.

2. Colonial buildings in Kon Tum town

In Kon Tum town you will find a number of French colonial buildings, such as the Archbishop's Residence and the beautiful wooden church.





3. Pa Sy waterfall

The Pa Sy waterfall is located in a jungle area near Mang Den where you can hike.

4. Forests and mountains around Mang Den

Mang Den is een toeristisch gebied wat wordt vergeleken met Dalat. De regio heeft een indrukwekkend berggebied en rijk aan bossen.





5. Chu Mon Ray National Park

This national park is rich in biodiversity and indigenous culture. This area is home to many ethnic minorities such as H'Lang, Gia Rai, K'Dong, Ro Mam, Bo Rau. The best way to explore the park is by trekking.

6. War Sights

Charlie Hill and Rocket Ridge, where some of the fiercest fighting took place during The Battle of Dak To. Also nearby was an American base – Dak To camp with Phoenix airstrip.





7. Spend the night in a homestay

Stay overnight in a Ba Na minority homestay to learn more about their culture and for a truly unique experience.

8. Touring with the motorcycle

The roads in the Kon Tum province are quiet, interspersed with villages, forests and mountains. For that reason it is wonderful to drive around here by motorcycle.





9. Kon Tum prison

This is where the French settlers imprisoned political prisoners. It has been badly damaged over the years and not much is left of it. You can visit it, as it is now a museum.

10. With a canoe on the river

At the Kon K'Tu village near Kon Tum town you can take a canoe across a small river and watch the local life.



2 DAYS IN KON TUM

Day 1

- Explore Kon Tum town, including the colonial buildings.
- Visit ethnic villages around the city and learn about their culture
- In the afternoon you make a small trek in Chu Mon Ray National Park through the jungle to a waterfall.
- Stay overnight in a local homestay.

Day 2

- Explore the region around Mang Den, with mountains, forests, ethnic minorities and the Pa Sy waterfall.



DALAT

Dalat is clearly one of the highlights of Vietnam, especially if you like adrenaline. Dalat is completely different from any other place in Vietnam. The weather is spring-like cool instead of tropical hot, the city is dotted with elegant French-colonial villas instead of stark socialist architecture, and the farms around are dotted with strawberries and flowers instead of rice.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 2-3 days
You can see most of the sights in Hanoi in 2 days.

Best time to visit

- Spring (January-March) – Season of trees and flowers; between 20 and 28 degrees
- Summer (April – June) – Season of fog and warm weather; between 24 and 31 degrees
- Autumn (July – September) – Season of rain; between 24 and 31
- Winter (October to December) – Season of flowers on the hills; between 20 and 26 degrees

Money
There are ATMs everywhere in Dalat.

Getting around
Car: Daily rental (with driver) starts around $50.

Engine: Rent is 150,000d to 200,000d per day.

Easyrider: An alternative to self-driving is on the back of a motorbike with a local guide who shows you the area. The Easy Rider waterfall tours are popular.

Taxi: Uses Mai Linh for reliable taxis.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Flights
There are regular flights with Vietnam Airlines, VietJet Air and Jetstar, including a daily service to Danang (1¼ hours), four daily to Hanoi (1¾ hours) and HCMC (45 minutes), and twice weekly to Can Tho (1¼ hours).

Bus
There are daily buses to and from Mui Ne, Nha Trang and HCMC. The bus station is 1.5 km from the center, but most companies have free transfers to and from your accommodation in the center.

RESTAURANTS

- **Chu Quan Bbq Grill** - One of Dalat's specialties is the BBQ. Grill yourself in this restaurant among the locals with a good atmosphere.
- **Gourmet Burger** - Not in the mood for Vietnamese food? Get a good burger with fries here.
- **One More Cafe** - Good restaurant for breakfast, with delicious food.
- **Dalat Train Cafe** - Sit in a cosily furnished train carriage with a nice view and good food.
- **V Cafe** - Great food, good atmosphere and live music.
- **Artist Alley Restaurant** - Good food, friendly staff and cozy atmosphere.
- **Primavera Italian Restaurant** - Atmospheric and beautifully decorated Italian restaurant with homemade pasta and pizzas.
- **Goc Ha Thanh Restaurant** - Delicious local Vietnamese food.

NIGHTLIFE

- **Dalat Night Market**: The streets of the city center are open daily between 5 and 10 PM and are lined with colorful stalls selling local snacks, second-hand clothes and souvenirs.
- **Maze bar**: This is literally a bar in a maze. A must-visit, if only for one drink.
- **The Escape Bar**: The best place for live music ranging from country and blues to rock 'n' roll and reggae.
- **Beepub Hostel & Bar**: Known for its lively atmosphere. Part of a hostel, you can play pool, dance to various music and chat with fellow travelers.
- **Rain Nightclub**: Attracts partygoers who want to enjoy a night of dancing.
- **V Club Da Lat**: Lively nightclub near the market, with mostly local young people and travellers.

STAYING IN DALAT

Where to stay

Center - Located near Dalat night market, suitable for shopping, eating and relaxing, most means of transport (taxi, motorbike, bicycle) are available, with many beautiful views worth seeing.

Outside Dalat City - A calm and quiet atmosphere, less touristy and cheaper price. Although it will take you more time to travel to the market or other city highlights, in return you get beautiful scenery to enjoy

Recommended accommodations

Swiss-Belresort Tuyen Lam From $70 Book via: booking.com

Large resort, with spacious rooms, swimming pool and surrounded by forests and mountains.

Terracotta Hotel & Resort Dalat From $50 Book via: booking.com

Great location; close to Dalat but in the middle of nature. There is a lake next to the resort where you can walk.

Zen Valley Dalat From $50 Book via: booking.com

Bungalow style rooms in a beautiful setting with swimming pool.

SAM Tuyen Lam Resort From $50 Book via: booking.com

Secluded resort in a quiet location to get away from the city and the crowds. The view of the lake, countryside and forest all around is amazing.

Iris Dalat Hotel From $25 Book via: booking.com

A good hotel in the middle of the city, walking distance to the market.

Tulip Hotel From $25 Book via: booking.com

A good hotel in the middle of the city, walking distance to the market.

Tasme Hotel From $20 Book via: booking.com

Clean hotel with modern decor and helpful staff.

Cozy Nook Hostel From $7 Book via: booking.com

Very highly rated hostel in Vietnam, with a great atmosphere.

Mr. Peace Backpacker's House From $5 Book via: booking.com

Very popular among backpackers, with a good atmosphere and cozy family dinners.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Canyoning in Dalat

Abseil from cliffs, waterfalls, float in a river with natural water slide. For the highlight, jump off a pair of gushing waterfalls.

2. Explore waterfalls

The best known is Datanla waterfall where you have, among other things, a roller coaster and cable car. The most beautiful waterfalls are the Pongour waterfall, Elephant waterfall and the Bao Dai waterfall.





3. Mountainbiken

A mountain biker's paradise, with some great single track, technical descents, rock climbs and once on top, breathtaking views.

4. Trekking

Relaxed walks or adventurous trekking through nature and along forest trails are another way to discover the beauty of this area.





5. Visit coffeeshops

It is more than a place where you come for coffee. These small coffee bars are often uniquely decorated or located in a unique environment with great views over mountains or lakes.

6. Easy Rider Tour

An Easy Rider is a local guide who shows you the area on the back of your motorcycle and shows you both known and unknown sights in Dalat.





7. Tuyen Lam lake

The most beautiful lake in the area is also called Paradise Lake. The lake is surrounded by a green pine forest and gives a calm feeling in a beautiful landscape.

8. Dalat night market

The weekend night market is sheer madness, with thousands of people shopping. But even on weekday evenings, the area is rich with inviting scents from all the street vendors.





9. Visit Coffee and Tea Plantations

Vietnam is one of the world's largest coffee exporters and many of the highlands around Dalat are used for plantations.

10. Crazy house

A bizarre building with many twisting corridors, odd spaces, weird sculptures. Get lost in the maze officially called Hang Nga Guesthouse.



2 DAYS IN DALAT

Day 1

- Visit the Datanla waterfall. Take the roller coaster down.
- Take the funicular to Truc Lam Pagoda.
- Kayak across Tuyem Lam Lake.
- Visit Crazy House Dalat.
- Walk across Dalat Night Market

Day 2

- Option 1: Canyoning
- Option 2: Mountain biking
- Option 3: Hiking
- Option 4: Easy rider tour (on the back of the motorcycle) to the waterfalls in the area.



DAK LAK

Dak Lak is located in the Central Highlands of Vietnam, 200 km from Dalat and 350 km from Ho Chi Minh City. The capital of Dak Lak province is Buon Ma Thuot. Dak Lak is known for its high-quality coffee, black pepper and cashew nuts. There are a number of ethnic groups living in the province, including the Mnong, Ede, and King. Dak Lak is known for traditional villages that specialized in taming elephants. There are some beautiful waterfalls that make the province worth walking around for a few days.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 2-3 days
The sights in Dak Lak can be seen within 2 days. If you plan to do a lot of hiking, it is useful to spend more time here.

Best time to visit

- Dak Lak is located in the highland climate area with two distinct seasons: rainy season (from May to October) and dry season (from November to April). The ideal time to visit this place is from December to March as this is the time when wildflowers bloom in the Central Highlands and also the time for many festivals.

Money
You will find plenty of ATMs in the capital Buon Ma Thuot, but not in the villages beyond. Therefore, do not forget to bring cash, because many restaurants do not accept credit cards.

Getting around
Metered taxis are plentiful and your hotel can call the green Mailinh taxi – they will pick you up at your location at no extra cost.

Motorcycle/Scooter – Homestays and backpacker-oriented hotels rent scooters for VND 150,000 to 200,000 per day.

Private car with driver is the most comfortable way to visit multiple places of interest in the area around the city.

Local bus is the slow and cheap way to go. The bus stops are located near the central roundabout near the Victory Monument, Tank and Church.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Flights
An airport can be found in the capital and largest city of the province, Buon Me Thuot. Currently, there are 3 airlines operating routes to Buon Me Thuot, including Vietnam Airlines, Vietjet Air and Jetstar. There are direct connections to Hanoi, Vinh, Da Nang and Ho Chi Minh City.

Bus
The Buon Ma Thuot bus station is located five kilometers northeast of the city. Bus companies will pick you up and drop you off at your hotel, so you don't necessarily have to travel to and from the station yourself. There are direct bus connections to Ho Chi Minh City (10 hours), Nha Trang (4 hours), Da Nang (12 hours), Mui Ne (9 hours) and other destinations in the central highlands such as Dalat (5 hours), Pleiku (3 hours) and Kon Tum 5 hours.

RESTAURANTS

- **Thanh Tram** – They only have one dish but it is delicious. You make your own spring rolls and then dip them in the accompanying sauce
- **La Garden Restaurant** – A good western restaurant with on tap.
- **Com Saigon** – Serves the typical lunchtime meal of rice plus a choice of meat, tofu and vegetables.

STAYING IN DAK LAK

Lak Tented Camp From $57 Book via: booking.com

Out of town, right on the lake with great views. Nicely furnished bungalow style rooms and tents are available.

Zan HomeStay From $14 Book via: booking.com

This homestay is located outside the city, but there are plenty of restaurants within walking distance. The family who run this homestay speak little English but are very friendly and helpful.

Windy Garden homestay From $10 Book via: booking.com

The Homestay is very clean and tidy, just outside the city, in a nice location and surrounded by nature. They have a nice garden where you can relax and the host is a good cook.

Hai Ba Trung Hotel & Spa From $38 Book via: booking.com

A more luxurious hotel, but in Vietnamese style. Has spa facilities, a rooftop pool and a small gym.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Yok Don National Park

The largest national park in Vietnam. Elephants formerly used for tourism and industry have been released here. You can spot these elephants and you can take boat trips and treks through the jungle.

2. Dray Sap en Dray Nur waterfall

Fed by the Srepock River, a major tributary of the Mekong. The falls of Dray Nur and Dray Sap are almost next to each other and are very impressive during and just after the rainy season.





3. Lak Lake

Lak Lake is the second largest natural freshwater lake in Vietnam with a width of 5 km. You can take a boat trip across the lake and visit the minority villages along its shores.

4. Buon Jun

A place to learn about the culture of ethnic people in the Central Highlands. This place still maintains its long lasting traditions. Here you can see houses on stilts and the old way of life.





5. Chu Yang Sin national park

The national park consists of a series of high mountains, with Cu YangSin mountain (2442 m) in the middle as the highest point. Several rivers flow through the park and the rest is covered with forest.

6. Dak Lak Ethnic Museum

This is the site of those famous images of tanks driving through the gates of Saigon in the fall of 1975, heralding the end of the Vietnam War.





7. Yang Prong Cham-tower

This is one of the surviving ancient works of Cham Pa people in the Central Highlands. Similar to the structures of My Son near Hoi An.

8. Krong Kmar-waterfall

This waterfall is located near the Chu Yang Sin National Park and the water flowing from this waterfall comes from the highest mountain in the region, the Chu Yang Sin mountain.





9. Ea Kao lake

The lake is 12 km from Buon Ma Thuot. The area around the lake is full of green plants and colorful flowers. There are also various cultural events, an amusement park, hotel, flower gardens and restaurants.

10. Ban Don

Three villages at the entrance to Yok Don National Park. This is where the ethnic minorities such as the E De, Khmer, Thai, Lao, Jarai and Mnong people live.



2 DAYS IN DAK LAK

Day 1

- Take a boat trip on Lake Lak
- Visit the ethnic minority villages around the lake
- Go to the Dray Sap and Dray Nur waterfall
- On the way back to Buon Ma Thuot you can pass Ea Kao Lake

Day 2

- Take a full day trip to Yok Don National Park
- Enjoy a boat ride, trekking and elephant watching in the national park



MUI NE

Once, Mui Ne was an isolated stretch of coastline with a small traditional fishing village, where only the truly adventurous travelers camped on the beach. The original fishing village is still there, but today there are more tourists than locals. It has now become a tourist beach destination with a number of luxury hotels, a few cheap hostels, but mainly a mid-range one. The sights on Mui Ne and Phan Thiet range from beautiful beaches, tropical forests and sand dunes to traditional villages, fishing harbor and ancient Cham buildings and ruins.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here 2 days
Most sights in and around Mui Ne can be visited within 1 day, but you mainly come here to relax at the beach for a day or two.

Best time to visit
- Rainy season: between the months of April and October.
- Best time to visit: The best time to enjoy to Mui Ne is from November to March.

Money
There are many ATMs along the main Mui Ne strip.

Getting around
Motorbike or Scooter - The easiest way to explore Mui Ne. Shops and hotels rent them out for 80,000-150,000 dong per day. Be very careful while driving in Mui Ne, little traffic but nobody knows traffic rules.

Bicycles - Some hotels offer bicycles for free or rent them out.

Taxis - are available for further locations. Taxis usually hang outside the larger resorts or have your hotel call one, they will come to you at no extra cost.

Jeep or Bus Tours - To see sights that are usually cheaper than the cost of renting a motorbike with gasoline.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Bus
Bus tickets to Mui Ne can be purchased in the tourist district of Ho Chi Minh City. There are day and night buses. The duration of the trip is 5-7 hours, depending on how much traffic there is on the road. There are also buses to and from Nha Trang (5 hours) and Dalat (6 hours). If you don't want to travel by bus or train, you can take a private car to Mui Ne.

Train
Mui Ne does not have a train station, but the closest is at nearby Phan Thiet, in the northwest corner of the city. There are trains to and from Ho Chi Minh City and to Nha Trang. The red local bus runs from Phan Thiet train station to Ham Tien (the tourist strip) and Mui Ne. Otherwise, metered taxis are available.

RESTAURANTS

- **Surfing Bird's WOK** - Tasty and simple wok dishes.
- **Sindbad** - Small Mediterranean restaurant serving Turkish and Greek food.
- **Choi Oi** - Simple restaurant with cheap but tasty Vietnamese food.
- **Modjo Bar & Restaurant** - Western restaurant with good atmosphere and delicious food.
- **Strawy Restaurant** - Part of Bamboo Village Resort right on the beach serving western and vietnamese food.
- **Lacheln Restaurant** - Good and extensive fish restaurant.
- **El Latino** - Mexican restaurants with delicious homemade nachos and tasty enchilladas.
- **Breeze Restaurant & Bar** - Extensive menu with cheap western, Mexican and Vietnamese dishes.
- **Sandals** - A real beach restaurant right on the sea with good atmosphere and choice of western and vietnamese dishes.

NIGHTLIFE

- **Joe's Café**: Sofas, dining tables, loungers or beach chairs, right on the beach, with billiards, pool, table football, drinks, a BBQ and even a playground for children.
- **Jibe's Beach Club**: Private beach with happy hours from 5pm to 8pm and 10pm to 12 noon.
- **Ratinger Löwe**: Best of German traditional beers
- **Dragon Beach Bar**: Mui Ne's most popular nightlife spot, very busy with locals, tourists and ex-pats. A spacious dance floor, pool, deep house and electro music, along with pole dancing and fire dance shows.
- **Line Up Bar & Grill**: The second busiest nightlife spot. Music, party, showgirls, shisha, fire shows, beer and champagne.
- **Déjà Vu Bar and Restaurant**: A cozy bar with a pool table, a romantic open roof under the starry sky, a tropical garden with a children's playground and an air-conditioned room. On Vietnamese night on Wednesdays, there are shows about Vietnamese folklore, with spiritual values, reflecting traditional fashion and art.

STAYING IN MUI NE

Where to stay

Mui Ne Beach - The beach covers 15 kilometers of sandy beaches where you can enjoy a wide variety of water sports. The northern part is a traditional fishing village, while the southern part houses hotels, shops and souvenir shops.

Recommended accommodations

Sailing Club Resort Mui Ne From $165 Book via: booking.com

A beautiful resort right on the beach with bungalow style rooms and everything is well looked after.

Villa Aria Muine From $100 Book via: booking.com

Beautiful beachfront resort with pool and modern rooms.

Muine Bay Resort From $60 Book via: booking.com

Nice pool, beach at the hotel, nice sunbeds, good service, nice hotel.

Hoang Ngoc Beach Resort From $50 Book via: booking.com

Beautiful resort right on the beach with pool and neat rooms.

Bao Quynh Bungalow From $50 Book via: booking.com

Bungalows and hotel rooms close to the beach and located in a beautiful garden.

Cocosand Hotel From $16 Book via: booking.com

Neat but basic rooms and restaurants and bars within walking distance.

Vietnam Backpacker Hostels - Mui Ne From $7 Book via: booking.com

Very popular and attractive hostel with swimming pool, pool table and bar.

Mui Ne Hills Backpackers From $3 Book via: booking.com

Clean and cozy backpackers hostel with 2 swimming pools and a lot of organized activities.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Relax on the beaches

Mui Ne has 10 kilometers of sandy beaches and more if you continue along the coast. There is always a stretch of beach to yourself where you can sunbathe or cool off with a dip in the sea.

2. Sand dunes

The white and red sand dunes are a must. It is a small piece of desert in Vietnam. You can even rent a quad and drive to the dune tops or slide down with a sled.





3. Wind or kite surfing

Kitesurfing or windsurfing are both very popular as it is one of the top places in Asia to do it. There are many kitesurfing schools in Mui Ne for all levels at competitive prices.

4. Fairy Stream

Walk through the crystal clear, single deep water. The colors mixed of brown, red and yellow make for Instagram-worthy photos and there is a small waterfall at the end.





5. Mui Ne harbor

On the north side of the bay you will find a beautiful view over the bay which is full of colorful fishing boats. It really is a beautiful place to stop, even if just for a quick picture.

6. The local fish market

Mui Ne's chaotic morning market offers a fascinating glimpse into the lives of local Vietnamese fishermen. Every morning they get their catch to shore.





7. Visit the Cham tower

Po Shanu Cham towers show you the remains of the Champa Empire. The temple dates back to the ninth century and is located on a hill between Mui Ne and Phan Thiet.

8. Ke Ga lighthouse

Thirty kilometers south of Mui Ne along the coast is an area known for the lighthouse on a small island. Here you will also find a beautiful beach.





9. Ta Cu Mountain and the Reclining Buddha

Ta Cu Mountain is made up of lush rainforests, rare flora and fauna, limestone caves and ornate Buddhist structures.

10. Sunrise and sunset

Choose to sit on the beach, watch from the fishing village, or atop one of the white or red sand dunes for incredible skies.



2 DAYS IN MUI NE

Day 1

- Start early in the morning for Mui Ne harbor and the local fish market.
- Drive to the white sand dunes and grab a beach along the way.
- Walk through the Fairy Stream
- End the day with a sunset in the red dunes.
- Enjoy a drink by the beach.

Day 2

- Option 1: Take a kitesurfing or windsurfing course. You can enjoy the rest of the afternoon on the beach.
- Opti 2: Visit Po Shanu Cham Towers, visit The Prince's Castle and Ta Cu Mountain. On the way you will drive through Phant Thiet town.



HO CHI MINH CITY

Ho Chi Minh City, of Saigon, is de grootste en meest chaotische stad van Vietnam. Het is het zakelijke en financiële centrum van Vietnam, met een prominente geschiedenis die al honderden jaren terug-gaat. Het is een stad met een miljard dingen tegelijk. De stad heeft veel te bieden: prachtige winkels, fantastisch nachtleven, goede musea en heerlijk eten.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 2-3 days
Ho Chi Minh Citi is een goede basis om de Mekong Delta te bezoeken. Hier is ook het beste nachtleven van het land te vinden en een paar van de beste museums.

Best time to visit
- Februari: Nauwelijks regen, de minste vochtigheid en een stad vol met bloemen voor de Tet-feesten.
- Maart: Weinig regen en luchtvochtigheid, plus de jaarlijkse fiets-race.
- December: December is koeler dan normaal voor HCMC en relatief droog.

Money
Banks and ATMs can be found everywhere. Money changers and gold traders at Ben Thanh Market are the first choice of locals and visitors when it comes to exchanging currencies.

Getting around
Walking: Most places of interest are close to each other in the center. A great way to explore the city is therefore on foot.

Taxi: Metered taxis drive through the streets. The price is around 12.000d for the first kilometer. Use Mai Linh Taxi and Vinasun Taxi. An even better alternative is Grab (similar to Uber in the Netherlands). Grab also has motorcycle taxis; perfect for solo travelers.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Flights
Vietnam's constantly expanding network of domestic flights connects Ho Chi Minh City to every other major city in the country, which is good news for visitors with limited time. Prices are reasonable, and flying to places like Hanoi, Hue, Nha Trang and DaLat saves a lot of time.

Bus
The cheapest way from or to another city in Vietnam to/from Ho Chi Minh City is by bus. The bus to Dalat takes about 7 hours and Nha Trang 22 hours. There are also buses to Mui Ne and the Mekong Delta, although it can often be more convenient for the Mekong to explore this area by tour.

Train
Trains to the north of Vietnam start from Saigon Train Station. There are trains to Mui Ne, Nha Trang, Quy Nhon and Hoi An and further north to Sapa and across the border to China.

RESTAURANTS

- **Poke Saigon** - You can create your own bowl with many different toppings.
- **Cyclo Resto** - Choice of 4 set menus, all good quality and delicious food.
- **Bun Cha 145** - Bun Cha is a delicious Hanoi dish made from vermicelli noodles, grilled pork patties, a stock, fish sauce, and pickled papaya and carrot.
- **Bep Me In** - Delicious authentic Vietnamese dishes in a cozy setting.
- **Royal Saigon Restaurant** - Right in the entertainment area with good food and good service.
  Baba's Kitchen - Good place if you like indian food.
- **Home Finest Saigon Restaurant** - Slightly more expensive, but nice restaurant with regular live music. Good service and delicious food.
- **Noir. Dining In The Dark** - A unique concept where you eat in the completely dark restaurant.

NIGHTLIFE

- **Bui Vien Street**: It is the backpacker hub of the city, welcoming a mix of foreigners and local Vietnamese who mingle freely and chat all night, drinking cheap beers on small plastic bar stools lining the street. There are also many inexpensive restaurants and several nightclubs if you want to hit the dance floor later in the evening.
- **Cocktails op een Rooftop Bar**: The city has one of the most impressive collections of rooftop bars in the world. The best known and most popular are Saigon Saigon, Chill Skybar, Rex Rooftop Garden and Glow Skybar Saigon.
- **Saigon Opera House**: For the culturally inclined, with a variety of performing arts, ballet, music concerts, traditional Vietnamese dance and live theatre, most notably the AO show.

STAYING IN HO CHI MINH CITY

Where to stay

District 1 - Always try to find a hotel in the center (district 1). From here you are close to the sights, many restaurants and nightlife. In addition, day tours guarantee a pick-up service from district one, but this does not always apply to other districts.

Recommended accommodations

Grand Hotel Saigon From $120 Book via: booking.com

In this beautiful colonial building you will find a super de luxe hotel right in the center. Colonial history is reflected in the rooms and there is a swimming pool on the roof.

Rex Hotel From $87 Book via: booking.com

A colonial building with a history, right in the center within walking distance of the most famous sights.

Silverland Jolie Hotel & Spa From $75 Book via: booking.com

Located in a quiet area in the center, overlooking the river. You'll find an outdoor jacuzzi, a rooftop bar and a restaurant.

Huong Sen Annex Hotel From $55 Book via: booking.com

A hotel with a pool right in the center (District 1), close to Nguyen Walking Street, City Hall and Saigon Post Office.

Chez Mimosa – Boutique Hotel From $35 Book via: booking.com

This cozy boutique hotel is also located in district 1. It was created as a combination between a hotel and a house.

Jan Hostel Central Park From $25 Book via: booking.com

This hotel is very small, but that also creates a good personal atmosphere. With a low budget you get a nice and modern room at this hotel.

Sunland Saigon Riverside Hotel From $20 Book via: booking.com

This hotel has both normal rooms and capsules, which is why prices start from twenty euros.

The Hideout From $5 Book via: booking.com

It is mainly seen as a "party hostel" with 2 free beers, its own rooftop bar and they organize pub crawl.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Cu Chi Tunnels

The tunnels were used by the Vietcong to attack the Americans. Some of the Cu Chi Tunnels have been widened so that tourists can view them now.

2. War Remnants Museum

This is the most impressive museum about this war there is. Outside there are abandoned vehicles such as tanks, cannons, planes and helicopters.





3. French Colonial Buildings

The most famous are the Central Post Office, Notre-Dame Cathedral of Saigon, the Ho Chi Minh City People's Committee, and the Saigon Opera House.

4. Street food tour on the back of a scooter

With a street food tour you sit on the back of the scooter and travel like a real local from place to place to try the best food on the street.





5. Nightlife

Enjoy a cheap drink in Bui Vien Street, the famous backpacker street with bars and street stalls. You can also visit one of the clubs or go to one of the best rooftop bars in Asia.

6. Reunification Palace

This is the site of those famous images of tanks driving through the gates of Saigon in the fall of 1975, heralding the end of the Vietnam War.





7. Bitexco Financial Tower

On the 49th floor you will find the Skydeck, with a beautiful 360 degree view. From the 50th to the 52nd you will find restaurants and the EON Heli Bar. At the very top you will find The World of Heineken

8. Nguyen Hue Walking Street

For one of the best spots of social and dating life in Ho Chi Minh City, head to Nguyen Hue Walking Street.





9. Markets

You can experience the daily life of the locals here. The two most famous markets are Ben Thanh Market in District 1 and Binh Tay Market in Chinatown.

10. Saigon river

The best thing to do is take a boat trip down the river; you have several options. In the evening you can take a dinner cruise and during the day take a boat trip to the secret city canals where the locals live.



2 DAYS IN HO CHI MINH CITY

Day 1

- Take a city tour and explore landmarks such as Ben Thanh Market, Reunification Palace, War Remnants Museum, Post Office and Notre Dame Cathedral.
- In the evening, take a food tour on the back of the motorcycle.

Day 2

- In the morning you will take a half day trip to the Cu Chi Tunnels.
- In the afternoon explore Chinatown. In the evening you take a river cruise with dinner.
- End the day at a rooftop bar with a cocktail.



MEKONG DELTA

Many tourists think they can see enough of the Mekong Delta on a short day trip from Ho Chi Minh City. However, there is so much more than a pagoda and a floating market. This region is home to unique ecosystems and diverse unique communities.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here 2 days
The Mekong Delta is huge, but if you choose 1 destination, 2 days are often enough to see all the highlights.

Best time to visit
- The weather is pleasant all year round. Even when it rains, you can still see interesting aspects of local life.
- If you want to avoid the rain, visit the Mekong Delta between December and March.
- May to August: Summer in Vietnam and this is the season when a lot of fruit grows in the area.
- Rainy Season: September to November is the rainy season with lots of flooding.

Money
ATMs are mainly found in the cities. Cash is preferred, but debit and credit cards can be used in many hotels.

Getting around
Taxis are everywhere in Hue, although there are a few that will take you on quite a detour if you're unfamiliar with the area. To avoid this, look out for the Green Mai Linh or Yellow Taxi Vang, which use both meters.

Cyclos and motorcycle taxis are very popular. Drivers will quote an amount they think they can get, so you should come up with a price that you think is reasonable.

Cycling is best suited for those who want to do sightseeing on their own in and around downtown Hue. There are plenty of hostels and bike shops with daily rates between VND 25,000 and VND 30,000.

MEKONG DELTA REGIONS

My Tho - An important market town in the Mekong region. Being a local trade center, this town is quite busy compared to some of the quieter destinations in the area.

Ben Tre - Just a short drive past busy My Tho, you'll find tranquil Ben Tre. Stay here for the tranquility of this area and enjoy the beautiful natural surroundings of tropical flowers and green waterways.

Can Tho - The largest city in the Mekong Delta, it is also one of the most popular destinations in the Delta region, mainly due to its famous floating markets. It is an important transport hub for the surrounding towns and villages.

Chau Doc- An Giang province is a place where few tourists come, except Chau Doc, a border town. Vast rice fields, villages, submerged forests and small floating markets.



MY THO

Just a two-hour drive from Ho Chi Minh City, you will arrive at the Mekong River and My Tho, the provincial capital of Tien Giang Province and the gateway to the Mekong Delta. Today, My Tho's proximity to Ho Chi Minh City means huge tourism potential as it can be done in a day. In fact, an organized day tour is how the vast majority of people are here.

4 highlights



1. Boat trips in My Tho

Around My Tho there are many small islands that you can visit by boat. On the islands you will visit fruit plantations, bee farms, villages and local factories.



2. Vinh Trang Pagoda

Vinh Trang Pagoda is the largest temple in the province. Bringing together Chinese, Vietnamese, Khmer and European architecture, the pagoda has several Buddha statues.



3. My Tho market

While most travelers are still asleep, the vendors in My Tho Central Market (Cho My Tho) are already in full swing. A fascinating walk through the market is a good way to fill the time in a city.



4. Cai Be floating market

As the name suggests, the Cai Be floating market is not located in My Tho but in Cai Be. But because this place is only 40 km from My Tho, these sights are often combined.

Recommended accommodations

Happy Farm Tien Giang Homestay From $16 Book via: booking.com

The Farmstay is run by a very friendly family and together with the many animals they make it a pleasant place. Beautiful quiet large garden.

The World Hotel From $14 Book via: booking.com

Clean and modern rooms with soft beds.

The Island Lodge From $180 Book via: booking.com

Boutique lodge located on an island Thoi Son (Unicorn). Wrapped in a manicured tropical garden with palm trees, the property features an elegant open-air reception and restaurant.

How do you get there?

Tour
Like most other destinations in the Mekong Delta, My Tho is most frequently visited by tour from Ho Chi Minh City. A day trip is the most popular, as My Tho is the closest city in the Mekong Delta from Ho Chi Minh City.

By bus
There are buses and limousine vans from Ho Chi Minh City to My Tho. Most include hotel drop-off in My Tho, but do not include pick-up from your accommodation in Saigon. The journey takes 2 hours and costs between $ 2.5 and $ 6 depending on which quality transfer you choose.

Private car
Instead of by bus, you can also rent a car with a driver who will pick you up directly from the hotel in Ho Chi Minh City and take you to My Tho. The advantage is also that you can arrange with a driver to visit some sights along the way.

BEN TRE

Just a short bus ride from Ho Chi Minh City, Ben Tre is located in the Mekong Delta; one of the most beautiful, untouched and authentic provinces of Vietnam. And the tranquility of Ben Tre is unbelievably great. The province's main town, also called Ben Tre, showcases simple Vietnamese small-town life.

4 highlights



1. Boat trip
During a boat trip you can visit local villages, fruit orchards and islands. You can see how local life uses the rivers for mainly collecting and distributing coconuts.



2. Cycling
Ben Tre is a good place for cycling. Large and flat with many rice fields. From the city, cross the river and go east and just keep going. The further you go, the more beautiful it gets.



3. Vam Ho Bird Sanctuary
An underwater reserve. This spectacular place contains many wild forests including coconut trees, dates, mangroves and reeds. This is a favorite destination for many animals, especially birds.



4. Local villages
Around Ben Tre you will find many local craft villages and ecotourism zones. In each village they have their own craft, such as fruit and orchards, rice paper and coconut handicrafts.

Recommended accommodations

Mekong Home From $51 Book via: booking.com

A unique experience, in a beautiful location on the river, away from the crowds. Beautiful resort-like residence, with swimming pool, bar and beautiful bungalows.

Mango Home Riverside From $35 Book via: booking.com

The view from the hotel is beautiful. There is also a lovely swimming pool and a bar. Friendly staff and free bikes to borrow.

Quoc Phuong Riverside Homestay From $15 Book via: booking.com

The Homestay is located in the middle of the fruit trees, away from the crowds and right next to the river. Comfortable rooms.

How do you get there?

Tour
The most popular way to see Ben Tre is on a tour. Pay close attention to what kind of tour you book. You have tours in which you visit Ben Tre in 1 day from Ho Chi Minh City and return the same day. If you are short on time, you can opt for this. In addition, you also have many cheap tours, where you explore the region in a bus with a large group. These large group tours are generally not recommended.

Bus
Futa Bus has a bus every hour from Ho Chi Minh City to Ben Tre. The bus departs from Mien Tay bus station and the journey takes approximately 2 hours. There are also a lot of local buses that commute between these cities, but are longer on the way.

Car
Often you can rent a car through your accommodation that will pick you up from Ho Chi Minh City and take you directly to your accommodation in Ben Tre.

CAN THO

Can Tho is the largest city in the beautiful Mekong Delta in southern Vietnam. Located on the banks of the Hau River, it serves as the political and commercial center of the Mekong. Famous for its mesmerizing floating markets, beautiful temples and delicious food, Can Tho is a great starting point to discover the maze of waterways that make up the Mekong Delta. It also has temples, great nature and many cozy villages that you can visit by bike.

4 highlights



1. Cai Rang Floating Market
Cai Rang Floating Market is the largest and most impressive floating market in Vietnam. To see the market at its peak you have to get up early, because the market starts from 5 o'clock.



2. Boat trip through the canals
While the markets are the highlight, the peace and tranquility of slowly navigating the back-waters and the slow pace of life in the surrounding villages is just as delightful.



3. Cycling
an Tho is surrounded by beautiful nature, rice fields and quaint villages and the best way to see it all is by taking a bike ride around the area.



4. Bang Lang stork garden
The Bang Lang Stork Sanctuary is one of the few places in Can Tho to see the biodiversity of the Mekong Delta wetlands.

Recommended accommodations

Can Tho Ecolodge From $55 Book via: booking.com

Great beautiful place; great pool, nice location, comfortable rooms and really helpful staff.

Farmer Homestay From $32 Book via: booking.com

A friendly family who run a beautiful homestay. A local experience in comfort.

Nguyen Shack - Mekong Can Tho From $11 Book via: booking.com

The idea that you are really staying in the middle of nature. Unique location and real local experience.

How do you get there?

Bus from Ho Chi Minh City
If you're planning to visit Ho Chi Minh City before traveling to Can Tho, it's best to hop on a bus as there are tons of transportation services to this city. The total travel time from Saigon to Can Tho is only about three to five hours, depending on traffic. Tickets can be booked in advance or at the bus station.

Flights to Can Tho
The good news is that you can easily reach Can Tho by plane from Hanoi, Saigon, Da Nang and Phu Quoc. Depending on your time, interest and budget, you can choose Vietnam Airlines, Vietjet Air or Bamboo Airways whose average price ranges from USD 30 to USD 100 per flight ticket

Chau Doc

An Giang is a province in the Mekong Delta, bordering Cambodia. It is a place where few tourists come, so it still feels very authentic. A place where everything revolves around the rivers, floating markets, fishing and one of the most beautiful rice fields in the region.

4 highlights



1. Tra Su Forest
All trees have sunk deep into the water, creating a unique environment. It is the habitat for many colonies of waterfowl, bats and even rare and endangered animals and reptile species.



2. Long Xuyen floating market
The Long Xuyen Floating Market is not as large as other floating markets in the Mekong Delta, but it is a bustling market with hundreds of boats congregating to trade during rush hours.



3. Ta Pa rice fields
Eén van de mooiste rijstvelden in de Mekong Delta kun je vinden in An Giang. Om specifiek te zijn, de rijstvelden bij Ta Pa.



4. Sam Mountain
This "mountain", which is more of a hill, has two main attractions; a cluster of temples on the northern base and the viewpoint from the top.

Recommended accommodations

Victoria Chau Doc Hotel From $75 Book via: booking.com

Stay in style in this historic building at the Three Rivers Point. It has a pool with sun loungers on the river side.

Sang Như Ngọc Resort From $31 Book via: booking.com

More in the countryside of An Giang, with beautiful views of the surrounding area. Bungalow style resort with swimming pool.

The Luxe Hotel Châu Đốc From $20 Book via: booking.com

In Chau Doc the best hotel for this price; comfortable and good looking rooms.

How do you get there?

From Ho Chi Minh City to An Giang
There are direct buses from Ho Chi Minh City to An Giang. The bus journey takes about 6 hours and prices are around 120,000 VND. You can book the tickets in advance via vexere.

By tour
An Giang is located a lot deeper in the Mekong Delta from Ho Chi Minh City as My Tho, Ben Tre, Can Tho and Ving Long. For that reason, tours to An Giang are less popular. Still, a tour may be the best option as it can be difficult to travel in that region on your own.



PHU QUOC

Phu Quoc is a beautiful island with crystal clear waters, incredible sunsets, lush tropical landscapes, perfect sandy beaches and hospitable inhabitants. It is the largest island in Vietnam, the same size as Phuket in Thailand. The northern part of the island is relatively untouched due to its status as a UNESCO-listed national park, but there are plenty of luxury resorts, funky bars and cafes along the southern coastline.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 2-3 days
There are hardly any sights to be found on this island. This is where you stay, often at the end of a tour, to relax and enjoy the beaches.

Best time to visit
- High season – November to March: the weather is extremely pleasant with an average temperature of 30 degrees and clear skies.
- Shoulder season – April to June: the hottest months on the island. Chance of good weather is fifty-fifty.
- Low season – July to September: it rains everywhere.

Money
In the larger towns such as Duong Dong there are banks and ATMs. Less in smaller villages, so bring enough cash with you.

Getting around
Taxis are readily available outside Phu Quoc International Airport, as well as prominent resorts and points of interest on the island. It is also possible to rent a car with driver for a day that takes you around the island.

Motorbikes and scooters are ideal if you want to explore Phu Quoc at your own pace, with daily rates ranging between VND 120,000 and VND 250,000.

Bike rental is offered by most hotels and resorts on Phu Quoc Island for about US $1 per day. Ideal for short trips within Duong Dong and Long Beach.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Flights
Phu Quoc International Airport (PQC) is located on the south side of Long Beach, about nine kilometers from Duong Dong city. There are several flights a day from Ho Chi Minh City and Hanoi.

Ferry
Weather permitting, ferries make the trip a few times a day, from Ha Tien (1.5 hours) and Rach Gia (2.5 hours) to Phu Quoc and vice versa. The vast majority of travelers take the Superdong fast ferry, which is efficient, orderly, air-conditioned and comfortable.

RESTAURANTS

- **Mango Bay Restaurant** - Right on the beach, good location for sunrise.
- **The Home Pizza** - For when you don't want rice and noodles. Very good pizzas.
- **Saigonese Eatery** - Good Vietnamese food and vegetarian options available.
- **Winston's Burgers & Beer** - Very good (western) burgers.
- **The Spice House at Cassia Cottage** - Extensive menu, luxurious appearance and beautifully situated on the beach.
- **Crab House Restaurant** - If you like fish this is the best choice.
- **Thu Phuong Restaurant** - Don't expect much atmosphere, but good food for a very reasonable price.

NIGHTLIFE

- **La Veranda Beach Bar:** A luxury resorts in the heart of Long Beach. A great place to watch Long Beach's famous sunset in a chic setting.
- **Golden Sand Bar:** Various drinks, a beautiful wooden beach terrace and many beach chairs.
- **Eden Beach Bar**: It's a great place to hang out during the day and enjoy the beach life.
- **An Duong:** Located just above the water. The food here is quite pricey, but the drinks are decent.
- **Xin Chao**: A great place for beer, cocktails, socializing and people watching.
- **Boba Club**: A large dance club, a beer garden and a restaurant with live DJs and go-go dancers.
- **Coco Bar**: Cozy bar with pool table, beer and various cocktails.
- **Beer Garden**: Simple open air bar serves relatively cheap food and only serves beers on tap, which are brewed on the island.

STAYING IN PHU QUOC

Where to stay

Duong Dong - The heart of the island, centrally located to everything. The premier place for entertainment, shopping, dining and sightseeing.

Ong Lang - Famous backpackers village with a great local beach. Always full of tourists in high season, with many choices for budget hotels & guest houses.

An Thoi - An Thoi town is the main port of Phu Quoc, with an old fishing village. Not really a place to stay unless you are staying at the beautiful 6 star Marriot hotel.

Cua Can - Not yet affected by tourism and industrialization. Tourists can immerse themselves in the real local life of Phu Quoc in the unspoilt old fishing village.

Vung Bau - Located along the coast and part of the national park. There are some beautiful resorts here, beautiful and wild. Technically in the middle of the jungle, ideal for adventurers and nature lovers.

Ganh Dau - Is 80% national park and now mostly owned by the Vingroup, the largest company in Vietnam and also the largest complex on the island. There is a Disneyland-style amusement park, a 5-star hotel, a 5-star villa resort, a casino, a golf course, a western standard hospital and even a zoo.

Recommended accommodations

Dusit Princess Moonrise Beach Resort From $130 Book via: booking.com

Beautiful resort right on the beach with infinity pool and free shuttle bus to/from the airport.

Ancarine Beach Resort From $80 Book via: booking.com

A beautiful bungalow style resort right on the beach.

Lahana Resort Phu Quoc From $75 Book via: booking.com

A beautifully designed resort with bungalows among the palm trees and a large swimming pool.

Nadine Phu Quoc Resort & Spa From $50 Book via: booking.com

Hotel in Duong Dong with beautiful garden and within walking distance of the center and the beach.

Cottage Village From $40 Book via: booking.com

Nice and modern rooms in a hotel and bungalows in Ong Lang.

Little Garden Bungalow From $25 Book via: booking.com

For relatively little money a very nice bungalow room with a swimming pool.

9 Station Hostel From $6 Book via: booking.com

Popular hostel in Duong Dong with pool and modern rooms.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Enjoy the most beautiful beaches

Bai Truong is the beach with the most hotels and resorts. The most beautiful beach is Bai Sao. Bai Ong Lang and Bai Cua Can are other quiet and beautiful beaches.

2. island hopping

There are several smaller islands around the “main island” of Phu Quoc that you can visit by boat. The most beautiful are the An Thoi Islands.





3. Diving and snorkeling

The best diving and snorkelling spots can be found around the An Thoi Islands in the south.

4. Sunset BBQ

In various places you can enjoy the sunset directly on the beach where a dinner is prepared on the BBQ.





5. Phu Quoc prison

During the Vietnam War, a detention camp was built by the Viet Cong to capture South Vietnamese soldiers. This prison is now a museum that you can visit.

6. Suoi Tranh waterfall

A fascinating part of the city where you can enjoy beautiful colonial architecture packed along narrow streets, with endless traffic of scooters, zigzagging around merchants.





7. Duong Dong Market

The largest market of Phu Quoc. Visit in the morning where you can watch locals bargain hard for household items, fresh seafood, meats, sweets and fruits.

8. Visit plantations and factories

Phu Quoc is known for their chillies and the famous fish sauce used in almost every dish. You can visit local fish sauce factories and pepper plantations.





9. Ganh Dau cape

Located in the extreme northwest of the island. Here you will find a beautiful beach with a traditional fishing village where you can see how the people live from fishing.

10. Eat fresh fish

You can find a huge range of fresh fish and seafood. Almost every local restaurant specializes in this.



2 DAYS IN HANOI

Day 1

- Explore the island on a motorbike or car with a driver.
- Learn about the Vietnamese Revolution at the Phu Quoc prison museum.
- Take a walk on the sands of Sao Beach.
- Visit a local pepper plantation.
- Explore the Suoi Tranh waterfall.
- Enjoy the sunset on Long Beach with a cocktail.

Day 2

- Option 1: Take a day trip to the An Thoi Islands.
- You can visit various islands by boat and explore the underwater world with snorkelling.
- Option 2: Alternatively, you can also take a diving excursion.



CON DAO

Con Dao is an archipelago off the southeast coast of Vietnam. They are known for their sandy beaches, coral reefs and marine life. The coast of Bay Canh Island is a breeding ground for turtles and there are many dive sites in the surrounding clear waters. At the eastern tip of the island, there is a trail through the forest to the colonial-era Bay Canh lighthouse. This place offers a panoramic view.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

Stay here for 2-3 days
Con Dao is a small island, but you can stay here for a few days if you combine activities with beach days.

Best time to visit

- The best time to visit the Con Dao Islands is during the dry season (November to February), but if you want to see turtles nesting on Hon Bay Canh Island, visit between June and September.

Money
Con Dao has ATMs.

Getting around
Boat
Exploring the islands by boat can be arranged through your hotel. A 12 person boat costs about 2,000,000d to 5,000,000d per day depending on the destinations. Local fishermen also offer excursions, but be sure to bargain hard.

Rent a motorbike or bicycle
This is one of the best places in Vietnam for cycling, with little traffic, no pollution and good paved roads. There is only one main road, connecting the airport in the north to Ben Dam in the south via the town of Con Son. Most hotels rent motorbikes for about US$6 to US$10 per day. Bicycles cost about US$2 per day. There are good coastal cycle routes.

Cab
Con Son Island has several taxis. However, because the taximeter rates are very high, always try to meet for a fixed price to destinations outside Con Son town and try to negotiate well.

HOW DO YOU GET THERE?

Flights
There are nine daily flights between Con Son and Ho Chi Minh City, all of which are operated by Vietnam Airlines. The cost for a one-way ticket is from $70. There are also two flights a day from Can Tho in the Mekong Delta, starting at $50. From other destinations in Vietnam you always have to transfer in HCMC.

Boot
There is a 12-hour ferry and speedboat ferry that runs to Con Dao from both Vung Tau, on the mainland near Ho Chi Minh City, and Tran De, in the Mekong Delta. Please note that the routes to Con Dao are sometimes canceled due to rough seas.

RESTAURANTS

More and more restaurants are opening on Con Dao. Western food is also increasingly available. Most larger hotels have restaurants serving good food, but be prepared to pay a little more than mainland prices. Also, hotels may not have everything on their menu available.

STAYING IN CON DAO

Where to stay

Con Dao city and Con Son Bay are where you will find the most places of interest. You should also look for a hotel here. Other parts of the island are calm and quiet, with expensive resorts here and there.

Recommended accommodations

Poulo Condor Boutique Resort & Spa From $150 Book via: booking.com

A beautiful villa, the entire resort has been furnished with great taste and (eco) attention. Attentive staff who do everything they can to make you feel comfortable.

Tan Son Nhat Con Dao Resort From $55 Book via: booking.com

Beautiful resort with large bungalows right on the beach. Staff very friendly and at the reception they speak good English.

Villa Maison Con Dao Boutique Hotel From $45 Book via: booking.com

Very nice small-scale facility, only 7 rooms, in a good location. Rooms are comfortable and have a nice mattress and a delicious breakfast included.

Hotel De Condor From $22 Book via: booking.com

Super friendly staff and nicely decorated, clean and spacious rooms.

Little Home From $15 Book via: booking.com

Little Home is run by a very friendly host. The rooms are clean and spacious with comfortable beds.

10 HIGHLIGHTS



1. Hiking through the National Park

Most of all the islands of Con Dao belong to the Con Dao National Park. It is a beautiful area for walkers to go hiking.

2. Diving

Con Dao long has the most pristine sea in Vietnam. The waters around the islands are officially protected and there is a lot of coral to see. Diving is possible all year round, but ideal conditions are January to June.





3. Watching turtles

The largest population of sea turtles in Vietnam come here every year to breed from the Philippines. The nesting season runs from May to October and peaks from June to September. Every year there are about 400 sea turtles.

4. Beaches

The best beach on the island is Bai Dat Doc, a pretty bay made up of a kilometer-long crescent of light sand, surrounded by hills. Dam Trau Beach is the second best beach on the island.





5. Prisons

Phu Hai Prison is the largest of the 11 prisons on the island, dating back to 1862. Thousands of inmates were held here, with up to 200 inmates crammed into each detention building.

6. Thanh Gia Mountain

Thanh Gia Mountain is met 577m hoog de hoogste berg in Con Dao. Op mooie dagen heb je op de top van de berg een panoramisch uitzicht over Con Son Island.





7. Con Dao Museum

This impressive museum has more than 2000 items, including many rare documents, dioramas and excellent photographs, which fully describe the history of the islands, including the French colonial era.

8. Eiland hoppen

Around the main island of Con Dao you will find a number of other islands that you can visit with a boat trip.





9. Market

Visit the local market to gain insight into the daily life of the Con Dao islanders.

10. Hang Duong cemetery

About 20,000 Vietnamese inmates died on Con Son, and nearly 2,000 of their graves can be seen in the Hang Duong Cemetery, located on the eastern edge of the city. Unfortunately, only 700 of these graves have names.



2 DAYS IN CON DAO

Day 1

- Take a hiking or diving excursion.
- Some rainforest walks you can do on your own. You can also get free hiking maps from your hotel.
- For diving, there are 35 dive/snorkel sites to choose from.

Day 2

- Sunrise at Ca Map Cape.
- Breakfast and shopping at Con Dao Market
- Learn about the culture and history of Con Dao. Visit the Con Dao Prison, Con Dao Museum, Ham Duong War Cemetery, Nui Mot Pagoda, and An Son Shrine.

CULTURE

DO'S & DON'TS

Vietnamese are friendly and tolerant and understand that western tourists have different customs. Still, it's useful to know what you should and shouldn't do as a traveler to show your respect.

Do

- ✓ Always treat Buddhist monks and elders with high respect and take care not to touch them, especially monks
- ✓ Vietnam is a conservative country, so be mindful of what you wear when traveling around the country. The dress code is more relaxed in the big cities. Shorts and tank tops are fine, but don't go out in your swimming trunks or bikini.
- ✓ When you visit a temple, holy place or museum, you pay extra attention to what you wear.
- ✓ Remove your shoes/sandals before entering a residence. Even some hostels, homestays and shops require you to take off your shoes before entering.
- ✓ Negotiation is normal in Vietnam, but always do it in a good way when shopping, calm and friendly.
- ✓ Use both hands to pass things on to older people
- ✓ Try to eat the food offered, it shows that you enjoy the food.

Not to do

- × Don't greet people with your hands folded and a bow. This is only done for the dead.
- × When you sit down in someone's home, don't point your feet at the family altar.
- × Don't show your affection for your loved ones too much in public. You can walk hand in hand, but don't kiss and hug when many people can see it.
- × Do not take a picture of people without asking permission.
- × Don't ask street vendors to show their goods if you don't intend to buy anything
- × Do not take pictures of anything related to the military as this could be considered a breach of national security.
- × Don't wear too much jewelry. This is incisive and increases the chance of robbery.

RELIGION

In the past, during the strict communist times, religions were banned. Today old and new religions are becoming more common. The religion in Vietnam has been influenced by the Chinese, mainly a mixture of Buddhism, Taoism and Confucianism. During the colonization of Vietnam, Catholicism spread among the Vietnamese. Most Vietnamese do not call themselves religious, even though they regularly go to a temple. Many Vietnamese are very superstitious..

THE PEOPLE

Vietnamese are a special mix of cultures, languages and historical backgrounds. The only common denominator among them is that, as in most Southeast Asian countries, they like to smile and are genuinely interested in foreign visitors. In many ways, Vietnam is still a traditional, conservative society, especially for the older generation, who remember the long, hard years and every inch of the territory they fought for. The new generation of Vietnamese is largely unfamiliar with the devastation the country suffered years ago. For them, Vietnam is very different: a place to succeed and ignore the staid structures of the communists.

The Vietnamese people
Vietnamese culture and civilization have been deeply influenced by the Chinese, who occupied the country for 1000 years and whose culture deeply permeates Vietnamese society. History has, of course, influenced the mix of Vietnamese minorities. The steady expansion southwards in search of cultivable lands first absorbed the Kingdom of Champa and later the eastern extent of the Khmer Empire; both Chams and Khmers are large minorities today.

Family
n Vietnam, family status is more important than salary. A family's reputation commands respect and opens doors. Extended family is important to the Vietnamese and that includes second or third cousins, the kind of family that in the Netherlands you may not even realize you have them. The extended family comes together in times of trouble and times of joy, celebrating festivals and successes, grieving deaths or disappointments. This is a source of strength for many of the older generations.

ETHNICAL MINORITIES

Vietnam has a large number of ethnic groups. Most of the inhabitants belong to the Viet, the ethnic Vietnamese who make up 88% of the population. Vietnam has 53 ethnic minority groups (about 14 million people). Most live in Northern Vietnam and live in the lush mountain landscapes along the border of China and Laos. Some groups have lived in Vietnam for millennia, while the Hmong emigrated south from China in recent centuries. Each has its own language, customs, fashion of clothing and spiritual beliefs.

The government has long encouraged hill tribes to move to lower areas to farm rice, tea and coffee, with incentives such as subsidized irrigation, better education and health care. But the hill tribe's long history of independence keeps many away from the lowlands.

- **Tay** (population 1.6 million) Live at low elevations between Hanoi and the Chinese border. They closely adhere to Vietnamese beliefs in Buddhism, Confucianism, and Taoism, but many also worship geniuses and local spirits. Tay literature and art are famous all over Vietnam.
- **Thai**: EA large group (1.5 million inhabitants) originating in southern China, settled along the fertile riverbeds between Hoa Binh and Muong Lay. Villages consist of thatched houses built on bamboo poles. The Thai minority is usually categorized by color: red, black and white. Black Thai women wear bright colored blouses and headwear.
- **Muong**: Mainly concentrated in Hoa Binh province, the male-dominated Muong (population 1.4 million) live in small hamlets in houses on stilts and are known for their folk literature, poems and music (performed by gongs, drums, flutes and string violin)
- **Hmong**: Rond een miljoen Hmong liggen verspreid over de verre noordelijke bergen. De meesten zijn animisten, die droge rijst cultiveren en dieren fokken. Elke Hmong-groep – zwart, wit, rood, groen en flower – heeft zijn eigen dresscode.
- **Nung**: This tribe (population 800,000) lives in small villages in the northeastern provinces; their culture combines ancestral worship and have a knack for handicrafts.
- **Jarai**: These people (350,000) of the south-central highlands still practice animistic rituals, respecting their ancestors and nature through a yang (genius). Jarai's burial grounds are extensive, including carved totem-like effigies of the deceased.
- **Sedang**: The 150,000 Sedang of the south-central highlands bear no surnames, and complete gender equality is said to exist.

HISTORY

This timeline below shows you the history of Vietnam in broad strokes.

3000BC – 1000BC Tribes from southern China moved to the Red River Delta area.

208BC – The Chinese general Trieu Da makes himself emperor of Nam Viet (part of present-day northern Vietnam and China).

111BC – Han Chinese Emperor Wu conquers the Viet people, beginning nearly 1,000 years of Chinese rule in the north.

40AD – Two Trung sisters led a rebel army against the Chinese; they have temporarily overthrown the Han and proclaim themselves queens of an independent Vietnam. China takes everything back and the capital moves to Hanoi.

939 – The Chinese are kicked out of Vietnam after 1,000 years of occupation, when Ngo Quyen leads his people to victory in the Battle of the Bach Dang River. The Viet Kingdom has been restored.

1288 – The Mongols invade Dai Viet but General Tran Hung Dao repeats history by defeating the Mongol fleet on the Bach Dang River.

1471 – The Dai Viet inflict defeat on the kingdom of Champa, killing more than 60,000 Cham soldiers and 36,000 prisoners, including the king and most of the royal family.

1516 – Portuguese traders land in Da Nang, the start of European interest in Vietnam. They set up a trading post in Faifo (present-day Hoi An).

1524 – A period of instability and warfare between Trinh from the north and Nguyen from the south.

1600s – Last of Champa territory conquered by Dai Viet.

1802 — Emperor Gia Long takes the throne and the Nguyen Dynasty begins, ruling Vietnam until 1945. The country will be reunited for the first time in more than 200 years.

1847 – France launches the first major attack in the port of Da Nang.

1859 – France conquers Saigon and Laos and Cambodia, which together formed French Indochina.

1883 – France took control of Vietnam and turned it into a French colony.

1930 – Ho Chi Minh founds the Indochinese Communist Party (ICP).

1941 – ICP organizes a guerrilla army, the Viet Minh, in response to the invasion by Japan during World War II.

1945 – The Viet Minh seizes power. Ho Chi Minh announces Vietnam's independence.

1946 – French troops attack Viet Minh in Haiphong in November, igniting the war of resistance against colonial power.

1950 – Democratic Republic of Vietnam is recognized by China and the USSR.

1954 – Viet Minh forces attack an isolated French military outpost in the city of Dien Bien Phu. The attempt to take over the outpost will last two months, during which time the French government agrees to peace talks in Geneva. Vietnam is divided into North and South at the Geneva conference.

1956 – South Vietnamese President Ngo Dinh Diem launches campaign against political dissidents.

1957 – Beginning of the communist uprising in the south.

1959 – Weapons and men from North Vietnam begin to infiltrate the south.

1960 – US aid to Diem increased.

1963 – Viet Cong, the communist guerrillas operating in South Vietnam, defeat units of the ARVN, the South Vietnamese army. President Diem is overthrown and then assassinated in a US-backed military coup.

1964 – Gulf of Tonkin incident: US says North Vietnamese patrol boats are firing at two US naval vessels. The US Congress approves the Gulf of Tonkin resolution and authorizes military action in the region.

1965 – 200,000 US combat troops arrive in South Vietnam.

1966 – The number of troops in the US rises to 400,000 and then to 500,000 the following year.

1968 – Tet Offensive – a combined attack by the Viet Cong and North Vietnamese army on American positions – begins. More than 500 civilians die in the American massacre at My Lai. Thousands are killed by communist troops during their occupation of Hue city.

1969 – Ho Chi Minh dies. President Nixon begins to reduce US ground forces in Vietnam as opponents of the war grow.

1973 – A ceasefire agreement in Paris, US troops withdrew completely in March.

1975 – North Vietnamese forces invade South Vietnam and take control of the entire country after South Vietnamese President Duong Van Minh surrenders.

1976 – Socialist Republic of Vietnam proclaimed. Saigon will be renamed Ho Chi Minh City. Hundreds of thousands of flights abroad.

1979 – Vietnam invades Cambodia and expels Pol Pot's Khmer Rouge regime. In response, Chinese troops are crossing Vietnam's northern border. They are pushed back by Vietnamese troops.

1989 – Vietnamese troops withdraw from Cambodia.

1994 – US lifts its 30-year trade embargo.

FOOD & DISHES

POPULAR DISHES

Pho



Noodle Soup With Beef

Banh Mi



Baguette with vegetables and meat

Banh Xeo



Vietnamese Pancake

Bun cha



Fresh noodle with vegetables and meat

Cha Ca La Vong



Grilled fish, often includes shrimp paste or fish sauce, ginger, and chili peppers

Mi quang



Yellow colored rice noodles with grilled meat, vegetables, peanuts and rice paper

Com tam



Broken rice served with fried egg, onions and meat.

Bun dau mam tom



Noodles, tofu and chunks of meat served with spicy stinky purple dipping sauce

Bun bo nam bo



Noodles with slices of beef, lettuce, crunchy peanuts and without broth.

Goi cuon



Fresh spring roll with salad vegetables, a piece of meat or fish/shrimp and a layer of coriander.

Bun bo Hue



Noodles with meaty broth and piles of beef and pork.

Lau



Vietnamese hotpot dish, with a choice of vegetables, mushrooms, meat and fish.

Xoi



Sticky rice

Nem nuong Ninh Hoa



Fresh spring rolls of grilled meat, vegetables and rice paper that you roll up and dip in peanut sauce.

Banh cuon



Rice flour pancakes with a hearty filling of minced pork and mushrooms.

Bun Thit Nuong



Thin vermicelli rice noodles, chopped lettuce, cucumber, bean sprouts, basil, peanuts and mint

VEGETARIAN DISHES

There is an abundance of delicious vegetarian – or "chay" – meals in restaurants. Below is a small selection of vegetarian dishes in Vietnam.

Bánh mì chay



Baguette with salad and (optional) tofu, egg and mushrooms.

Phở chay



The vegetarian option for Pho; soup with vegetables and noodles.

Nộm đu đủ



Vietnamese salad.

Bún chả giò chay



Rice noodles with vegetarian spring rolls.

Bánh ít trần



Bean filled dumplings.

Bánh cuốn chay



Rice flour batter, with crispy onion, herbs, a spicy dipping sauce and tofu

Rau Muong Xao Toi



Spinach fried with garlic and other Vietnamese herbs

Đậu sốt cà chua



Tofu with garlic and tomato sauce

DICTIONARY

Hello
Xin chào
Xin-chao

How are you?
Bạn khỏe không
Ban-ko-khe-khong

Good thanks.
Cảm ơn, tôi khỏe
Kam-own, toi-khe

What is your name?
Tên bạn bạn là gì
Ten-ban-la-zee

My name is...
Tên tôi là...
Ten-toi-la...

Yes
Vâng
Vang

No
Không
Kong

Help!
Cứu!
Kiu

What?
Cái gì?
Kai-ge

How much?
Bao nhiêu?
Baow-nhiu

Which?
Cái nào?
Cai-now

I am lost
Tôi bị lạc
Toi-bi-lak

Bye
Tạm biệt
Tam-biet

Nice to meet you
Rất vui được gặp bạn
Rat-vui-duoc-gab-ban

Do you speak English?
Bạn có thể nói tiếng Anh không?
Ban-ko-noi-duok-tien-eng-kong

I'm from Holland
Tôi đến từ Hà Lan
Toi-den-tu Haa-Lan

Do you understand?
Bạn có hiểu không?
Ban-ko-hiew-kong

I do not understand
Tôi không hiểu
Toi-kong-hiew

I understand
Tôi hiểu
Toi-hiew

Thank you
Cảm ơn
Kam-own

I don't like it
Tôi không thích nó
Toi-kong-thik-no

I like it
tôi thích nó
Toi-thik-no

True?
Ở đâu?
Ow-dau

When?
Khi nào?
Khi-now

Breakfast
Ăn sáng
An-sang

Lunch
Ăn trưa
An-trua

Dinner
Ăn tối
An-toi

Meat
Thịt
Theed

Beef
Thịt bò
Theed-bo

Chicken
Thịt gà
Theed-ga

Eggs
Trứng
Trung

Duck
Thịt vịt
Theed-vid

Pork
Thịt lợn
Theed-lon

Lamb
Thịt cừu
Theed-kiu

Seafood
Hải sản
Hai-san

Can I have a menu in English?
Bạn có thực đơn bằng tiếng Anh không?
Ban-ko-thuk-dern-bang-tieng-Anh-kong

Fish
Cá
Ka

Shrimps
Tôm
Tom

Shellfish
Sò
So

Rice
Cơm
Kom

Chopsticks
Đũa
Dua

Fork
Nĩa
Nia

Knife
Dao
Daow

Spoon
Thìa
Thia

Glas
Cốc
Coke

I am full
Tôi no rồi
Toi-no-roi

Very tasty!
Rất ngon!
Rat-ngon

Can I have the menu?
Làm ơn cho tôi thực đơn?
Lam-own-cho-toi-thuk-dern

May I have the bill?
Làm ơn cho tôi hoá đơn?
Lam-own-cho-toi-hoa-dern

Restaurant
Nhà hàng
Nha-hang

This is delicious
Món này thật là ngon
Mon-nay-that-la-ngon

Coffee
Cà phê
Café

Tea
Trà
Traj

Water
Nước
Nuok

It's an emergency
Đây là một trường hợp khẩn cấp
day-la-mod-truong-hop-khan-cap

Where is the nearest police station?
Đồn cảnh sát gần nhất ở đâu?
Don-canh-sat-gan-nhat-ow-dau

Please help me
Làm ơn giúp tôi
Lam-on-giup-toi

Where is the hospital?
Bệnh viện ở đâu?
Benh-vien-ow-dau

I need a doctor
Tôi cần một bác sĩ
Toi-kan-mod-bac-si

I'm out of gas
Tôi bị hết xăng
Toi-bi-het-xang

I'm lost, please help
Tôi bị lac, làm ơn giúp
Toi-bi-lak, lam-own-giup

Where is...?
Ở đâu là...?
Ow-dau-la

How far is it?
Nó xa bao nhiêu?
No-xa-baow-nhiew

Go straight ahead
Đi thẳng
Di-thang

Left
Trái
Trai

Right
Phải
Phai

Bank
Ngân hàng
Ngan-hang

ATM
Máy rút tiền
May-rud-tien

Hotel
Khách sạn
Khach-san

Market
Chợ
Cho

Police station
Đồn cảnh sát
Don-canh-sat